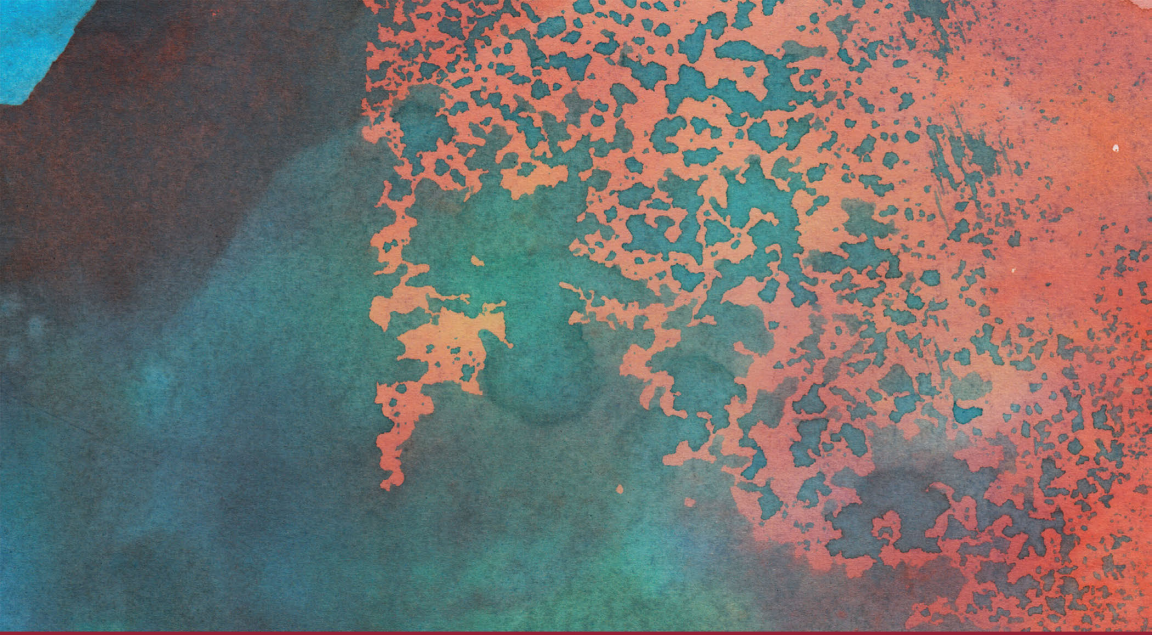
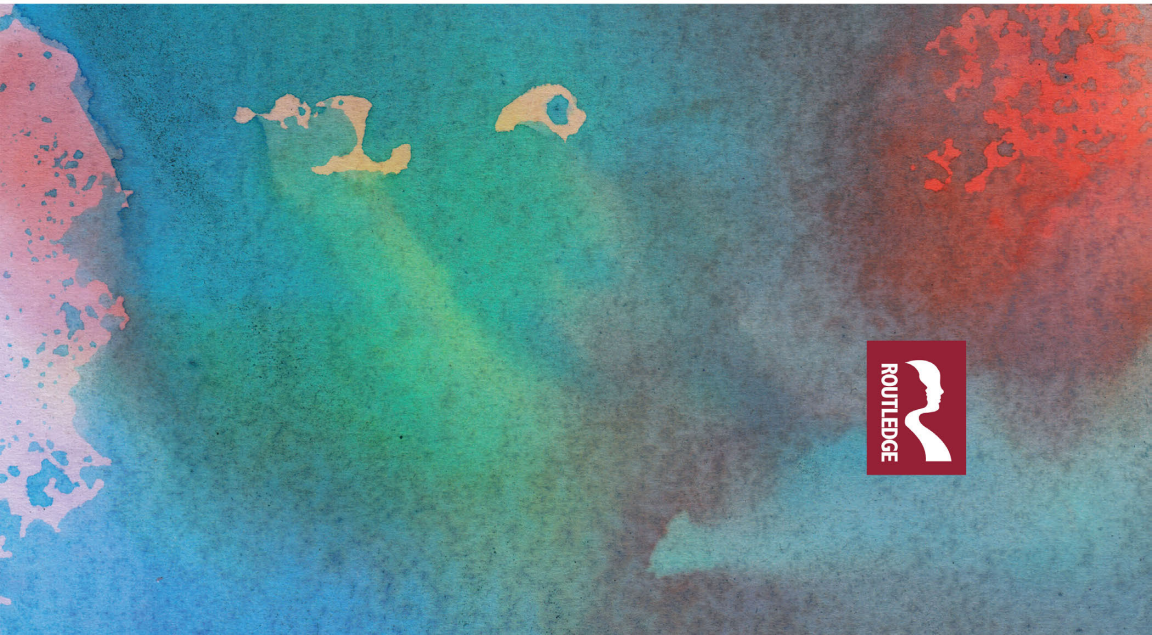


Feminism and Female Sexuality

QUEERING FEMININITY

SEXUALITY, FEMINISM, AND THE POLITICS OF PRESENTATION

Hannah McCann



Queering Femininity

Queering Femininity focuses on femininity as a style of gender presentation and asks how (and whether) it can be refigured as a creative and queer style of the body. Drawing on a range of feminist texts and interviews with self-identifying queer femmes from the LGBTQ community, Hannah McCann argues that the tendency to evaluate femininity as only either oppressive or empowering limits our understanding of its possibilities. She considers the dynamic aspects of feminine embodiment that cannot simply be understood in terms of gender normativity and negotiates a path between understanding both the attachments people hold to particular gender identities and styles, and recognising the punitive realities of dominant gender norms and expectations. Topics covered range from second wave feminist critiques of beauty culture to the importance of hair in queer femme presentation.

This book offers students and researchers of Gender, Queer, and Sexuality Studies a fresh new take on the often troubled relationship between feminism and femininity, a critical but generous reading that highlights the potential for an affirmative orientation that is not confined by the demands of identity politics.

Hannah McCann is a lecturer in gender studies at the University of Melbourne. Her research explores questions of gender presentation, sexuality, identity, beauty, and aesthetic labour. She has published in the *Australian Humanities Review*, *Australian Feminist Studies*, and *Women's Studies Quarterly*, and continues to write on topics including the history of feminism, postfeminism, affect theory, and queer femininity.



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

Queering Femininity

Sexuality, Feminism, and the Politics of Presentation

Hannah McCann

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group
LONDON AND NEW YORK

First published 2018
by Routledge
2 Park Square, Milton Park, Abingdon, Oxon OX14 4RN

and by Routledge
711 Third Avenue, New York, NY 10017

Routledge is an imprint of the Taylor & Francis Group, an informa business

© 2018 Hannah McCann

The right of Hannah McCann to be identified as author of this work has been asserted by her in accordance with sections 77 and 78 of the Copyright, Designs and Patents Act 1988.

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be reprinted or reproduced or utilised in any form or by any electronic, mechanical, or other means, now known or hereafter invented, including photocopying and recording, or in any information storage or retrieval system, without permission in writing from the publishers.

Trademark notice: Product or corporate names may be trademarks or registered trademarks, and are used only for identification and explanation without intent to infringe.

British Library Cataloguing-in-Publication Data
A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data
Names: McCann, Hannah, author.
Title: Queering femininity : sexuality, feminism and the politics of presentation / Hannah McCann.
Description: 1 Edition. | New York : Routledge, 2018. | Includes bibliographical references and index.
Identifiers: LCCN 2017035010 | ISBN 9781138894884 (hardback : alk. paper) | ISBN 9781315179742 (ebook)
Subjects: LCSH: Feminism. | Queer theory.
Classification: LCC HQ1150 .M42 2018 | DDC 305.42—dc23
LC record available at https://lccn.loc.gov/2017035010

ISBN: 978-1-138-89488-4 (hbk)
ISBN: 978-1-315-17974-2 (ebk)

Typeset in Times New Roman
by Apex CoVantage, LLC

To Geraldine



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

Contents

	Acknowledgements	ix
	Introduction: defining femininity	1
1	The binds of femininity	17
2	Feminism lost in the feminine body	39
3	Feminism without anti-femininity	63
4	The invisible femme	81
5	The feminist femme	103
6	Feeling femme	117
	Conclusion: what is queer about femininity?	139
	References	147
	Index	161



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

Acknowledgements

Thank you to the Gender Institute at the Australian National University for funding the development of this project, particularly Kim Rubenstein and Fiona Jenkins for their leadership during this period. Endless thanks to Helen Keane for guiding me through the many ups and downs of my PhD, from which this book is adapted. Thank you for being an outstanding academic mentor and source of inspiration, and for helping me to develop and maintain a love for writing, teaching, and research even in the most difficult of times. Thank you also to Rosanne Kennedy for the continued insights and intellectual support. To the many people who have made this project possible, thank you for providing personal encouragement over the many years of this work's progress, including Mon Bird, Rosanna Stevens, Shane Tas, Whitney Monaghan, Kiki Skountzos, Jessica Thompson, Eleri Mai Harris, David Pope, Carolyn Dunn, Daniel Pope, Ben Pope, Tim McCann, Su Wild-River, Jeanette Pope, Beverley Axford, Matthew Pope, Renee Wierzbicki, and Kathleen McCann. Thanks in particular my grandmother Ruth Fensom, for giving me so much to write about and encouraging resistance in every facet of life. To Catherine Ayres, Clare Southerton, and Briony Lipton I have the deepest gratitude, for supporting me at every turn and for giving me the strength to keep going. This book would definitely not have been possible without Geraldine Fela, whom I cannot thank enough for reading through drafts, providing helpful advice, arguments, endless patience, and sustenance. Last but certainly not least, my most sincere appreciation goes out to all of the queer femmes who participated in this research, and who were generous and open in sharing their stories and feelings with me. In you I find desire, pleasure, and astonishment; you are the spark for this research to exist.



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

Introduction

Defining femininity

There is a scene in the film *The Hunger Games: Mockingjay Part 1*, where the heroine's mentor Effie Trinket is learning to adapt to her new life in the revolutionary compound of District 13. Previously an inhabitant of the wealthy Capitol area, Trinket has been forced to leave behind her old excessive style in favour of a grey jumpsuit, a uniform worn throughout the District. Cleaned of makeup and without her frilly dresses, Trinket retains only a set of bangles which she still wears and often touches wistfully. Her fellow District 13 comrades find Trinket's attachment to these objects absurd, and she is met with derision. This response from her revolutionary companions calls to mind Germaine Greer's assertion that "the women who dare not go outside without their fake eyelashes are in serious psychic trouble" (1970, 325). That Trinket's affection for feminine accoutrements makes her the focus of ridicule illustrates an important conundrum. It begs the question: should we laugh and pity the Trinkets of the world "who dare not go outside" without their feminine accessories? Are Trinket's bracelets symbolic manacles? Or should we sit awhile, and wonder why these attachments might remain in the face of strong suggestions from others that liberation can be found in throwing such objects away? This leads to the central question: how can we consider femininity in a way that best attends to people's experiences of, and attachment to, feminine styles?

Looking to both popular and scholarly feminist commentary over history we see that feminine styles of the body are often not merely understood as the *effect* of an oppressive gender system, but rather are seen to *perpetuate* and *maintain* this system. So the dominant theory goes: if a woman fails to reject those bodily expectations of the gender regime, she is part of the problem. I do not wish to deny that there are norms and expectations that shape the way that we are expected to appear and present ourselves in the world. Indeed, at times this regime is a punishing one. Women are expected to put an enormous amount of energy and money into their appearance, in order to be understood as "respectable", "beautiful", and "sexy". The effort required to produce feminine aesthetics is increasingly being discussed in terms of labour (Baker 2016, 52). Furthermore, successfully achieving various looks for different contexts is no easy task. To wholeheartedly celebrate the various aspects of appearance which often constitute what is recognised as "feminine" – including makeup, clothing, hairstyling, and

so on – would be to deny the daily experiences of women who are *compelled* to conform to particular styles in both the private and the public sphere.

For these reasons, I do not wish to celebrate femininity as something that should be seen as necessarily empowering nor inherently "good". However, I do seek to intervene in the idea that political transformation can or should be affected at the level of appearance and identity. That is to say, I argue that femininity is *not* necessarily disempowering, nor inherently "bad". Those aspects of feminine styling that may for some people feel cruel or laboursome may at other times or for other people be a source of pleasure or, indeed, may be central to their sense of identity and belonging. This is a more dynamic understanding of gender presentation that appreciates the structural basis of the imperatives of gender but that does not dismiss feminine-appearing persons as merely cultural dupes labouring under false-consciousness who might instead be liberated through donning something else (for example, a jumpsuit). To simply map this variety of experiences onto a binary of disempowerment/empowerment misses the broader picture of oppression and the mechanisms employed by individuals to negotiate this terrain.

As gender theorist Raewyn Connell helpfully points out on the question of gender development in children, gender is not a production in which gender is simply written onto the body as if it is a blank slate, where each and every person comes out in a clear and coherent way along the binary masculine/feminine. Rather, children negotiate gender in diverse and dynamic ways, and thus the lifetime process of gender development is both anarchic and full of contradiction (Connell 2002, 81). Applying this idea to adulthood, we can understand gender as involving a degree of rebellion and resistance, where we are not determined by wider structures of gender in a simple way that sees "masculinity" and "femininity" coherently and evenly expressed. Even as we are encouraged to adhere to and describe ourselves in terms of discrete binary positions where ideals of gender persist (albeit shifting ones), gender in its expression is messy.

That gender expectations are contextual and change over history and location also reveals that it is not the specific elements of what we designate as "feminine" in appearance that are innately problematic, but rather what is arduous is being compelled to conform to expectations. While women of one era might define long dresses as oppressive, another might see miniskirts in the same way depending on the specifics of the disciplinary regime at the time. Another clear example of this is currently the colour pink, which is discussed in some detail in chapter two: pink is not inherently bad, but functions today as a symbol of girlhood. While many reject pink for the gender normativity it represents, at times the debate gets mired in making pink *the problem* rather than seeing the real issue as the system that merely encourages the use of pink as a signifier. We can also see this false location of the problem in debates around Muslim women's attire and the wearing of various iterations of "the veil". While various Western governments seem intent on banning these garments, using the argument that these objects are oppressive to women, there has been response from many Muslim women across the world to say that the veil cannot simply be understood in terms of gender oppression. Ironically, by prescribing that women *remove* their veils, a punitive system of

appearance is itself instituted. Some women may feel empowered through rejecting pink, or the veil, or any other object associated with a system of gender expectations, and this is understandable. Others, however, may feel oppressed if they are compelled to conform to an alternative regime.

So far the study of femininity has largely concerned itself with a "paranoid reading" of the kind described by Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick (1997), focusing on the punishing aspects of femininity that ought to be rejected. In contrast, I present a "reparative reading" (see also Sedgwick 1997), that seeks to recover the potential value of femininity for some, without recourse to the language of empowerment or neoliberal individual "choice". Most importantly, I contend that the harshly enforced system of sexual and gender oppression cannot simply be overturned by enacting different styles, which may so readily be absorbed and produced as new regulated modes of appearance. As Sara Ahmed suggests on the question of striving for a different possible world, "the point might be that we do not point our emotions toward the objects of our cause" (2010b, 198). In other words, rather than investing in the "object" of femininity as the key to liberation, we might imagine a world where we do not yet know what liberated or experimental styles of gender (or indeed "gender") might look like, but we might keep striving for a change under current conditions nonetheless.

What is femininity?

In this book I employ the term "femininity" in relation specifically to appearance, often as a "style of the body". As for example, Toni Calasanti and Kathleen Slevin have argued, "hegemonic femininity is primarily about appearance" (2001, 65). However, as others have highlighted, femininity as a concept is both indefinite and often engaged in contradictory ways (Skeggs 2004, 24). Skeggs argues that femininity is often used to refer to *more* than just appearance, with multiple gendered aspects conflated under the term. She writes, "The appearance of femininity, i.e., the labour of looking feminine, can also be distinguished from the labour of feminine characteristics, such as caring, supporting, passivity and nonassertiveness, although the two are merged in the term 'femininity'" (2001, 297). Others have suggested that we must speak of multiple *femininities* rather than femininity per se (Scharff 2013, 59). Like Jack Halberstam in his investigation of masculinity in *Female Masculinity*, I do not have a *definitive* answer to what femininity "is" (1998, 1).

It is important to acknowledge that historically femininity has also been discussed in a wide range of ways: in relation to roles, behaviours, desires, and subject positions. The different ways femininity has been defined have led to difficult questions of how we can identify which bodies can be considered feminine and whether femininity describes an expectation or a quality. For example, femininity has often been used synonymously with "woman", and early psychoanalytic approaches saw femininity as inevitably bound to womanhood (Freud 1965, 113). Indeed in mainstream Western culture today the "feminine" is often used interchangeably with what is considered "womanly". However, this connection

between "woman" and "feminine" also at times works to suggest that *all* women are feminine but in different ways, thus defining femininity as descriptive rather than normative. In other words, these accounts use "femininity" as a way to describe women, where "woman" is a term used to label adult bodies designated female. This perspective is most clearly illustrated by the Dove Campaign for Real Beauty launched in 2004, an advertising campaign for body products which emphasised that feminine beauty can be embodied by a wide variety of different women, challenging the notion that there is one type of perfect female body. Some theorists working explicitly on femininity have also taken up this position; for example, Samantha Holland, author of the book *Alternative Femininities*, argues that femininity "can mean as many things as there are women" (2004, 8). This is not the approach to femininity I wish to adopt; such perspectives problematically fix femininity in ways that preclude recognising, for example, butch masculine women (as Halberstam 1998 famously explored) or other diverse arrangements that untie gender identity from gender presentation. In other words, it must be recognised that not all women are feminine, even if they are expected to be.

Indeed, in the majority of scholarly work, femininity is most frequently used to describe the *normative* gender expectations imparted on bodies designated as female. For example, in her seminal text *The Female Eunuch* Greer argues that femininity is the result of women's socialisation, which ought to be rejected. She writes, "What we ought to see in the agonies of puberty is the result of the conditioning that maims the female personality in creating the feminine" (1970, 89). Today, many textbooks and encyclopaedia entries on gender also understand femininity in normative terms. For example, Christina Scharff argues that femininity can be considered a norm specifically associated with heterosexuality, middle-class status, White European appearance, an able "sexy" body, and a rejection of feminism (2013, 62). Similarly, other accounts argue that femininity refers to the expected traits and behaviours of women in society (Stets and Burke 2000, 997). Femininity has also at times been described as a discourse, which is socially enforced to prevent girls from deviating from their gender "script" (Hudson 1984; Smith 1988). Others have also suggested that defining femininity is work done specifically by cultural gatekeepers such as magazine editors, who are involved in promoting what women and girls *ought to* look like (Milkie 2002, 840). What all of these approaches have in common is that they understand femininity as a normative ideal which girls/women are expected to live up to and embody.

However simply recognising that femininity operates as a set of normative expectations does not do justice to the lived experience of femininity. Whether you are labelled as feminine by someone else, or personally strive to be recognised as feminine, we ought to call to mind the messiness of gender in its reality. Thus while femininity is bound up with expectations it cannot be reduced simply to an ideal, or a fantasy, because femininity is used as a descriptor and identifier even as the "ought" of femininity is never fully achieved. Perhaps this is why femininity is – as Holland suggests (2004, 35) – generally easy to identify but difficult to describe; we simultaneously speak of femininity as a set of

expectations impossible to meet and use it to describe particular bodies in the world – producing a false sense of adherence and coherence that is at once a fiction and perceived and reiterated as a reality.

Whatever femininity "is", however, as queer theorists such as Halberstam have fruitfully argued, masculinity and femininity are qualities that can be split from particular bodies coded as male or female (2012, 91). For example, in examining the phenomena of "female masculinity", Halberstam argues that "masculinity must not and cannot and should not reduce down to the male body and its effects" (1998, 1). While there have been discussions focused on female masculinity (Halberstam 1998) and male femininity (Schippers 2007), the idea of "female femininity" is rarely described because the connection between these terms is assumed. As Julia Serano writes: "While an individual woman may purposefully eschew femininity in her appearance and actions, she cannot escape the fact that other people will project feminine assumptions and expectations upon her simply because they associate femininity with femaleness" (2007, 341). Inspired by Halberstam, I attempt to fill the gap in investigating female femininity, but where femininity is understood as a non-inevitable normative descriptor that ought to be understood as more complex than a norm or a description.

The approach to femininity I adopt does not seek to ignore the multiple possible ways of discussing femininity but instead particularly considers how femininity as a "bodily property" has been thought of in feminist discourse and how this plays out for the people who inhabit these styles. This work may go some way to fleshing out the contention made by some that one can "of course" be a feminist and wear makeup and enjoy fashion, without reducing this simply to choice or awareness, or turning a blind eye to the punishing aspects of gendered life under capitalism. This work seeks to sit with this question of the surface presentation of femininity in a way that does not dismiss it as irrelevant, nor develop a position that insists on rejecting such styles.

Indeed, on the question of using femininity to refer to the *appearance* of the body (as opposed to roles and behaviours), Rosalind Gill observes that "there seems to have been a profound shift in the very definition of femininity such that it is defined as a bodily property rather than a social structural or psychological one" (2008, 42). According to Gill, femininity today is infrequently used in reference to roles such as "mother" or psychodynamic aspects such as "caring", instead often being portrayed as a quality, particularly related to sexiness (of which she is critical). However, I argue that explicitly exploring the idea of femininity as a style of the body, such that it can be separated from biologically "female" bodies, allows for a conceptualisation of it as an aesthetic that also goes beyond the surface of the skin. This approach takes into consideration not only how the body is shaped socially but also the way it is enacted and felt as a gendered mode. In other words: there are many benefits to understanding femininity in terms of gender appearance, yet this approach need not throw away the relevance of the social or psychological. As Sara Ahmed has argued – taking a phenomenological perspective on performativity of the kind offered by Butler (1990) – "norms surface *as* the surfaces of bodies" (Ahmed 2010b, 145; emphasis in original). However, as I

argue, "normative" surfaces might be read queerly, without presuming that such appearances reveal something about the state of feminism or a person's sexuality, or indeed, that political positions must involve specific surface enactments.

Liberation and representation

As the earlier discussion attests, reflections on "the woman question" are often overburdened by the idea that aspects of feminine appearance are in themselves central to the subjugation of women. Here, *effect* is misperceived as *cause*. Rather, we might generously read appearance as an effect that is productive of *affects* that might work in various directions, depending on the context at hand. For instance, to be attached to wearing dresses as a young girl may be an *effect* of the gender socialisation of the school context, itself a product of a much larger mechanism under capitalism working to define "men" and "women" in a regime of compulsory heterosexuality. As such, complicity to the norm in this scene ought not to be misconstrued *as* the mechanism. That the individual self is so readily seen as the site of liberation and place where oppression is perpetuated is, in this contemporary context, undeniably an effect of neoliberal ideology that reduces society to the self. This self is not the root cause of oppression but *can* be understood as productive of affects that work in complicated and messy ways. In this instance, the affects produced may include feelings of acceptance in the schoolyard, pleasure of identification as "girl", but also feelings of unease for the sexual attention and sexism that follows from being perceived as "feminine". Precisely because socialisation does not work on the body as if it is a blank slate, for a different young girl, the same process may result in very different affects – perhaps a defiant commitment to refusing femininity, a sense of rejection and gender vilification in the schoolyard, but also relief from the expectations of weakness and inferiority that come with being "girly". The resolution to the possible tribulations of these affective paths must be to challenge the wider mechanism, rather than seeing certain modes of appearance – for example, celebrating *or* rejecting dresses – as the antidote, as the key to empowerment. However, in terms of analysing the diverse affects bound up with femininity as part of ultimately confronting this mechanism, the "pleasure of identification as 'girl'" is perhaps a question infrequently attended to, and is an important gap I intend to address.

In this book I also challenge the persistent emphasis that the power to effect political change lies in questions of individual appearance and representation. Though femininity is theorised in this book as a mode of gender presentation intimately connected with the aesthetic, the productive power of representation to shape the world and to reveal what is going on "underneath" (what feminine presentation *means*) is questioned. If we see femininity as embodied and productive of a mess of *affects*, we see that these neither necessarily comply with nor coherently and clearly push back upon the forces that shape gender or that encourage us to present in certain ways. If there can be no ethical consumption under capitalism, then those industries (such as beauty and fashion) which profit from women buying products in order to live up to aesthetic expectations must be understood

and critiqued *separately* from individual women who engage with these industries and use these products themselves.

The purpose of this book is also to elaborate a new way of approaching femininity that differs from traditional feminist recourse to questions of patriarchy and objectification. This is not to say that these dimensions can easily be dismissed; rather, I propose we take a break from lines of questioning that place these concepts as central, to see what else might emerge. Rather than seeing individual feminine embodiments as a sign of oppression, instead we can ask: *What can the body as feminine do?* and *What might utopian femininity look like?* In other words, the premise that feminine appearance is always a function of oppression is placed on hold. Though, as the case may be, this line of questioning also opens up the likelihood that what the body as feminine can do may present both possibilities and obstacles.

However, the main function of these questions is that they displace the impetus to invest in gender presentation and representation as a mode of effecting political resistance. They ask us to investigate femininity rather than assume a predictable connection with oppression, while at once imagining radical possibilities for femininity into the future. Here we might unpack the dimensions of feminine gender presentation otherwise missed if the body is always already enrolled in a politics of representation. While feminist discourse often describes feminine presentation as a decidedly anti-utopian vision of gender, attending to femininity without recourse to the binary of empowerment/disempowerment means not necessarily knowing in advance what liberated gender will *look* like. As Debra Ferreday argues, what is needed in accounts of gender is "awareness of the complex and multiple forms of pleasure and desire that characterise women's attachment to feminine identities" (2008, 21). I seek to consider femininity long enough for some of these attachments to become visible. In other words, I give time to the suggestion that feminine styles and accoutrements deserve attention outside of evaluations of their presumed representational significance.

Queering femininity through affect

While I seek to give attention and time to femininity, I aim to do more than simply describe a phenomenon. As the title suggests, the aim of this work is "queering" femininity. While "queer" is often used as an identity term to denote "not-straight" (and often used in this book in this way), *queering* is a process rather than an identity. As Steven Seidman describes, queering can be understood as a method which "make[s] strange or 'queer' what is considered known, familiar, and commonplace, what is assumed to be the order of things, the natural way, the normal, the healthy, and so on" (1997, xi). Seidman describes queering as both deconstructive and intimately related to sexuality. However, the form of queering employed goes beyond the purely deconstructive and involves more than the sexual subject. As Heather Love has highlighted, queer theory now embraces arenas beyond claims to "same-sex" desire and includes, among other things, attention to affect (2011, 182). Indeed, I take up the turn toward considering the affective

dimensions of social life. As such, this work undertakes a queering of femininity not through traditional modes of deconstruction, but rather through attending to affective aspects of femininity that help us to "make strange" the natural order of gender, through focus on intensities and becomings, the sensate, and the relational. This can be seen as part of the loose strand of queer affect theory identified by Gregory Seigworth and Melissa Gregg which:

> [A]ttends to the hard and fast materialities, as well as the fleeting and flowing ephemera, of the daily and the workaday, of everyday and every-night life, and of "experience" (understood in ways far more collective and "external" rather than individual and interior), where persistent, repetitious practices of power can simultaneously provide a body (or, better, collectivized bodies) with predicaments and potentials for realizing a world that subsists within and exceeds the horizons and boundaries of the norm.
>
> (2010, 7)

As Love also tracks, one of the central aims of queer theory continues to be "to bring together a range of social outsiders united against the 'regimes of the normal' " (Love 2011, 183). While I seek to employ queer thinking in the sense of "making strange" and affective approaches in the way of considering "hard and fast materialities", here I also wish to trouble queer theory's traditional claims to the anti-normative *as* queer. In this way my work follows alongside recent discussions around "queer theory without antinormativity" (Wiegman and Wilson 2015, 2).

However this approach also draws on a more established strand of queer theory, following from Sedgwick's strategy of smuggling in queerness in where it may not otherwise be seen. As Sedgwick describes,

> I think that for many of us in childhood the ability to attach intently to a few cultural objects, objects of high or popular culture or both, objects whose meaning seemed mysterious, excessive, or oblique in relation to the codes most readily available to us, became a prime resource for survival.
>
> (1993, 3)

Indeed, survival is key: the concern here is not to undertake a paranoid approach to femininity, but rather one that gives time to those modes of being that allow us to survive, or that limit our capacities, or both. A view to understanding how survival is a driving force allows for recognition of both individual agency in negotiating conditions, and those structures which act upon us, to be taken into account. However, most importantly this view does not direct us to invest in personal modes as the political key to liberation, which would otherwise suggest that the "non-normative" holds the keys to challenging the "norm" (Wiegman 2006).

Rather than starting from the point of that which is considered obviously non-normative, I trouble dominant conceptions of normative femininity in the first

instance. Here, the term "normative femininity" rather than "hegemonic femininity" is used, to echo the discursive shift toward considering norms in literature on gender particularly since the 1990s. However using queer theory and an affective lens provides intervention in a history of feminist discourse that has marked feminine styles of the body out in terms of norms that both signify *and* produce female subordination. Where I turn to discussion of queer femme identity, which involves subjects who suffer for being perceived as "normative" and not-queer, I also examine the anti-normative tendencies that permeate this identity discourse and that undermine the potential of seeing femininity queerly. Turning to the affective dimensions in the case of both feminine bodily styles marked as problematic under feminism, and queer femme embodiments, allows for an unpacking of femininity in a way that blurs identity lines and generously attends to attachments that may be perceived as in line with the "normative". In other words, opening up queer modes of engagement – of reparative reading – to affect allows for new ways of *doing* queer theory.

Feminine attachments

My personal experience is essential here to understanding the development of this book. The journey of this work began during 2009, when part of my studies involved considering how Judith Butler had addressed the gaps evident in Simone de Beauvoir's gender existentialism. I became stuck on de Beauvoir's chapter from *The Second Sex*, "The Lesbian", which describes the expected masculine features of lesbian sexuality. Here de Beauvoir notes, "We commonly think of the lesbian as a woman wearing a plain felt hat, short hair, and a necktie; her mannish appearance would seem to indicate some abnormality of the hormones" (1953, 424). In my own life, I had felt the effects of this expectation; often ignored in LGBTQ spaces, I found it difficult to communicate my sexual identity as a queer woman. I didn't appear to meet the aesthetic requirements of being a lesbian; I looked "straight" but didn't feel that I was. I didn't have the language to express what this made me.

My own attachment to femininity had long been unshakable, despite being raised in a single parent (plus single grandmother) household, where my desire for feminine styling was frowned upon. While my mother never explicitly identified as a feminist, she raised me as a girl with the understanding that I should be empowered. However my grandmother exposed me to both radical and cultural feminist ideas, annotating my children's books to encourage awareness of the problematic ways women are depicted. For example, under a picture of a wicked witch in a colouring book she wrote "STEREOTYPE". I also recall a birthday card involving Barbie, with a message inside explaining exactly why she wouldn't give me one. I understand now that my childhood context – unequivocally feminist and critical of femininity rather than encouraging of it – is *not* the norm. However, as my formal schooling began, so too did a process of feminine socialisation, where I became more attached to being easily recognised as a girl. I felt deeply uncomfortable being seen as masculine or read as "boy", as I often was. I doubt

that this feeling was something clearly innate but rather was painfully social, and yet my attachment to femininity remains to this day. At the time, I began to reject the feminist readings offered by my grandmother, claiming that they were outdated and unhelpful, and I refused to wear anything but dresses. But my femininity became overdone: I wore giant bows in my hair and layers of plastic jewellery to pass as appropriately feminine, not knowing that there was a fine line between "just right" and "too much".

My fixation on the feminine became particularly problematic when I began to identify as queer in my late teens, and I found it very difficult to have my sexuality recognised. I did not feel accepted as legitimately or authentically queer. In my academic life, I persistently returned to the question of the lesbian. In 2012 I discovered the queer femme movement, which aims to promote the visibility of feminine queer sexualities. I had previously heard of the identifier "lipstick lesbian", often used as a derogatory term, as well as "butch/femme" pairings before, but not the idea that femme could be a standalone concept which could be celebrated. Finally, I felt there was a space that marked out queer femininity as legitimate and real. Simultaneously, I had been reading popular feminist texts such as Ariel Levy's *Female Chauvinist Pigs*, and had found them uncomfortably reductive on the question of sexualised feminine styles, taken to symbolise a new and unhealthy "raunch" culture (2005). I felt as though these books were calling me back to childhood, where my femininity was seen to clash with my family's feminist ideology. I wondered if the queer femme movement was a remedy for this perspective on femininity.

However, as I moved through the world of queer femme texts, conferences, and interviews with femme participants, I felt a growing problem with the emphasis on the *power* of femininity and femme identity imagined in this realm. The politics of this territory became increasingly apparent: femme was seen as an identity that ruptured not only queer expectations but straight ones too. To be femme was to become enrolled in a political project of seeing identification and gender presentation as inherently powerful. Similarly, to be feminist, according to texts such as Levy's, was to be part of an identity politics that sees some forms of gender presentation as harmful. I was in favour of fighting for recognition of identity, but I wasn't clear as to why this meant I had to attach certain powers to my individual appearance. I felt as though my femininity *did do* something – it brought me joy, anxiety, fun, difficulty, pleasure – but the politics I encountered in both femme and feminist accounts did not necessarily capture all that femininity was for me. Feminist works such as Levy's stressed feminine styles as purely disempowering, but femme accounts agreed on straight femininity as disempowering and only queer femme femininity as empowering. I wondered why femininity always needed to be understood along this binary, and why both feminists and femmes agreed that the best way to overcome gender oppression was at the level of individual gender presentation.

I decided to try and negotiate a third way, while attempting to maintain my dedication to femme identity. On this basis, I do not argue against particular attachments to identity categories, but rather suggest interventions into the identity

politics that flow from these sites. This is not a total break from politics, obviously, but a shift in focus that sees politics as constituted altogether differently. Identity needs to be recognised as an important and valuable site because to fail to have one's identity recognised can be painful (Bornstein 1994, 50) and indeed can lead to violent ends (Butler 2004, 18). However, what *constitutes* identity can perhaps be thought of differently, without singular recourse to representational modes of recognition. The idea of considering femininity anew is to unpack what occurs on a bodily and sensate level, before aligning feminine styles of the body with particular political meanings. I do not wish to argue against understanding oneself as femme, for example, but do challenge the emphasis on the power of such identifications as they are regularly discussed. As such, I take a break from both dominant feminist and femme approaches to feminine styles of the body. In order to achieve this, I provide critique of feminist and femme discourse, but give time to feminist and femme voices and reflections on feminine styles of the body. I shift focus from the power of representation to the surprising capacities and feelings engendered by feminine embodiment.

Feminine futures

In this book I leave aside arguing for plurality and difference as an antidote to gender norms, as doing so simply leads us down a path of ever-complexifying identities vying for recognition. Gender presentation in itself should not be the locus of political goals related to gender inequality. This is not to say that gender embodiments exist in a cultural, historical, or political vacuum, nor that gender can be divorced from politics. The dominant capitalist ideology in society has an effect on our bodies insofar as we are born into pre-existing society, and into a set of gendered expectations of the "normal", which we must adhere to for social recognition. As Butler argues, though our styled bodies contribute to what is perceived as normal, our bodies are in interaction with social forces acting upon the body and are not fully self-styled (1990, 201). However, I explore the idea that the things gender presentation "does" are not necessarily directly or controllably linked to the forces of culture, history, and politics; thus such forces cannot easily be shaped or acted back upon with the individual body alone. In other words, politics is not so clearly, or at least not so *wilfully*, done with our singular bodies (or personalities or identities), despite there being a relationship between politics and bodies and gender. While Butler argues for small sites of resistance to shift the "normal" via subversive repetition, I ask what happens when we question our assumptions about the normal altogether and discontinue seeing our individual embodiment as a site of resistance. In turn, I want to step away from arguments that only conceive of femininity and other gender embodiments as *either* empowering (having power or resisting oppressive power) *or* disempowering (contributing to powerlessness).

The first half of this book considers the relationship between femininity and politics in depth, looking at the historical feminist debates on feminine gender presentation within feminism, as well as more recent feminist perspectives. These

chapters question whether femininity is always anti-feminist, critically examining a number of recent feminist texts, some of which are highly critical of feminine styles, and others which offer alternative perspectives. Chapter one looks in detail at feminism's historical engagement with femininity. Chapter two involves a thematic analysis of key texts, looking at how some feminist accounts position ideas of feminism "lost" directly alongside references to the female body, where exposed bodies only reflect oppression, and "girl on girl" sexual displays in public are mere performance. Here we see that feminine styles act as signifiers of postfeminism, rhetorically locating the "problem" of feminism lost, in the flesh of women's bodies. Chapter three considers how some feminist accounts navigate a path between attachments to feminine styles while maintaining a critical feminist perspective. Emphasis here is on the capacities and pleasures of femininity while retaining a feminist critique, and importantly the way that political action should *not* centre on the presentation of the individual body but, rather, should involve targeting broader social structures. Indeed, the point here is to examine how we might imagine feminism without anti-femininity.

The second half of this book interrogates the question of whether femininity can ever be queer. Chapters four through six draw from interviews conducted with queer femmes in Australia, as well as texts on queer femme identity from across the world. These chapters consider the dominant ideas circulating in queer femme culture that at once celebrate the queer potential of feminine styles, yet paradoxically concur with many feminist accounts that mark so-called straight femininity as problematic. An alternative way of understanding femme, which may be extended to femininity more broadly, is considered. Chapter four starts by looking at the issue of invisibility experienced by many queer femmes, who are not recognised as queer within either LGBTQ or heterosexual spaces. This chapter discusses how this issue plays out for queer femmes, and how this contributes to an emphasis on representational strategies and identity politics. Chapter five looks at the approaches used to differentiate femme femininity from heterosexual femininity, and the way that feminist critiques of femininity support this logic. Here we see that many femmes reflect feeling marginalised by feminists because of their feminine presentation, yet cite feminism as essential to identifying as femme. The final chapter makes a case for looking at femme differently, in a way that breaks down the emphasis on the queer versus the heterosexual, and that transcends representation and the logic of empowerment versus disempowerment.

It is hoped that this work offers a thorough interrogation of the problematic ways that femininity is currently imagined and critiqued, and gestures to understanding shared experiences of embodiment through considering the sensate, material, and bodily aspects of feminine gender presentation. I aim to present a glimmer of a feminine future where the pleasures, fascinations, and complexities of femininity are taken seriously but not necessarily enrolled in a politics that sees identity as the founding moment of social transformation.

Notably, however, one limitation of my focus in this book is that it is particularly Western-centric. The feminist texts discussed and analysed predominantly originate from the United States, Australia, and the United Kingdom. The femme

texts also come from similar areas, and the femme interview participants are all Australian residents. A possible critique of may be that this work overlooks other cultural approaches to femininity outside of a Western context. While a comparative cultural analysis would be interesting, it is not the task I wish to undertake. Rather, I extend from my own location within Western feminism and queer femininity and speak from this position. As Linda Martin Alcoff notes, dangers arise in speaking on behalf of others:

> We are collectively caught in an intricate, delicate web in which each action I take, discursive or otherwise, pulls on, breaks off, or maintains the tension in many strands of a web in which others find themselves moving also.
>
> (Alcoff 1992, 21)

As Alcoff also suggests, the solution to the problem of speaking is *not* either to speak only on behalf of the self or to stop speaking at all. Rather, the answer is to engage in dialogue with others to promote open discursiveness. While I do not engage in cross-cultural interchange here, I do the work of putting theorists and theories in dialogue within a Western context. As such, this book extends beyond my own experiences and is limited by its Western focus, but nevertheless offers a dynamic conversation about femininity within this space.

Intelligible femininity

In concrete terms, with this exploration I aim to create new possibilities for reflection that may eventually make feminine lives more liveable. This sentiment echoes Butler, who explains:

> One might wonder what use "opening up possibilities" finally is, but no one who has understood what it is to live in the social world as what is "impossible", illegible, unrealisable, unreal, and illegitimate is likely to pose that question.
>
> (1990, viii)

In exploring the limits of feminist and femme approaches to femininity, the aim is also to further interest in femininity theoretically and in practical terms. In revealing the possibilities of femininity as more than simply oppressed, powerless, weak, and deeply normative, I hope to hint at a way forward where advocating liberation does not necessarily centre on a particular style of the body.

Despite a desire for positive outcomes for those occupying feminine embodiments, this book is heavy with theoretical reflections and interventions. The hope here is that theoretical offerings and the community they reflect upon ought not to be kept separate. For example, I presented some of the work on queer femininity at the Femme Hive Conference in Berlin in 2014, a conference organised by the femme community there. I found myself in a strange position, speaking to a group of femme-identifying people *about* femme, and offering a challenge to the way

it is normally imagined and discussed. At this talk I stressed the importance of bridging between theory and community and prompting dialogue between these arenas. My main point was that theory isn't separate from life; it is a way of seeing that can help to understand things differently. I suggested that theory can be transformative, and indeed femmes attending the conference agreed with this idea. This is my hope for this book and the work that follows from it: that the theoretical interventions into the question of femininity can assist in real-world transformations.

One final note is that as I have conducted this research I have been haunted by Angela McRobbie's association of femininity with sickness. She writes, "Seeking to achieve a feminine identity makes women and girls ill. Being, as Butler would have it, 'culturally intelligible' as a girl makes one ill" (2009, 97). McRobbie's argument is that the standards expected of femininity in society encourage girls to undertake certain measures to regulate their bodies, which leads to problems such as anorexia. Reflecting on McRobbie's sentiment, I have often wondered whether my attachment to femininity is an unhealthy bond. However, my sense is that femininity as a style of the body has more to offer than sickness, even as normative expectations around gender may indeed make us sick. As Jasbir Puar has also convincingly argued, though capitalism demands productive wellness, debility has its own kind of profitability (Puar 2011, 153). Like McRobbie, Puar too calls attention to the slow death that might be experienced by girls due to expectations of femininity (2011, 157). I think the problem here lies in the fact that although McRobbie raises the important issue of eating disorders, she locates the problem in the symptom, rather than turning attention to the cause: sexism under capitalism. Following such a perspective to its logical conclusion might encourage us to think that power can be best found in rejecting this object (femininity), akin to a consumer boycott within a capitalist economy. Undoubtedly when one company or product is boycotted, another pops up to fill its place. Similarly, to take leave of particular styles and norms of appearance does not address what underlies the issue in the first place: that there is a regulative system in place that defines how we ought to live our gendered lives. When one style is rejected, a subcultural one fills its place with another set of norms and expectations. In contrast, if we focus on the systemic cause broadened out from femininity, rather than the symptom which McRobbie collapses *into* femininity, we must see that slow death is not unique to femininity. Thus we might rephrase McRobbie: it is not *femininity* that makes girls ill, but rather, it the conditions under late capitalism that drive *all of us* to sickness. Importantly, the messiness of gender means that femininity might not always be experienced as a negative, and may indeed provide a way of navigating and surviving an otherwise treacherous terrain.

I hope that giving time to consider femininity – unpacking what it means, how it has been discussed over time, and how we might approach it in new ways – might interrupt assumptions about feminine presentation and the idea that one can draw discrete and clear meanings from these gendered embodiments. As Serano remarks: "The greatest barrier preventing us from fully challenging sexism is the pervasive antifeminine sentiment that runs wild in both the straight and queer

communities, targeting people of all genders and sexualities" (2007, 343). I agree with Serano's claim that critiquing "antifeminine sentiment" might assist in better addressing sexism because it can show us where we are wasting our energies and how these might be better spent. In making a case for femininity broadly, I hope to show that where feminism rejects the feminist possibilities of femininity, it cuts off connecting with certain bodies. Similarly, where femme discourse distances itself from heterosexual femininity it misses an opportunity for advocating for a different approach to femininity within a broader collective. As such, by drawing out various dynamics of feminine styles of the body, it is hoped that this book might contribute to the liveability of femininity. I aim to bring a revaluing of certain bodily styles which are often too readily dismissed, denigrated, or altogether erased within a society that only values the feminine in narrow and punitive ways.



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

1 The binds of femininity

Within feminist discourse, femininity has oft been imagined as a *problem* for women. Women are seen as beholden to expectations of femininity and, at times, physically bound by various items associated with femininity (corsets, girdles, and so forth). In other words, femininity is seen as a bind. In contrast, masculinity has been understood as an *interesting* gender phenomenon, not necessarily always theorised in relation to oppression or negative effects. As textbooks and encyclopaedias specifically dedicated to masculinity studies attest, masculinity has been considered in relation to such diverse topics as "Boy Scouts of America", "cowboys", "Hollywood", "leisure", "heroism", and more (Carroll 2004). Though men are also bound to expectations of masculinity, masculinity has not always been assumed as a bind. How can we understand this history of the binds understood as specific to femininity?

Undoubtedly the understanding of femininity as a bind lies in feminist critiques which have been incredibly productive for pointing out that gender expectations stem from inequality between men and women. While there is not "one" feminist approach to femininity, I aim to historically map some dominant approaches within feminism in the decades spanning from the 1960s through the 1990s. However the aim here is to illustrate how femininity could shift from being seen as a social *effect* to an individual *cause*, leaving little room to consider the queer potential, value, or intrigue of femininity in a way that might equal discussions taken up in masculinity studies. This historical investigation is also useful to show how stories we tell about feminism past (following Hemmings 2005) have influenced feminist discussions in the first decade of the twenty-first century, when the concept of "postfeminism" started to gain substantive critical currency. As such, I introduce postfeminism here, and the political assumptions underlying the use of this term, by placing it within a much longer history of feminist approaches to femininity. This contextual framing is intended to help illuminate how many contemporary feminist accounts continue to position ideas of postfeminism, or feminism "lost", directly alongside references to the female body. As discussed in the next chapter, many feminist accounts that engender a sense of loss focus on the *breast*, rhetorically locating the "problem" of lost feminism in the flesh of women's bodies. However first I examine the theoretical steps that led to this collapse of loss *into* feminine embodiment,

and outline how such a metonym could – perhaps surprisingly – develop from the concept of "the personal is political".

As an examination of the history of feminist engagement with femininity demonstrates, rendering the personal as political has led to a collapse of the political *into* the personal, where self-presentation is understood as a key site for effecting change. The damage here – as I unpack in the remaining chapters – is that gender presentation is imbued with a significance only ever determined as either empowered *or* disempowered. This is a severely limited binary that renounces both the social basis of gendered embodiment and the significance of personal attachments developed in relation to gender. Many contemporary feminist texts treat feminine styles of the body as ultimate signifiers of an era of postfeminism where the gains of feminism past are enjoyed but also forsaken.

We need not limit our analysis to the binary of empowerment/disempowerment or only to concerns of objectification. The aim is not to suggest how people *ought* to negotiate gender. Rather, the intention is to reflect on major ways that femininity has been critically engaged with, to show how the feminine body has frequently and inadvertently been *re*-inscribed with meanings of loss, danger, deception, stupidity, and other negative connotations. Ultimately, the point of this is to show the pressing need to ask different kinds of questions about femininity than the dominant ones that have been on offer to date.

A note on masculinity studies

Before turning to examine the history of feminist approaches to femininity, it is helpful to consider the ways that the field of masculinity studies considers masculinity, to highlight how different kinds of questions about masculinity versus femininity are currently being asked and why. Even a brief look through key gender studies textbooks and guides reveals that femininity is a concept rarely addressed in the same way as masculinity. While gender or women's studies texts often focus on girls, women, men, and masculinities, the term "femininity" is generally excluded (Scharff and Gill 2011, 2). For example, *Fifty Key Concepts in Gender Studies* (Pilcher and Whelehan 2017) includes sections on "Masculinity/Masculinities" in addition to "Men's Movements/Men's Studies" and "Women's Studies". Femininity/femininities is, however, absent. This demonstrates the way that a complementary "femininity studies" has been slow to emerge alongside masculinity studies, and how consideration of femininity has historically been located under "women's studies". Limited attention has been given to this lacuna. As Scharff and Gill discuss:

> There has been, to our knowledge, no investigation of "hegemonic femininity", yet a wealth of writing about "hegemonic masculinity". What new questions, we wondered, might the notion of femininities allow us to ask? What new insights or possibilities might it open up?
>
> (2011, 2)

Furthermore, accounts of femininity generally render it as *necessarily* subordinate. Indeed, while Scharff and Gill propose a new investigation of femininity, they continue to locate it in terms of neoliberalism and postfeminism (2011, 1), and femininity remains problematic, rather than offering queer possibilities. In comparison to this, masculinity studies approaches do not always centre on theories that see masculinity *only* as the subordinating correlate to the subordinate feminine position.

Understanding the different academic origins of masculinity studies and women's studies helps to shed light on why these two fields have engaged with questions of gender in different ways. During the second wave of the feminist movement, women's studies first emerged within North American universities (Boxer 2002). The aim was to address the gap in considering women's lives in disciplines such as history, literature, and politics (Wiegman 2002). As Marilyn Boxer writes, "the generation of women who founded women's studies acted out of intellectual and emotional needs too powerful to repress" (2002, 42). Thus women's studies arose within intellectual research and teaching enterprise directly related to the theories, demands, and practices of the feminist movement of the time. In turn, the history of women's studies has largely been a history of analysing the oppression of women (McCann 2016, 226). Necessarily investigations of femininity have most frequently fallen along an axis of considering its disempowering/empowering effects in relation to women's oppression.

In contrast, masculinity studies in the academy has its origin in the "men's movement", which emerged as a way of addressing a perceived gap in the consideration of men in theorisations of gender (Hearn 2013, 151). This can be considered a rather different gap to fill compared to the gender discrepancy in the academy writ large that women's studies sought to amend. However, while men's studies nominally began in the mid-1970s, mainly in the United States, it was during the 1980s and 1990s that men's studies faced major critique for lacking feminist or other critical clarity (Flood et al. 2007, viii). Responding to this criticism, men's studies made way for masculinity studies. As Jeff Hearn notes, "Masculinities theory developed from the late 1970s at the same time as feminist auto-critiques of the concept of patriarchy" (2013, 150). The 1990s saw a rise in masculinity studies as reflected in the launch of the first journals, the publication of the first readers and encyclopaedias, a growing number of texts, and a huge increase in the number of works published on the topic (Flood et al. 2007, viii–ix). During this time, theorists like Halberstam also extended the investigation of masculinity across gender, to include female masculinity (1998). This history illustrates that masculinity studies developed within a very different milieu than women's studies, alongside reflexive critiques of feminist theory and emerging queer theory and postmodernist accounts.

This is not to say masculinity studies dismisses conceptions of patriarchy and power altogether – rather, the opposite has occurred historically. However, insofar as masculinity has been studied in relation to patriarchy, many accounts consider the *benefits* of inhabiting masculinity. As Nigel Edley and Margaret Wetherell argue,

there is a "considerable amount of power enjoyed by men who fulfil their culture's ideal of masculinity" (1995, 144). As Connell also writes: "'Masculinity', to the extent the term can be briefly defined at all, is simultaneously a place in gender relations, the practices through which men and women engage that place in gender, and the effects of these practices in bodily experience, personality and culture" (1995, 71). Connell proposes that we consider a three-part model for understanding gender, with a focus on power relations, the relationship between gender and modes of production, and relations of desire (1995, 73–74). Though, according to Connell, few men in reality meet the hegemonic ideal, she writes: "The public face of hegemonic masculinity is not necessarily what powerful men are, but what sustains their power and what large numbers of men are motivated to support" (1987, 185). Under this famously taken up theory, femininity is *always* subordinate to masculinity, and the product of patriarchal domination is the ideal of "emphasised femininity" (Connell 1987, 183). Connell argues that society's prevailing hegemonic masculinity positions women as the Other, but states that there is no corresponding form of dominant femininity that can be described, since any expression of femininity is always within a context of oppression relative to masculinity (1987, 183).

Femininity is figured in terms of the extent to which women are complicit in a masculine regime, with greater conformity equalling more exaggerated forms of femininity (Connell and Messerschmidt 2005: 848). Accordingly, alternative femininity is suppressed by both masculine forms and emphasised femininity: "Central to the maintenance of emphasised femininity is practice that prevents other models of femininity gaining cultural articulation" (Connell 1987, 188). Connell suggests that this dominant masculine paradigm obscures a history of alternative female identities such as "spinsters, lesbians, unionists, prostitutes, madwomen, rebels and maiden aunts, manual workers, midwives and witches" (1987, 188). Here, Connell's suggested model presumes a patriarchal structure as fundamental, which necessarily defines femininity as always subordinate even as there may be forms of femininity that do not conform to social expectations.

However, where Connell theorises that "[a]ll forms of femininity in this society are constructed in the context of the overall subordination of women to men" (1987, 186–187), the ability to give time to considering femininity in depth is precluded. Hence, rather than see femininity only as a problematic subordinate position, we might investigate ways that femininity is lived and how it might be imagined radically into the future. As Serano argues, "[T]he idea that femininity is subordinate to masculinity dismisses women as a whole and shapes virtually all popular myths and stereotypes about trans women" (2007, 5–6). Although various analyses have critiqued and adapted concepts of patriarchy theory since Connell's work on gender, as the following discussion elaborates, femininity continues to be cast not only as a negative effect, but indeed a cause of women's subordination.

Coding femininity as oppression

Certain stories of feminism past that are continually returned to entrench the idea of femininity as an effect of gender oppression that also perpetuates this

oppression. While the stories I explore here centre particularly on White North-American contexts as key to the genealogy of second wave feminism, the task here is not to offer rival origin stories which for example might start with a history of class struggle or the fight for civil rights, rather than "feminism" per se. Indeed, as Robin Morgan proposes in the introduction to the anthology *Sisterhood Is Powerful* published in 1970, the women's movement in the United States largely had foundations in student, civil rights, and anti-war activism (xxi–xxiv). As Clare Hemmings also warns, there is a particularly monolithic story often recounted in the telling of Western feminist history, that suggests a move from a radical past that was centred on discreet categories, to a post-modern future less encumbered by fixed identity (2005, 115). I take heed of Hemmings' point, that feminism has always involved complex and competing strands. However the aim here is to interrogate how dominant feminist narratives have been integral to a persistent orientation within feminism that has coded femininity *as* oppression. I repeat these stories in order to question their ramifications, and their limitations.

As alluded to in the introduction, during the period of so-called second wave feminism, the term "femininity" was not necessarily used to refer to gender presentation, but rather often described in terms of traits, values, and behaviours (Hollows 2000, 1). However, in many texts from the time that are still drawn upon today, femininity has also often been referred to as a normative style of the female body inseparable from the dictates of beauty and fashion. For example, we see this conflation between femininity as both role and presentation in Betty Friedan's *The Feminine Mystique*, which is frequently cited as a key text for the movement:

> Over and over women heard in voices of tradition and of Freudian sophistication that they could desire no greater destiny than to glory in their own femininity. Experts told them how to catch a man and keep him, how to breastfeed children . . . how to dress, look, and act more feminine and make marriage more exciting.
>
> (Friedan 1963, 15)

For Friedan, the "feminine mystique" was "the problem that has no name", the feeling of secondary status and dependence on men that women felt as wives and mothers. Yet as we see in her discussion, this secondary status was intimately tied with norms around appearance: "how to dress, look". Friedan also argued that femininity stopped women from flourishing, "keeping most women in the state of sexual larvae, preventing them from achieving the maturity of which they are capable" (1963, 77). According to this perspective, conforming to perceived norms of femininity signified complicity with a repressive system. In other words, looking to Friedan we see that feminine styles were seen as a way to uphold oppression and not merely reflect it, with appearance therefore central to the project of liberation.

Even in early texts about the rights of women prior to the advent of second wave feminism in the 1960s, we see references to fashion and beauty not as *effects*

but as key *contributors* to female inequality in society, where preoccupation with beauty and fashion is seen as a dangerous activity. As Mary Wollstonecraft writes in *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman*, men spend little effort on dressing, while women become mentally debilitated through the activity of dedicating time to fashion. She suggests: "It is not indeed the making of necessaries that weakens the mind; but the frippery of dress" (2003, 153). Similarly, de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* – a key influential text for the emergence of the second wave – suggests that women are imprisoned by their dedication to fashion:

> The goal of the fashion to which [woman] is in thrall is not to reveal her as an autonomous individual but, on the contrary, to cut her from her transcendence so as to offer her as a prey to male desires: fashion does not serve to fulfil her projects but on the contrary to thwart them.
>
> (1953, 572)

As Caroline Evans and Minna Thornton explain, the study of fashion (and by extension, beauty) is specifically taken as essential for feminist analysis because it is seen to signify cultural constructions of the representation of femininity: "If we see women's fashion as a field of representations of the female body it then becomes a significant text of how culture constructs femininity and how it addresses that representation to women" (1991, 49). In other words, though one might argue that femininity is also related to roles, behaviours, desires, and relations, the extensive feminist critique of fashion and beauty also suggests the inseparability of femininity from appearance and surface. While earlier women's liberationists focused on the limitations imposed by the impracticality and distraction of fashion, many second wave feminists shunned "constructed" femininity in favour of "naturalness" signified through cropped hair, flat shoes, dungarees, and un-made faces (Negrin 2008, 33).

A key example of this is the infamous protest at the Miss America pageant in 1968, which is often depicted as a (if not *the*) crucial moment in the beginning of second wave feminist activism (Siegel 2007, 49; Pilcher and Whelehan 2017, 133). At the pageant feminist protestors paraded sheep and held signs condemning the Miss America pageant and contestants. Inside, they unfurled a protest banner, and outside they threw magazines, bras, makeup, and other feminine accoutrements into a "freedom trashcan", sparking the media myth of the feminist "bra-burner". This action is reflected upon as revealing the feminist movement's sentiments about liberating women from feminine accoutrements, reversing gender dress norms, and focusing on the "natural" body (Barnard 1996, 133–137; Negrin 2008, 37). The centrality of the Miss America protest in the story of the second wave demonstrates key ways in which the relation between feminism and femininity has been imagined. First, it suggests that a key target of feminist protest has been – and, where a "return" to the second wave is called for, ought to be – norms around feminine presentation. Second, it suggests that when targeting the aesthetic culture of femininity, individual women (such as the contestants themselves) should be made focus, even if there

is a call for women to join the protest movement. On this latter point, what is striking about this example is that the "freedom trashcan" was never set alight, as a fire permit was unable to be obtained. As Deborah Siegel outlines: "Organizers were careful to follow the Atlantic City police's request not to endanger the wooden boardwalk by lighting anything on fire" (2007, 49). In remembering the story of the Miss America pageant protest, this aspect is generally pointed out as evidence of how the media sensationalised the event after the fact, and made the protestors out to be a radical crowd of bra-burners (Paoletti 2015, 53; Beins 2015, 173). However, what this scene also reveals – and what has *not* become part of the canon in remembering the significance of this event – is that while protestors were happy to target the women partaking in the pageant as propping up an oppressive gender regime, they were less willing to look outward to challenge the state's role in maintaining order. As the *No More Miss America!* flier for the event read: "we do not plan heavy disruptive tactics and so do not expect a bad police scene" (Morgan 1970b, 521). Indeed only once is the source of the oppressive ideals of femininity gestured to in the flier, simply as "The Man" (Morgan 1970b, 523). In looking to this example, stripping away the broader context of women's liberation (where certainly some women *were* burning things), we are left with a story where "the problem" is reduced to feminine styles, rather than wider social structures. As I discuss in the following chapter, this kind of reduction is most apparent in calls for a return to an imagined feminism past: feminist accounts which focus their concern on bras (and breasts) and femininity *as* oppression, rather than arguing for a form of more substantive social revolution.

Along these lines, that one of the slogans of the second wave feminist era, "the personal is political", continues to be historically salient reveals why gender presentation is often seen as a key site for feminist resistance. In its original usage, the idea of the personal as political sought to break down the distinction between the private and public spheres, as women's issues were often cast as "merely" personal. This perspective, emerging from radical feminist groups, was intended to highlight how structures of gender oppression dictate the personal (Hekman 2014, 50–51). As Siegel writes, " 'The Personal Is Political' meant that – suddenly! – sex, family life, house-hold chores, and, indeed, everyday interactions between men and women were not simply private matters of individual choice but involved the exercise of institutional power" (2007, 32). Yet the evolution of this slogan has meant the collapse of the political into the personal, such that personal experiences are not seen as an effect of wider politics, but rather a way to enact the political. It is telling for example that other slogans of the time such as "wages for housework" or "there is no liberation of women without revolution" have not been returned to with such vigour. With a growing sense of disenchantment in democracy and the ability of the institutions of "politics" to deliver change, there has been increasing desire to find this power at a personal level. In this way – as discussed throughout this book and particularly in the chapters on femme femininity – personal choices around dress and gender presentation have come to be seen as deeply political.

The "problem" of femininity

Along these lines of "the personal is [*the*] political", in the 1980s and early 1990s more feminist texts began to appear that explicitly explored the connection between bodily aesthetics and gender oppression. These texts draw on feminism of the previous two decades, particularly focusing on moments such as the Miss America pageant as a way to highlight the pressing need for feminism to focus on questions of femininity in terms of the body and surface aesthetics.

Susan Brownmiller's *Femininity* for example focused on hair, clothes, and skin, among other things, as key sites for investigating the phenomena of femininity (1984, 9). Brownmiller writes: "To care about feminine fashion, and do it well, is to be obsessively involved in inconsequential details on a serious basis" (1984, 81). Brownmiller begins by invoking the figure of Venus as symbolic of a tyrannical ideal of femininity that women must live up to. Like many others, Brownmiller calls upon the 1968 Miss America protest as key: "the new wave of feminism that began fifteen years ago in the United States coincidentally chose to attack a symbol of Venus in its first dramatic act" (Brownmiller 1984, 24). Here Brownmiller at once cites the 1968 pageant as the seed of the women's movement, and in doing so locates the issue of beauty and femininity as key to the feminist project. Ultimately Brownmiller returns to the point that rejecting femininity, including fashion and beauty, might allow women to be "a little closer to being themselves" (1984, 237). Here, femininity is understood as both body and surface, but crucially, as a problem to overcome.

Likewise, Naomi Wolf's (1990) *The Beauty Myth: How Images of Beauty Are Used against Women* became a key popular feminist text at the time. Wolf calls upon feminist history situated particularly around Friedan and *The Feminine Mystique*, calling for a shift from focus on domestic labour (from which Wolf argues we have largely been freed) to a focus on beauty. Wolf seeks to explore how "something important is indeed at stake that has to do with the relationship between female liberation and female beauty" (1990, 9). Interestingly, Wolf speaks of ideal femininity as just one version of femininity promoted and "flattened" in culture (1990, 59), rather than rejecting the idea of femininity altogether. However, it becomes clear in Wolf's work that her imagining of non-problematic femininity involves the claim that a "raw" and "natural" state is possible for women, which is distorted by culture (1990, 269). This explicitly infers the notion that femininity is a masquerade (which I turn to shortly), and suggests the possibility of a pre-social natural womanhood. Importantly, Wolf also genders the beauty myth, as she writes, "Can *we* bring about another future, in which it is she who is dead and we who are beautifully alive?" (1990, 270; emphasis in original). "She" here refers to the surgically altered woman-machine that Wolf has described in the previous chapter. Yet this move also serves to rhetorically locate the problem in *a* "she", who must be metaphorically killed. As we shall see in the following chapter, the trend toward collapsing women *into* the problem of femininity as oppression persists today.

Similarly, Sandra Bartky's 1990 *Femininity and Domination: Studies in the Phenomenology of Oppression* works from an interpretation of Michel Foucault

and goes further in explicitly outlining the ways in which the feminine body is subjugated. Though it only appears as a footnote, Bartky too cites the Miss America pageant as the "original women's liberation demonstration" (1990, 126), revealing that this memory of history informs her approach. Though Bartky draws on Marxist notions of alienation, she at once forsakes the structural for the personal. Her theory suggests that individual women perpetuate regimes of their own oppression, specifically describing "feminine narcissism" as "*infatuation with an inferiorised body*" (1990, 40; emphasis in original). Foreshadowing arguments that would be made in texts such as Levy's *Female Chauvinist Pigs* in the following decade, Bartky argues:

> A woman can become a sex object for herself, taking toward her own person the attitude of a man. She will then take erotic satisfaction in her physical self, revelling in her body as a beautiful object to be gazed at and decorated. Such an attitude is commonly called "narcissism".
>
> (1990, 36–37)

In this theorisation, and following Foucault's notion of docile bodies (1979, 135), the male gaze is not necessary for oppression to occur – all that is required is the gaze of the woman toward herself. Similarly Susan Bordo, drawing upon both Friedan and Brownmiller, describes femininity as something both imposed upon women and "obsessively" pursued by women themselves. In *The Body and the Reproduction of Femininity* (1997, 92), she writes:

> Through the pursuit of an ever-changing, homogenising, elusive ideal of femininity – a pursuit without a terminus, requiring that women constantly attend to minute and often whimsical changes in fashion – female bodies become docile bodies – bodies whose forces and energies are habituated to external regulation, subjection, transformation, "improvement".
>
> (1997, 91)

This pursuit of the feminine is linked by Bordo, at its most extreme, to death (1997, 91), resonant with the sentiments to be made by McRobbie over ten years later, connecting femininity to illness (2009, 97). For Bordo, femininity is related to weakness, affliction, and pain. These selected feminist writings on femininity from the 1980s and 1990s show a concentration on beauty as a key place to enact the idea of the "personal is [the] political". However, while these critiques gesture at the limiting effects of a broader oppressive system on the female body, they also inadvertently locate the problem in the personal – the individual experience of embodying femininity.

Femininity as masquerade

More specifically, many feminist analyses of beauty have understood femininity as a "masquerade", where enacting the political involves pointing out and

removing this mask. In particular there have been many attempts within feminist thought to differentiate womanhood (seen as natural) from the feminine (seen as constructed and normative), where a false external presentation is assumed to mask a true self underneath. The basis of the masquerade approach can be traced back to psychoanalytic theories, in particular Joan Riviere's paper "Womanliness as a Masquerade" (1929). Riviere argues that femininity is a mask taken up as a way to respond to the anxiety of the castration complex as described by Freud. As Stephen Heath comments on this theory, "Adornment *is* the woman, she exists veiled; only thus can she represent lack, be what is wanted" (1986, 52). While many feminists have critiqued and extended psychoanalytic frameworks particularly around the idea of "lack" (Pilcher and Whelehan 2017, 123), the association between femininity and masquerade appears to have stuck wherein femininity is now referred to as a norm contrasted with "genuine" womanliness.

To this point, many feminist accounts specifically position norms of fashion and beauty as controlling and oppressive forces. For example, Greer draws a connection between the charade of femininity and the alienation of women from their own sexuality, as she writes, "I'm sick of being a transvestite. I refuse to be a female impersonator. I am a woman, not a castrate" (1970, 62). Greer's position reveals a transphobic attitude to womanhood, which presumes a fundamental essential womanhood that can be separated from surface appearance. Sheila Jeffreys in *Beauty and Misogyny* also focuses on feminine presentation as a key part of the oppression of women in Western society, and refers to femininity as a "mask" (2005, 65). Jeffreys argues that beauty is not – as some women purportedly claim – about expression or creativity, but is a major facet of the oppression of women (2005, 2). Jeffreys likens practices such as wearing lipstick and undergoing cosmetic surgery to torture (2005, 28). She also equates women wearing makeup in the West to garments worn by some Muslim women; she writes, "Makeup, like the veil, ensures that they are masked and not having the effrontery to show themselves as the real and equal citizens that they should be in theory. Makeup and the veil may both reveal women's lack of entitlement" (2005, 38). Though Greer and Jeffreys are both writing within the vein of radical feminism and their views are certainly not representative of feminism as a whole, their thoughts sit easily alongside broader discussions that suggest femininity is a masquerade. Indeed, we see in many feminist accounts that fashion and beauty are seen as markers of alienation and oppression (Negrin 2008, 33), involving a false-consciousness that causes estrangement from the self (Bartky 1990, 40). As Bartky argues, "femininity is an artifice, an achievement", and "woman's body is an ornamented surface" (1997, 132, 136). Even Connell suggests that femininity involves a putting-on, remarking on "sex-typed adornment" and arguing that the clothing used to signify femininity such as "frills, tucks, bows, lace, ribbons and such like" is often functionless and obsessively employed (1987, 79–80). In all of these accounts, seeing femininity as a masquerade inadvertently helps to support the idea that the overall liberation of women must involve emancipating one's "authentic" self under the mask of femininity.

Some theorists have already responded to these critical views on femininity, suggesting that *even if* femininity is a masquerade it can be adopted wilfully – though this remains consistent with the idea of the personal as "the" political. For example, Holland argues that many women both intentionally adopt feminine signifiers and actively resist them. She differentiates between the "doing girl" who puts on the masquerade of femininity knowingly, as a parody, and the "resisting girl" who altogether derides stereotypically feminine things (Holland 2004, 45). Holland also notes that both identities may occur simultaneously. This recovery of the feminine masquerade through mindfulness is also suggested by Heath, who cites Marlene Dietrich as an example of someone who knowingly "puts on" femininity. He writes, "Dietrich wears all the accoutrements of femininity *as* accoutrements" (Heath 1986, 57; emphasis in original). However, the kinds of accounts offered by Holland and Heath still contend that femininity is a façade, implicitly suggesting that to embody femininity *without* mindfulness would constitute oppression. This claim warrants further investigation, as they continue to locate the solution to regulative gender regimes within individual actions – in this case mindfulness rather than an unmasking.

Perspectives that adopt the masquerade as a key feature risk the suggestion that there is a pre-social or essential self, which exists outside of processes of cultural influence (Ferreday 2007, 6). In contrast to these accounts, Ruth Holliday and Jacqueline Sanchez Taylor argue that ideology in the West has actually promoted the notion that "false" beauty is bad because it is sinful while "natural" beauty is good because it has traditionally signified obedience and passivity (2006). This has led to a culture where the "masked" woman is seen in negative terms:

> Women who paint their faces usually do so for seduction – using sexuality to confuse men, usually with some ulterior motive in mind. Women using make-up are thus bad women, as opposed to unpainted good women. So naturally beautiful women are good, falsely beautiful made-up women are bad – bad because they have a sexuality.
>
> (2006, 182)

Holliday and Taylor highlight the flaw in many accounts that suggest eschewing "false" or "enhanced" femininity might grant women agency in a world where this is the norm. To argue that femininity is a masquerade obscures the fact that *all* manifestations of gender are socially formed, and problematically suggests that there is an underlying "true" self behind the mask. As Jonathan Dean also notes, the idea that feminine presentation is a sign of oppression inadvertently erases political possibilities, insofar as women who are seen to conform to femininity are often dismissed as not "truly" feminist (2012, 321).

Perhaps most problematic, deriding fashion, beauty, and feminine modes of presentation often involves inadvertently denigrating women *themselves* (Negrin 2008, 42), even where there are very careful attempts to avoid this. For example, Maddy Coy and Maria Garner explore agency in glamour modelling through

examining the celebrity figure Jordan (also known as Katie Price), noting, "It is not Katie Price the woman that we critique or pathologise; our aim is to question the marketed brand of femininity that 'Jordan' represents" (2010, 659). They specifically use the term "feminine" to describe Jordan, and note that she is a source of inspiration for many women in the United Kingdom. They argue that Jordan exemplifies how "femininity becomes a brand packaged to young girls and marketed through the celebrity/reality genre" (Coy and Garner 2010, 664). They seek to critique insidious neoliberal norms of Jordan-like femininity as false choices, and argue for "thoughtful listening to women's accounts while questioning contexts" (Coy and Garner 2010, 659). Yet, despite their intentions, their approach fundamentally dismisses the lived experiences of women who wish to emulate Jordan because this desire is seen as the result of false-consciousness. The agency of these Jordanesque women is described as merely an illusion and they are marked as passive to larger machinations selling them false empowerment. If feminism ignores young women's admiration of people like Jordan they will likely be turned off feminism, as Holliday and Taylor note:

> It is therefore vitally important to recognize that contemporary women who routinely adopt the markers of hypersexualization associated with classed and racialized bodies (such as buttock implants or collagen lips) are not passive but active and desiring (not just desirable).
>
> (2006, 191)

While Coy's and Garner's approach may have many merits in critiquing the empowerment model espoused by women who enjoy Jordan, as Holliday and Taylor suggest, women still need to be seen as active in these accounts (2006, 192). We may need to take a break the assumption that femininity must be enrolled as a political form of embodiment that is only either empowering or disempowering, and pay some attention to the experiences and attachments involved in feminine gender presentation in the first instance.

From the "third wave" to postfeminism

Alongside the accounts sketched so far, during the 1980s and 1990s arguments around femininity as empowering (rather than oppressive) also began to appear (Orr 1997; Gillis and Munford 2004; Snyder 2008; Renegar and Sowards 2009; Snyder-Hall 2010; Harris and Dobson 2015). One of the effects of seeing the personal as *the* political has been to try and embrace rather than reject feminine styles. These accounts have largely been defined as constituting "third wave" feminism, where celebration of the feminine is often cited as one of the defining features of this wave (Press 2011). However, it also seems that the *critique* of third wave approaches that has arisen may have too readily pre-empted the problems of this position, preventing the development of more substantive investigations into femininity.

Though third wave approaches often embrace rather than reject femininity, similarly to Brownmiller, Wolf, Bartky, and Bordo, third wave writing invests

in the *power* of individual appearance and embodiment to effect broader political transformation. For example, cultural practices such as burlesque and roller derby are frequently taken to represent third wave norms of empowered femininity (Ferreday 2008; Finley 2010). Ferreday argues that burlesque highlights the complexity of femininity, the practices of which might yield pleasure and thus might be taken seriously rather than being dismissed as signifying oppression (2008, 49). Ferreday writes:

> The new burlesque is haunted by feminism, but the burlesque community is troubled by a sense that any cultural practice that makes visible an attachment to feminine identity is always already irreconcilable with feminism.
>
> (2008, 51)

Similarly, on the topic of roller derby, Nancy J. Finley states: "When derby girls are 'kicking ass,' they are kicking a prescribed femininity" (2010, 378). Together, Ferreday's and Finley's approaches illustrate how some forms of feminism call for a reimagining of femininity as potentially empowering.

However, many have claimed that third wave feminism is in fact apolitical, and misguided in its attempt to reclaim femininity. For example, Dole argues that third wave feminism has a focus on "girlie" aesthetics, is less politically active than earlier feminisms, and is predominantly spread through popular culture (2008, 59). Third wave feminism has also been critiqued for its emphasis on "choice" used to justify a more feminised and sexualised version of feminism (Snyder-Hall 2010). In many accounts third wave approaches are often connected with the loosely termed "girl power" movement, and very similarly to the later concept of "postfeminism" girl power has been described as:

> An international trend . . . in favour of an attitude that women can handle all kinds of constructions of themselves, even the most apparently negative, since such images nevertheless grant women a kind of power.
>
> (Cranny-Francis et al. 2003, 121)

Others have argued that girl power wrongfully dismisses the "trials and tribulations" of feminine presentation, in favour of narrowly considering feminine aesthetics as pleasurable (Russell and Tyler 2002, 620). Interestingly, accounts actually exploring the pleasures and potential of feminine aesthetics have been few and far between.

There is also a large body of feminist writing on the objectifying and commercial aspects of the girl power trend (Banet-Weiser and Portwood-Stacer 2006; Lazar 2006; Gill 2008; Power 2009; McRobbie 2009; Whitehead and Kurz 2009; Coy and Garner 2010). More than anything, the idea of girl power has, since the 2000s, been widely critiqued in feminist writing as a tool of capitalist subversion of feminist aims (Gill 2008, 36). Elizabeth Freeman for example argues that the term "girl power" has been used as a powerful commercial slogan: "[T]he phrase ['Girl Power'] has become a way to sell clothes, records, TV shows, online

games, dolls and pink and purple plastic things to young females" (2010, 84–85). The third wave focus on the power of femininity is seen by critics as related to an emergent neoliberal ideology of choice (Jeffreys 2005, 1). As Sarah Banet-Weiser and Laura Portwood-Stacer write:

> This consumer post-feminism is often individualized and constructed as personal choice or individual equality, and thus is figured quite differently from a historical feminist emphasis on social change and liberation.
>
> (2006, 257)

In other words, the third wave attempt to think about femininity differently has been largely characterised as related to a postfeminist consumer culture wherein women have literally bought into their systematic objectification.

Subsequently, and in light of debates around third wave sentiments, the term "postfeminism" has arisen. This term is used by many feminist scholars to describe the milieu of a younger generation who have benefitted from the victories of earlier feminism, yet see feminism as a movement of the past (Tasker and Negra 2006; Vint 2007; Banet-Weiser and Portwood-Stacer 2006). As McRobbie elaborates, postfeminism is "a process by which feminist gains of the 1970s and 1980s are actively and relentlessly undermined" (2009, 11). Notably, postfeminism is also often used interchangeably with references to third wave feminism (Scharff and Gill 2011, 3; Nash and Grant 2015), the result of which is a wholehearted rejection of the third wave's approach to femininity. Furthermore, many discussions of postfeminism connect feminine presentation with a lack of "true" feminist political sentiment. For example Michelle Lazar describes the modern "empowered" postfeminist as "able-bodied and heterosexual(ised) (or at least not overtly signified as otherwise)" (2006, 515). Here Lazar interprets problematic postfeminist politics as having a certain mode of gender presentation, namely, normative heterosexual femininity, similarly to Emma Renold and Jessica Ringrose, who argue that the postfeminist zeitgeist "demands hyper-sexualised femininity" (2008, 315). It is argued that this "postfeminist" culture of mainstream sexiness offers a false promise of empowerment for women; indeed there is "empowerment fatigue" – a promise that can deliver little for women in real terms (Gill 2012, 742).

Many critiques of the postfeminist landscape also focus on specific elements of popular culture – predominantly those representing and marketed at women – as evidence of the problems of the new postfeminist femininity. There has been, for example, much focus on television shows like *Sex and the City* (Gill 2003; Vint 2007; Mendes 2012; Gill 2008; White 2012; Littler 2013) and films *like Bridget Jones' Diar*y (McRobbie 2009; Evans, Riley, and Shankar 2010) as evidencing a postfeminist climate. This has involved discussion of how romantic comedies portray "retrosexism" and a kind of nostalgia for sexism pre-dating second wave feminism (Tasker and Negra 2006, 174), as well as seeing makeover reality TV shows as a sign that "feminism itself has undergone a 'makeover'" (Banet-Weiser and Portwood-Stacer 2006, 257). Indeed there has been prolific discussion about

makeover television shows as representing an insidious postfeminist ideology (Gill 2008; Coy and Garner 2010; Marwick 2010). The disproportionate focus on popular culture texts enjoyed by women as part of the argument against the third wave inadvertently contributes to a sense of women themselves – the willing audience – as *the* problem. As Andreas Huyssen discusses, mass culture is often coded as feminine, with many historical struggles being represented as feminine in conservative press, and critical theorists such as Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer offering metaphors of the feminine to describe an insidious mass culture as "the evil queen of the fairy tale" (1986, 192). As Huyssen explains, "The universalising ascription of femininity to mass culture always depended on the very real exclusion of women from high culture and its institutions" (1986, 205–206). From this perspective we can see why such a strong connection between postfeminism and popular culture *and* the feminine is made in various feminist analyses – not because popular texts objectively illustrate postfeminism but because mass culture is coded as feminine and thus is a seemingly obvious place to evidence a critique of postfeminist (as feminine) ideas.

The important point to take away from this is also the emphasis on the representational in critiques of postfeminist femininity, and the way that a particular "look" has come to be understood as problematic. This critique flows directly from a history of feminism relating to femininity in a way that centres on femininity as disempowering following from the idea that personal is *the* political. While third wave feminists have often argued that femininity can be recovered if it is a style consciously adopted, critics of the third wave have argued against the validity of such "choices". Yet this critique often implies the notion that one might still exert choice, just not in the direction of "corrupt" feminine styles. For example, Renold and Ringrose argue that resistance necessarily means the "conscious struggle against norms" (2008, 316). However, as Christina Scharff argues, the extent to which femininity is shaped by culture is sometimes overlooked in the Western world, with secularism being connected to a false rhetoric of choice (2013). This is by comparison to the perception of the non-Western world as more heavily governed by cultural norms of femininity, as she writes: "Muslim femininities, for example, are regarded as being determined by culture, while secular femininities are constructed as autonomous, precisely because of their alleged ability to step in and out of culture" (2013, 61). Scharff's argument here is to assert that the "secular femininities" of the West are not wholly liberated from the effects of culture. Taking into account Scharff's point here means questioning both the ability to "choose" *and* "choose differently" proposed by third wave feminists and their critics alike.

The complicating factors of class and excess

I want to turn here to a consideration of femininity and class because, as the work of Beverley Skeggs reveals, class offers one way to examine femininity without dismissing it merely as mark of gender oppression. Skeggs' work has predominantly focused on White working-class women's modes of presentation. In her

ethnography of working-class women in the United Kingdom, Skeggs found that participants demonstrated a high level of ambivalence toward femininity, positioning themselves as both close to and far from it (1997, 115). Skeggs notes that different forms of femininity were adopted by participants depending on various situations. Femininity was enacted as a way to gain "respectability", but due to their understanding that working-class bodies are coded as "sexual, vulgar, tarty, pathological and without value" they also maintained a distance and awareness of their "difference" (1997, 115). Skeggs also notes the pleasure expressed by participants in taking up feminine styles, but their reluctance to identify as feminine due to their sense of classed difference (1997, 116).

Indeed femininity is frequently treated as a problem that crosses class lines. This is particularly evident in the way "raunch culture" is used to refer to an entire societal take-up of norms of hypersexuality (Levy 2005). Such accounts gloss over the ways femininity is classed, and indeed how femininity is readily seen as excessive or grotesque if performed by women viewed as lower class. This is an important point because it raises the question of whether the "whore" of the virgin/whore dichotomy is *ever* socially acceptable. As Jeffrey Brown argues, using celebrity Anna Nicole Smith as a case study: "[W]here the classical body is the dominant normative model representing middle- and upper-class beliefs and values, the grotesque body is emblematic of all things socially unacceptable and hence lower class"; he later notes that: "Interestingly enough, although Smith first became famous for her nude photographs in *Playboy*, it is only after she is identified as a white trash grotesque that her sexuality is seen as exaggerated" (2005, 81, 84). Brown's observations suggest that lower-class femininity is not only coded as unacceptable femininity, but also as involving exaggerated and excessive sexuality. Extending upon this, we can observe that what we see in many feminist accounts is a critique of a form of excessive sexuality associated with working-class women, based in part on the assumption that this form of femininity has become a societal norm. What tends to be ignored or minimised is the ways these embodiments are coded as unacceptable and attached to devalued subject positions.

What is revealed in accounts that critique working-class femininity – even as they might acknowledge the classed dimensions of acceptable femininity – is a tension between seeing working-class hypersexualised femininity as a dangerous norm in society (the embodiment of which can have powerful negative effects), and seeing it as the effect of larger forces (the embodiment of which renders one powerless). Indeed, as Skeggs notes in her research on attitudes toward working-class women: "The women are read as both sad and dominating. It is these contradictions that contain the contemporary evaluations and readings of femininity. Femininity is paradoxical, it occupies a space of symbolic legitimation via corporeal capital but then is also delegitimated as an investment" (Skeggs 2001, 302). Like Skeggs' observations about women's responses to working-class femininity, the femininity that is the subject of critique in feminist accounts is not only predominantly connected with working-class women but is also seen as holding power and as being something that ought to be critiqued; femininity is seen as both an effect and a cause of oppression.

Further to this, arguments as to precisely what constitutes normative femininity often focus on feminine *excess* as the key problematic. For example, in the work of Levy and McRobbie which I turn to in the next chapter, we see a focus on hypersexual performances of femininity as encapsulated by Levy's "female chauvinist pig" (2005, 89), McRobbie's "phallic girl" (2009, 83), or indeed the "ladette" as discussed in many other texts (Muncer et al. 2001; Jackson 2006a; Jackson 2006b; Jackson and Tinkler 2007; Renold and Ringrose 2008; Redden and Brown 2010; Smith 2011). As Jo Littler explains, the term "ladette" entered popular usage in the United Kingdom during the 1990s and refers to women who act like "lads", that is, like young men who drink, are boisterous, and so on (2013, 240). As Ferreday suggests, when feminists deny the dynamic potential of displays of femininity, it is "as if . . . feminism itself were a system for curbing feminine excess" (2007, 9). The problem here is that the focus is on extreme and *obvious* embodiments of femininity, while a more insidious norm of "genuine" acceptable womanliness is inferred but not addressed.

In particular, we see a feminist focus on popular texts that represent feminine excess critiquing precisely the *excess* represented. In many analyses, characters such as Elle Woods in the film *Legally Blonde* (Luketic 2001) are seen as archetypes of "ironic postfeminism" (Tally 2008, 112), emblematic of apolitical and narcissistic femininity in a new era (Radner 2011; Karyln 2011). However the messages around what constitutes *acceptable* femininity in films such as this are often missed. Carol Dole points out that the film *Legally Blonde* warns viewers that embodying femininity might actually be to their detriment. She argues that one of the central messages of the film is that "(demure) beauty is good but not at the expense of intelligence; overt sexiness is dangerous to the self and others", and, further: "to assure maximum success, these films imply, women should moderate their feminine display" (2008, 69, 70). While Dole focuses on *Legally Blonde* predominantly in terms of its connection to third wave feminist sentiments, what we can draw from her observations is the film's commentary on various norms of femininity. Far from being merely a celebration of feminine styles in the wake of second wave feminism, the film offers reflection on the difficulties of feminine excess.

The film *Calamity Jane* (Butler 1953) offers another illustration of the difficulties of successfully adopting what is seen as excessive femininity. The film follows Calamity Jane (played by Doris Day), a wild woman of the West, who wears leather and rides horses, and whose *lack* of femininity is frequently commented upon and made a joke of in the town of Deadwood. When a singer from Chicago, Katie Brown, comes to town, she moves in with Calamity. With Katie, Calamity's feminine transformation begins. In one of the final scenes, Calamity is dressed in an over-the-top ballgown, but it seems that this feminine excess cannot stick to her successfully, and her failure to pass as a "normal" woman remains a focus. As Tamar Jeffers McDonald writes, "Katie's attempts to feminise Calam are, by contrast [to the cabin which they makeover], only partially successful: as noted, the attempt to graft the borrowed ballgown onto Calamity fails when she realises that her new daintiness has not got her the man she wants, and she

rejects the donation" (2007, 183). McDonald argues that Calamity's near-final state of "newly laundered" trousers evidences a tension in the film between desiring Calamity to be adorned as excessively feminine and admiring the activity and spirit represented by her trouser-wearing (2007, 184). However we might read this storyline a little differently: Calamity's excessive femininity could not "pass" because it was read as dangerous. As Calamity's partner comments, her breasts are "concealed weapons" revealed by the ballgown. In the final scene, Calamity is in a high-necked, long-sleeved white lace wedding dress. Thus the gendering to which Calamity is finally made subject is associated more with the demure and less with the extreme. Like *Legally Blonde*, *Calamity Jane* reflects the difficulty and perceived dangers of feminine excess.

As the focus on the problematic femininity of Elle Woods and Calamity Jane reveals, excessive femininity often stands out as an obvious choice for feminist critique of popular texts. In contrast, these texts might be read differently, to understand how the gendered norms illuminated in these texts are less associated with excess and more concerned with "passing" and appearing naturally and properly gendered. In focusing critique on excessive femininity, feminist discourse on femininity inadvertently targets working-class women, as well as taking attention away from other more insidious and less obvious norms of gender possibly in operation.

Lessons from fashion

All of this is not to say that being interested in femininity, giving time to feminine gender presentation and embodiment, need not be justified only through discussions of violence and survival even as these remain central concerns. Here, it is useful to turn very briefly to some sociological and historical perspectives on fashion, as a micro-case study in how attending to appearance without investing in it as a political mode *and* maintaining a broader political critique might work.

Some commentary from the perspective of the history and sociology of fashion offers vastly different analyses of feminine gender presentation to those offered by many feminist accounts, owing to the different overarching rationales that drive the approaches. While much feminist theory has set out to unpack gender issues as related to a framework of gender inequality, and often patriarchy, in contrast, analyses of fashion include discussions of gender as a subsection of broader historical inquiries into fashion. Indeed, fashion theorists often focus on investigating changing norms of fashion in interaction with social movements such as feminism. Thus fashion theorists take into account the complex interrelationship between social expectations around femininity and feminist responses in dialogue with fashion trends.

One way that some fashion theorists have understood the connection between fashion, beauty, and femininity is that external appearance acts as a signifier of gender; or, to put it another way, appearance is a way of communicating gender. Fashion historian Elizabeth Wilson argues: "Fashion is obsessed with gender, [and] defines and redefines the gender boundary" (1985, 117). This is a point

sometimes reflected in feminist accounts; for example, as Brownmiller notes: "Clothes never shut up. They gabble on endlessly, making their intentional and unintentional points" (1984, 81). In other words, fashion communicates and is in dialogue with expectations of gender (Entwistle 2000, 140). On the struggle for feminists to respond to fashion, Wilson writes that the challenging question is: "[D]oes [fashion] muffle the self, or create it?" (1985, 231). Wilson and others argue that it is through the adornment of external appearance that one becomes intelligible in society, and that fashion is inextricably connected with the body (Silverman 1986; Wilson 2001; Wilson 2013). However fashion historian Rebecca Arnold argues in *Fashion, Desire, and Anxiety: Image and Morality in the 20th Century* that, rather than reinforcing gendered norms per se, fashion experiments with gender and representations of femininity often intentionally play with the idea of masquerade to highlight the constructed nature of gender altogether. After a lengthy description of the changing ways femininity has been represented in fashion over time, she notes:

> Fear of exaggeration, of drawing too much attention to oneself that is so important a part of bourgeois culture, has become a moral restraint to be defied rather than reinforced by couture fashion, now so self-reflexive in its parodies of its own past and the feminine images it has created.
>
> (2001, 111)

Arnold's point is a reminder of the ways in which fashion might challenge and engage with questions of gender, rather than simply reproduce oppression.

While perspectives on fashion offer a way to engage with questions of femininity and appearance in a way that does not simply code this in terms of oppression, it is important to note that the claims made by some feminists about feminine fashion and beauty do not emerge from mere speculation but from material conditions of gender inequality. As Ferreday notes, owing to the *social pressures* on women to undertake specific beauty regimes, which require effort to achieve, femininity has often been conceived of as "oppressive labour" (2007, 3). While Ferreday accepts this argument, she also adds caution and suggests considering realms of alternative femininities such as burlesque, where feminine appearance carries a different weight. This point is echoed by Holliday and Taylor, who claim that feminist approaches to beauty often overlook its changing history and focus *only* on the idea that beauty is connected to power, seeing beauty as a set of arduous disciplinary forces acting upon the body (2006, 180). Furthermore, focusing on fashion and beauty as central to feminist critique raises the conundrum of whether being outside of these systems of recognition is even possible. As Negrin argues: "It is never possible to simply 'opt out' of the discourse of fashion" (2008, 40). Wilson makes a similar point: "For everyone clothes are compulsory" (1985, 228). Barnard also questions the specific strategy of rejecting "feminine" clothes in favour of androgynous or masculine ones, suggesting that this reversal may in fact reify a problematic gendered binary, simply replacing the "norm" with a different set of expectations (1996, 135–136). In any case, positioning "alternatives"

to feminine fashion and beauty as the antidote to women's oppression suggests an underlying philosophy that one can be "outside" of this system of signifiers.

In defence of the way that fashions are adopted, Wilson contends that fashion is much more than a reflection of oppressive gender norms, but is in fact a mixture of facets of life. She writes: "when we dress we wear inscribed upon our bodies the often obscure relationship of art, personal psychology and the social order" (1985, 247). There are, of course, critiques of the fashion industry that fall outside its relationship to norms of femininity. For example, Wilson turns to the inequitable economic aspects of fashion production, instead of critiquing the ways fashion is taken up as most problematic. Wilson argues that there are economic aspects to the production and circulation of fashion that might be considered: "Capitalism maims, kills, appropriates, lays waste. It also creates great wealth and beauty, together with a yearning for lives and opportunities that remain just beyond our reach. It manufactures dreams and images as well as things, and fashion is as much a part of the dream world of capitalism as of its economy" (1985, 14). She also writes: "Only progressive economic policies can end this exploitation, and in that sense the clothes we wear are part of a wider struggle that doesn't necessarily imply a rejection of finery as such" (1985, 235). Wilson pays heed to the feminist critiques that target fashion for its relationship to gender. She argues that fashion, rather than being oppressive, can be a place for experimentation. She also writes: "Out of the cracks in the pavements of cities grow the weeds that begin to rot the fabric. In the sense, therefore, that we can use and play with fashion, we should reject feminist ambivalence as an inappropriate if understandable response" (1985, 245). Rather than see this perspective as endorsing individual embodiment as a form of resistance per se, we might see Wilson here as suggesting that fashion can offer a glimmer of hope for a different future.

To presume that fashion and beauty are simply oppressive regimes is to overlook several factors: how femininity is embodied and experienced in dynamic ways through fashion and beauty practices; the pleasures these practices might afford; the potential for these arenas to present opportunities to challenge rather than reify gender norms; and the limits of appearance in resisting forces of culture more broadly. Rather than critiquing fashion and beauty, then, as key instruments of the oppression of women, we might instead turn to a more nuanced account that considers the limitations *and* possibilities of fashion and beauty. As Negrin writes:

> Rather than simply affirming the enjoyment afforded by fashion, more crucial is the necessity to recognise the impediments that prevent the full realisation of these pleasures in contemporary society.
>
> (2008, 51)

Undertaking such an approach is clearly not a simple task, as evidenced by the work of Coy and Garner, who consider that emphasising elements of structural oppression can easily slip into the claim that women have no real agency. In giving time to femininity, and in questioning what femininity might "do" alongside considering what utopian femininity might look like, we can find a

way to negotiate this dilemma of asking new questions about femininity while maintaining the ability to imagine radical possibilities for the future.

Undoing femininity

As I have sketched in this chapter, the history of feminism has involved a long history of critiquing femininity, in ways that have often inadvertently collapsed effect into cause. Femininity has been seen as little more than a bind because feminine appearance has been understandably understood as connected to the expectations placed on women in society where gender inequality persists. However, where there has been a target on larger structures – or "The Man" as the Miss America pageant flier alluded – this focus has often been reduced down to the level of individual embodiment. While masculinity studies continues to be a growing area of study that does not simply or easily map masculinity onto oppression (even in Connell's famous theory there is the possibility of subordinate masculinity offering a site of interest), the same cannot be said of studies of femininity. Feminine styles have come to act as powerful signifiers of women's oppressions, and have historically been targeted as such. Though the story of the second wave feminist movement was much broader than that which I have covered here, I have focused on the Miss America pageant protest precisely because of the way it is remembered as key. This protest, focused on the embodiment and gender presentation of women, is so frequently represented as "the" moment the second wave began to take off that we must also see this as an indication of how the relationship between feminism and femininity was and continues to be imagined. Such an imagining bends easily toward transforming "the personal is political" into "the personal is *the* political", where femininity is coded as oppression, seen as a problem to be overcome, and as a masquerade that must be unveiled. Attendance to class, and following this, the implication that excessive femininity is most problematic, complicates the story of femininity as oppressive and helps us to question whether femininity is simply a mask to be taken off to reveal an authentic self underneath. The following chapter explores the perpetuation of the "personal is *the* political" in the twenty-first century, where individual feminine embodiment is not only seen as a signifier of oppression, but is understood as symbolic of a lost period of feminist activism. The question that remains is how we might understand femininity in a way that undoes and unbinds the connection between femininity and oppression.



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

2 Feminism lost in the feminine body

As many others have pointed out, a discourse of loss has been a characteristic and dominant feature of contemporary feminist discussion at the beginning of the twenty-first century (Adkins 2004; Clare Hemmings 2005; Dean 2012). Lisa Adkins for example points to the problems of loss narratives in the "*passing on* of feminism", which often creates generational ruptures (2004, 429; emphasis in original). Hemmings also observes that, despite the regular insistence by feminists that *multiple* feminisms exist, there is a homogenous focus on dialectical narratives of progress versus loss in accounts of the history of Western feminism (2005, 115). In the texts of Levy, McRobbie, Power, and Walter explored in this chapter, a prominent theme is the idea of a lost era of feminism. There is a sense in the four texts of a present time that has been evacuated of authentic feminist sentiment. Each author also suggests that lost feminism was a central motivation for the writing of their texts. For example, McRobbie describes her "rising discomfort" with feminist cultural studies and the celebration of the femininity represented in popular culture (2009, 3). Commenting on McRobbie's and Walter's work, Ferreday and Coleman suggest that the sense of loss in these texts is connected with feminism becoming too popular and thus appropriated, and in turn is seen as having failed (2010, 316). Furthermore, Dean argues that this theme of loss often manifests as a nostalgia for the feminist activism of the 1970s and 1980s, and as an active dismissal of the potential of young women to be feminists today, along with the charge that they are uninterested in all things political (2012, 319). Dean contrasts this with a sense of what he sees as resurgent interest in feminism and activism among a younger generation (2012, 315).

Indeed, if we look to the *title* of the work analysed here, each highlights the theme of lost feminism. *The Aftermath of Feminism: Gender, Culture, and Social Change* (McRobbie 2009) alludes to a present following *after* a period of feminism (that is, postfeminism), and the use of the word "aftermath" also evokes a sense of a battle lost. *Living Dolls: The Return of Sexism* (Walter 2010), *Female Chauvinist Pigs: Women and the Rise of Raunch Culture* (Levy 2005), and *One Dimensional Woman* (Power 2009) all refer to the individual female subject as corrupted and diminished. They respectively conjure a sense of the present-day woman as doll-like, chauvinistic, and lacking depth. As suggested in these titles, these authors identify the women of today as a problem, and specifically

a problem for feminism. Furthermore, this prevailing theme reinscribes a notion of past feminism as the ideal, and contributes to a feminist identity politics based on the rejection of postfeminist feminine embodiment. Most importantly, as discussed in this chapter, this loss is specifically inscribed in the feminine body, in such a way that both the cause and continuation of loss is seen as perpetuated by bodies read as feminine.

A note on valuing "feminist killjoys"

Given the analysis of the feminist texts offered here, it is important to pause and take seriously the objectives of the feminist writers in relation to their critical engagements and evaluations of femininity. As Ahmed helpfully points out in *The Promise of Happiness* (2010a), we must appropriately recognise feminism's long history of providing critique, instead of merely dismissing feminists as unhappy, boring, or passé. Here, Ahmed argues that critical negativity is vital, as she resists the notion that happiness as a normatively enrolled endpoint is something to aspire to. She writes: "There is solidarity in recognising our alienation from happiness, even if we do not inhabit the same place (and we do not). There can be joy in killing joy. And kill joy we must, and we do" (2010a, 87). Ahmed argues that while happiness once linguistically referred to good fortune, contemporary society has taken the "hap", or chance, out of happiness (2010b, 574). She contends that rather than happenstance, happiness has become a deliberate striving, a teleological disposition toward objects that we associate with happiness (2010b, 575). Ahmed evokes a feminist history of questioning notions of happiness often predicated on particular sets of values and social norms that restrict women, such as the promise of happiness in marriage, children, and the domestic sphere (2010a, 50–88). However Ahmed's perspective is not about championing *unhappiness*; rather, she highlights how feminist killjoys challenge the current state of affairs. She calls us to recognise that feminism's intervention has historically been to encourage women to cast off the mask of false happiness, to inhabit other possibilities in the face of social expectations. In other words, the feminist killjoy puts the possibility (the "hap") back into happiness.

Accordingly, while critically engaging with feminist texts, I take heed of Ahmed's point that "feminists are [problematically] read as being unhappy, such that situations of conflict, violence, and power are read as about the unhappiness of feminists rather than about what feminists are unhappy about" (2010b, 583). Here, Ahmed highlights the need to generously consider the critical objects of feminism. While I offer a critique of points made in some feminist accounts of femininity, it must be simultaneously appreciated that these works also offer important insights into particular gendered modes, sets of expectations and narratives of how gendered life "ought" to be. Briefly applying Ahmed's ideas to the key texts analysed below, the feminist theorists engaged with are "unhappy" (read: critical) about the normative gender expectations placed upon women. Many feminists in recent years have been critical of the future of feminism based on their sense that feminism has been lost in the contemporary era. These feminists challenge

the supposed happiness of a "postfeminist" era where women are led to believe that their femininity is fully self-styled and freely chosen. They are also critical of the way women's bodies are made into consumer products. The image-dependent industries of pornography and magazine publication are particularly targeted, and are criticised for their lack of feminist content or depth and their objectification of women. The happiness rejected here is the promise of equality through sexual attention. Further, these feminists challenge the false promise of choice and agency encouraged under "raunch culture", and are critical about the disingenuous nature of public displays of sexuality, which, they argue, can never be more than performance. In sum, these feminists are critical of the current state of contemporary society, where feminist sentiment appears to have waned while the sexualisation of women has increased. Whether we agree or disagree with these arguments, these accounts nonetheless offer important insights into questions of agency, consumption, and objectification.

However, while I seek to take account of Ahmed's argument to avoid merely dismissing the feminists examined here as "killjoys", I am also interested in turning attention to what might inadvertently be "killed" in the process of their critiques. For example, the feminists I discuss below connect lost feminism to women's attachments to particular feminine stylings. These feminist critiques problematically make women and their bodies the focus, constructing an intimate – though possibly unintentional – connection between *lost feminism* and *feminine styles of the body*.

A critical moment in contemporary feminism

It is within the context of the history of feminist approaches to femininity sketched in chapter one that the specific feminist accounts analysed below must be understood. The crux of the accounts I investigate here is that they mark out the exposed feminine body as *the* vessel of lost feminism. It is important to note that since the publication of the feminist texts described below, a substantial number of others have been released (see for example: Moran 2011, 2012; Valenti 2008; Orenstein 2011; Appignanesi, Holmes, and Orbach 2013; Valenti 2014; Penny 2014; Cosslett and Baxter 2014; Gay 2014; Bates 2014; Bates 2016; Zeisler 2016). However, the texts considered here capture a distinct moment in feminist writing in the first decade of the twenty-first century. These texts have been of particular influence in opening up questions around postfeminism, raunch culture, and contemporary styles of femininity. Notably, McRobbie's *The Aftermath of Feminism* is more academic in register than the other texts, but has been chosen for its connection with the others, and its extensive citation more generally. These texts have been chosen as a way to help understand a recent historical moment in feminist thinking in more detail. As I unpack here, they reveal a nostalgic memory of a feminism past, which focuses on the politics of the individual body (the personal as *the* political) rather than proposing radical structural changes for a differently organised world. While I am certainly sympathetic to the issues that they raise around the treatment of women, their focus on the feminine as always already

problematic, and thus the limitations of their arguments for making space for differently gendered bodies, is deeply questioned.

First, Levy's best-selling book *Female Chauvinist Pigs* (2005), much like Bartky's (1997) work, aims to demonstrate that women are complicit in an overwhelming regime of female sexual objectification. Though the book was first published in 2005, it was reprinted in 2010, a sign of its appeal. Levy's work continues to be frequently cited in disciplines such as psychology, sociology, media studies, gender studies, political science, and cultural studies, particularly around discussions of the sexualisation of culture. Levy, based in the United States and a columnist for *The New Yorker* magazine, centrally argues in this work that there is a "raunch culture" in operation in Western society. Her idea of raunch culture has been frequently referenced (Gill 2009, 138; Cockburn 2007, 207; Bale 2011, 303). It is important to note that some theorists using the term "raunch culture" have also been critical of it, noting that it is too generalised and laden with moral judgements (for example see Gill 2011). There has also been debate in recent years about the possible resistant power of raunch in the wake of the SlutWalk movement, with the idea that "strategic raunch" might be employed to target sexism (Watson and Mason 2015, 138). However, even in these discussions there is a broad agreement that contemporary culture is marked by some form of feminine sexualisation that ought to be placed at the centre of feminist investigation. Levy's evidence for raunch culture includes (though some of these examples may read a little dated now): that porn stars have become household names; young women now willingly perform sexual acts on camera; female athletes have become pin ups; businesswomen attend sex parties; girls aspire to be part of the *Playboy* empire; and women act like men – that is, as "chauvinist pigs". Thus *Female Chauvinist Pigs* aims to show how a pornographic exhibitionist form of female sexuality has become socially normalised.

In contrast to Levy, McRobbie writes for a predominantly academic audience and is a preeminent scholar and researcher in cultural studies in the United Kingdom. In *The Aftermath of Feminism* (2009), McRobbie offers a similar – though more nuanced – intervention to Levy's, giving an account of the state of feminism in academia and popular culture following the 1990s. While Levy's text principally focuses on practices related to women's self-objectification, McRobbie extends this approach to the question of feminism's success as a movement, and the limited possibilities for its recuperation in the face of the "ironic normalisation of pornography" and the hyper-sexualisation of women in society (2009, 17). She argues that there has been a "backlash" to feminism, involving commodification and the absorption and nullification of feminist terms such as "empowerment" through replication in the popular realm, which has rendered them virtually antithetical to feminist concerns (2009, 1). McRobbie states that her work is in part a "retrieval" project: an attempt to recuperate authentic feminist critiques of female representation in visual culture (2009, 6). This is a departure from her previous works on girlhood and popular culture. For example, *Feminism and Youth Culture: From "Jackie" to "Just Seventeen"* considers the female consumption of magazines, and the ability of these objects to both adapt to and influence new

audiences (McRobbie 1991). McRobbie has also written previously about the class dimensions of femininity, arguing that "[working-class girls] are both saved by and locked within the culture of femininity" (1978, 108). However since the 1990s she has also been concerned with the impact of postmodernism and changing approaches to feminism in the United Kingdom and how these changes lead to "[a] dramatic 'unfixing' of young women in British society" (1994, 157). Similar themes are present in *The Aftermath of Feminism*, though she is more explicit in naming problems of femininity as postfeminist.

In contrast, Power's *One Dimensional Woman* offers a perspective ostensibly more focused on a structural analysis of consumption and neoliberalism (2009). A British academic, she has a background in philosophy, and also frequently writes for *The Guardian* and other mainstream publications. *One Dimensional Woman* is a short text that assesses the representation of women and feminism in the contemporary West. It takes a critical theory approach, and, as Power acknowledges, her book title plays on Herbert Marcuse's *One Dimensional Man* which analyses the connections between the body of "man" and consumption within capitalist society (1964). Power explicitly engages with Levy's work but has a stronger focus on how women are caught up in a neoliberal agenda of consumption and anti-feminism. For example, Power challenges the writing of popular feminist columnist Jessica Valenti (who I turn to in chapter three) on the basis of what Valenti's supposed "feminism" lacks. This gives us an idea of what Power thinks feminism needs and can be defined by, as she writes: "Valenti's version of feminism, with its total lack of structural analysis, genuine outrage or collective demand, believes it has to compliment capitalism in order to effectively sell its product" (2009, 30). Power's work is important here because although she offers a structural critique, she retains a focus on feminine styles as a central problem for contemporary feminism.

Lastly, Walter's *Living Dolls: The Return of Sexism* (2010) deals with a theme that continues to be central to public feminist debates: the relationship of gendered norms in childhood to adult norms of femininity. Based in the United Kingdom, Walter is an academic and has written for publications such as *The Guardian*. Walter's earlier works include *The New Feminism* (1999), which identified a resurgent feminism in the late 1990s, and an edited collection called *On the Move: Feminism for a New Generation* that includes accounts from young feminists (2000). In *The New Feminism*, Walter argues: "Rather than concentrating its energy on the ways women dress and talk and make love, feminism must now attack the material basis of economic and social and political inequality" (1999, 4). In *Living Dolls*, however, Walter tellingly does not refer to her earlier works, but argues that sexism has "returned". She explores the "pinkification" of childhood, and how women are encouraged to model themselves on dolls into adulthood. Though receiving less popular attention than Levy's work, and fewer academic citations than McRobbie's, the interest in both Walter's and Power's texts have been taken as evidence of a new resurgence in feminism in the 2000's (Bulbeck 2011, 236). For the purpose of this book, Levy, McRobbie, Walter, and Power are used to demonstrate how the claim that feminism has been lost

is often evidenced through examining the embodiment of women themselves, reinforcing the idea that femininity is a signifier of oppression: the personal as *the* political.

Modern femininity and the lost age of feminism

The theme of loss is particularly evident in Levy, who explicitly mourns the downfall of an earlier feminist activism. According to Levy, the feminism of the past was more exciting, more interesting, more critical, and more daring (2005, 85). Levy's concern for a lost, more authentic feminism is echoed throughout *Female Chauvinist Pigs*, most clearly in the chapter "The Future That Never Happened" (2005, 46–88). This title suggests a future-present haunted by a spectre of past feminism that has not been allowed to flourish. Most significantly, Levy ties this loss to the bodily stylings of women. Levy writes: "Only thirty years (my lifetime) ago, our mothers were 'burning their bras' and picketing *Playboy*, and suddenly we were getting implants and wearing the bunny logo as supposed symbols of our liberation" (2005, 3). Calling to mind the Miss America pageant protest, Levy focuses her critique on stylings of the female body in the modern era to claim that the women of today fall short compared to the feminists of the past. In Levy's writing we can see a particular focus on the body as symbolic: " '[r]aunchy' and 'liberated' are not synonyms. It is worth asking ourselves if this bawdy world of boobs and gams we have resurrected reflects how far we've come, or how far we have left to go" (Levy 2005, 5). Here "boobs" (breasts) and "gams" (legs) are made symbolic of a new world order evacuated of real feminism. Levy sets out to show that, despite a contemporary trend toward language of feminist empowerment, the actions and styles of the body currently being adopted by women suggest an insidious oppression masquerading as freedom. In this way, Levy is critical of present-day women's *appearance* and *embodiment*. Levy is sceptical of contemporary femininity insofar as this involves a sexualised presentation of the body – that is, that which falls under the rubric of what she terms "raunch culture". Though Levy expands her critique to reflect the problem of this as a *culture*, her focus nonetheless remains on the individual women who partake in and perpetuate this culture, with particular attention on their bodies. Women are cast as "female chauvinist pigs": corrupt and disordered promoters of an oppressive gendered regime.

Like Levy, Walter also argues that we should return to an earlier form of feminism more critical of processes of objectification. Walter suggests that modern women's focus on "self-expression" ought to be critiqued more heavily (2010, 65). While Walter remarks, "we have come so far already", she suggests it is not far *enough*, since traditional signifiers of femininity such as the colour pink remain in vogue (2010, 15). Walter begins *Living Dolls* with a discussion of the overwhelming use of pink for toys marketed to girls and extends this observation to the claim that young girls are growing up modelling themselves on toys such as Barbie and Bratz Dolls. Walter claims: "The brilliant marketing strategies of these brands are managing to fuse the doll and the real girl in a way that would

have been unthinkable a generation ago. This strange melding of the doll and the real girl can continue way beyond childhood" (2010, 2). As Walter points out, girls are submerged in a world of pink, princesses, and dolls, and she argues that this means that as adult women they go to dangerous extremes to model ideals absorbed in childhood:

> It often seems now that dolls are escaping from the toyshops and taking over girls' lives. Not only are little girls expected to play with dolls, they are expected to model themselves on their favourite playthings.
>
> (Walter 2010, 1)

With some optimism, Walter suggests that "the gains of the past have not yet been lost", and argues that by looking to feminism's past we can more effectively respond to the present (2010, 231). She approvingly cites several examples such as the website Pinkstinks, which she regards as an exemplary feminist initiative that "has the potential to have significant impact even in many areas where people have lost hope of seeing change" (2010, 233). Walter explains that Pinkstinks is a site dedicated to critiquing and actively lobbying against the "pinkification" and sexualisation of toys and clothing marketed to girls. Having interviewed the founders of the site, Walter highlights Pinkstinks' aims:

> "We want to raise awareness about the way that girls are being really restricted by the culture of pink", [founder] Emma Moore told me. "We aren't killjoys, but we don't think that there should be this monoculture that tells girls that there is only one acceptable way to be, and it's all about sparkles and make-up and princesses".
>
> (2010, 236)

Here the Pinkstinks group constitutes pink as the symbol which both reflects and reproduces limited possibilities for girls in contemporary society. They write: "Girls' products overwhelmingly focus on being pretty, passive and obsessed with shopping, fashion and make-up – this promotes a dangerously narrow definition of what it means to be a girl" ("Pinkstinks" 2015). The website includes banners such as "I'm no princess" and campaigns against "slap" (makeup) for children. For Walter, campaigns such as Pinkstinks are evidence of a reinvigorated new wave of feminist activism. Here we see that "pink" and the concepts signified by objects such as dolls are the targets, precluding a consideration of girls' interaction with these materials. Walter's representational focus means that particular signifiers such as pink are seen as inherently carrying meaning associated with oppression; for Walter, pink is a homogenous concept. Under Walter's framing, colours and objects such as dolls are heavy with a singular meaning and have the power to shape girls' subjectivity and limit their future possibilities. Thus pink is inscribed as dangerous, and through focusing on the figure of the doll as emblematic, Walter also locates lost feminism in the body, where the body of the doll – plastic, fake, and passive – acts as a metaphor for contemporary women.

Similarly to Levy and Walter, McRobbie argues for the retrieval of a lost feminism, outlining how contemporary society is caught up in an age of postfeminism characterised by "anti-feminist sentiment", or "a kind of anti-feminism" (2009, 1, 130). McRobbie suggests that the post-structuralist academic feminism of the 1990s led to feminism "undoing" itself through reflexivity and self-critique (2009, 43). Along these lines, McRobbie suggests a salvage project: to recover some of the "gains of the 1970s and 1980s" that postfeminism has "actively and relentlessly undermined" (2009, 6. 11). In this way, the term "postfeminism" functions for McRobbie not to describe a historical *period of time* following the women's liberation movement of the 1970s and 1980s, but to define an insidious *trend* working against the best interests of women. This postfeminist world is not simply a return to pre-feminist days. As she states: "Feminism is invoked, in order to be relegated to the past" (2009, 20). According to McRobbie, postfeminism is reliant on references to feminism in order to dismiss its aims and ideas as out-moded. Like Levy, McRobbie reveals the lost feminism of the postfeminist era through an emphasis on dominant forms of feminine embodiment and appearance. Though McRobbie is similar to Levy in her focus on issues of hypersexualisation (2009, 17), she pays more attention to the racialised White spectacle of modern femininity. For example, she argues that female characters from many popular culture texts represent a "nostalgia for whiteness" (2009, 9). The character Bridget Jones is also described by McRobbie as "adamantly girlish", this girlishness being, in her view, a requirement of modern femininity (2009, 24). In addition McRobbie focuses on the bodily pathologies of contemporary femininity and the way feminine bodies are dangerously compelled toward normativity as reflected in the prevalence of eating disorders. She points out that manifestations of this desire for thin feminine bodies are categorised as internal and individual disorders rather than being recognised as social, cultural, and political phenomena (2009, 94). McRobbie is critical of contemporary society for its active rejection of feminist ideals of the past as exemplified by White-culture-based, sickness-inducing, girlish feminine embodiments. According to McRobbie, feminism is being disarticulated with serious consequences that are echoed in popular culture and dangerously played out through the bodies of ordinary women. Thus her structural focus does not prevent her from identifying the bodily representations of women as the exemplars of lost feminism. Furthermore, as identified in the introduction, McRobbie's ability to critique the structural forces of sexism under capitalism are precluded by her collapse of the symptoms into the cause, where "femininity" is made the problematic object.

Similarly to McRobbie, Power organises her text around what has been lost. Her first sentence reads: "Where have all the interesting women gone?" (2009, 1). She mourns the loss of a women's liberation movement that she sees as having been compromised by a renewed focus on capitalist pursuits. She claims that the term "feminism" is being misused by those who would not traditionally be considered feminists, such as conservative American politician Sarah Palin (2009, 2). She also critiques an influx of new wave feminists, accusing them of overlooking the connection between women's liberation and the rise of consumer culture

(2009, 1). She writes: "[W]e are not only dealing with 'right' and 'left' feminism, but with a fundamental crisis in the meaning of the word" (2009, 8). Primarily, Power encourages the reader to be highly critical of the use of the term "feminist" by figures such as Palin and Valenti, though they are from opposite sides of the political spectrum. For Power, the loss of feminism is represented by the current bodily norms of femininity, specifically the commodification of the body under capitalism. For example, Power notes "just how confusing" women's magazines are, with different styles of the self on offer:

> Photoshop has turned fashion photography into something you'd want to lick, rather than emulate. And the whole libidinal economy of half-naked women staring up at you, as if you were the owner of a peculiarly classical male gaze. (2009, 31)

Power locates lost feminism in an objectifying female gaze, and in this way, like Levy, Walter, and McRobbie, suggests that women have taken up the role of the traditionally male sexual aggressor. The "lickable" bodies referred to here operate symbolically as a sign of the downfall of feminism; in her view the female body has become a commodity that women themselves now want to consume. Power's suggestion that there is a lack of "interesting" women also implies a turn toward the dull and banal. While Power maintains a structural critique of the capitalist system that enforces particular norms, she illustrates this problem by focusing on individual women and their bodily stylings, their presumed narcissism, and self-inflected gaze.

Notably in these texts we see a focus on *young* women at the centre of the problematic of lost feminism. The ideal of femininity described by these authors is located in youthful bodies. McRobbie explicitly connects her discussion to "girlhoods", but also talks about the problem of a younger generation that rejects patriarchy theory (2009, 57). The youthfulness of the postfeminist is essential to McRobbie's point because it is the young modern woman with whom the future is invested. McRobbie states: "The pleasingly, lively, capable and becoming *young* woman, black, white or Asian, is now an attractive harbinger of social change" (McRobbie 2009, 58; emphasis added). Similarly to the way Power talks about "girls", Walter focuses on young women and children, and Levy discusses a new generation of women that differ from an older, more feminist one. Here loss is in the feminine body, and this body is coded as young. As Catherine Driscoll notes, young women or "girls" have often been the focus of feminist critique (2002). It is of course important to note that normative femininity is often understood as coded by age; as Calasanti and Slevin note, there is a specific expectation for women to remain young-looking in order to maintain their femininity (2001, 65). Taking this into account helps to make sense of why young women easily become the target of femininity critiques of femininity – because it is a younger age group who are recognised as best achieving and representing normative femininity. However this is not to say that more caution ought not to be exercised in such discussions, where critiquing the imperative to present as youthful might so easily slip into a critique of the young.

According to these texts, the loss of true or authentic feminist activism is indicated by a world obsessed with female bodies that are sexualised, White, doll-like, youthful, and easily consumed. In the work of these feminists we see that loss is located *in* and evidenced *through* the styles of women's bodies. In tracing lost feminism directly alongside references to the female body, particular styles of the body (those marked as "raunchy") inevitably act as signifiers of postfeminism.

The centrality of fake breasts

The critique of auto-objectivisation offered in each of these texts, is highlighted by the authors' discussions of breasts as symbolic of this new culture. Summarised into the icon of fake breasts, exemplifying her unhappiness with lost feminism and with the current state of postfeminist self-aggrandisement, Levy claims:

> Instead of hairy legs, we have waxed vaginas; the free-flying natural woman boobs of yore have been hoisted with push-up bras or "enhanced" into taut plastic orbs that stand perpetually at attention. What has moved into feminism's place as the most pervasive phenomenon in American womanhood is an almost opposite style, attitude, and set of principles.
>
> (2005, 87)

We see in this passage that the female body – but in particular the breast – is the symbol encapsulating the transition from the freedom of feminism past to contemporary postfeminist raunch culture. Power similarly contends that auto-objectivisation is a growing problem and argues that women who are having surgery and breast implants are effectively turning themselves into spectacles (2009, 25). Both Levy and Power discuss the American reality TV show *Girls Gone Wild* (*GGW*), and here again the breast is used as a metaphor for a broader issue. In Power's words:

> When the "Girls Gone Wild" team hand out hats or t-shirts in exchange for a shot of breasts, or the performance of a snog with another woman, the logic is right out in the open: we'll give you something obviously crap in exchange for a kind of performance that reveals that there is nothing subjective, nothing left, hidden behind the appearance, that you simply are commensurate with your comportment in the world. You are your breasts.
>
> (2009, 24)

Power's account frames the exposed breasts in negative terms; fake breasts are the synecdoche for the modern postfeminist, reduced in her capacity and subject to male desire. This rhetorically locates the "problem" in the flesh of women's bodies, specifically in the breasts.

Likewise, McRobbie describes and critiques the bodily practices that young women today are expected to find enjoyable. McRobbie turns her lens to a figure she describes as "the phallic girl", a woman who "gives the impression of

having won equality with men by becoming like her male counterparts" (2009, 83). McRobbie outlines the elements of "masculinity" that these girls adopt as:

> Heavy drinking, swearing, smoking, getting into fights, having casual sex, flashing her breasts in public, getting arrested by the police, consumption of pornography, enjoyment of lap-dancing clubs and so on.
>
> (2009, 83)

Though McRobbie claims that the phallic girl emulates the masculine; again the "flashing breast" is used here as a marker of self-objectification. Importantly these girls also do not give up "the femininity which makes them so desirable to men"; indeed, McRobbie states that "glamour models" exemplify the phallic girl (2009, 84). In other words, phallic girls adopt the overt sexual proclivities and behaviours expected of men (that is, they perform masculinity) while remaining passive and subservient, constructing their gender presentation for the male gaze (that is, they equally perform femininity). According to this logic, women are adopting the position of the male gaze and are willing to make themselves sexual objects, becoming detached and dissociated from their own bodies. Thus women themselves are not entirely to blame for the culture they are perpetuating; in support of this, McRobbie writes:

> Consumer culture, the tabloid press, the girl's and women's magazine sector . . . all encourage young women, as though in the name of sexual equality, to overturn the old double standard and emulate the assertive and hedonistic styles of sexuality associated with young men.
>
> (2009, 84)

Exposed breasts are used here again as signifiers of a new culture of female sexuality wherein women are called upon to emulate men, in the name of empowerment.

Walter also focuses on scenes of flashing breasts as exemplary of a disordered culture, recalling in the first chapter of *Living Dolls* her visit to a nightclub, which ended with a crowd shouting "get your tits out, get your tits out, get your tits out for the lads", and the women present complying by "rubb[ing] their breasts against each other" (2010, 24). Like McRobbie, Walter's image of the new post-feminist generation is marked by bare breasts. Within these texts, the breasts operate as a powerful symbol of objectification. For example Power writes:

> They, the breasts, and not their "owner", are the centre of attention, and are referred to, with alarming regularity, as completely autonomous objects, much as one would refer to suitcases or doughnuts. Constantly fiddled with, adjusted, exposed, covered-up or discussed, contemporary breasts resemble nothing so much as bourgeois pets: idiotic, toothless, yapping dogs with ribbons in their hair and personalised carrying pouches. These milkless objects of bemused scopophilia (frequently and explicitly "fake", as is the fashion)

> are described over and over as if possessed of their own will and desire, separate from that of their owners ("Oh no! It slipped out of my top! Again!").
> (2009, 25)

More explicitly than in McRobbie's account, breasts are portrayed "as if possessed of their own will and desire", separated from the women to whom they belong. Power's contention is that the sexualised femininity embodied by fake breasts is nothing more than "idiotic". The target here is not the breasts per se, but all that they represent: their exposure for the pleasure of men; their fakeness; and their sexual rather than practical or nurturing nature – they are "milkless". Here we see the symbol of the breasts used to represent dangerous bodies and an unhealthy culture. Moreover, the women attached to these breasts are identified as foolish and mindless by association.

In these accounts we see that the problem of contemporary culture is not only reduced to the bodies of women but is specifically symbolised by breasts on many occasions. Moreover, this focus is generally on the "fake" breast, which is made an emblem of "fake" feminism. With the use of the fake breast as symbolic of a new postfeminist generation, women are cast as superficial and lacking the real "meat" of feminism. This kind of account argues that a particular style of the body (a particularly "sexualised" standard of femininity) symbolises some dysfunction of the person involved: femininity is pathologised as a sick version of feminism: feminism gone wild.

The always unacceptable exposed body

Another theme present in each of the texts is the limited nature of a discourse of "choice", which enables women to claim that they are empowered feminists, or indeed that they are *past* feminism. While these texts dismiss the possibility of "choice" for particular styles of the body, they present choosing to reject these styles as necessary for female and feminist flourishing. Thus empowerment is represented as *to choose to reject raunch culture* and disempowerment as *to fail to reject raunch culture*. The issues highlighted by the authors again relate to the presentation of the female body, particularly the revealed or sexualised body, which is understood as always unacceptable or oppressive even if "choice" is invoked.

According to McRobbie, in the era of postfeminism, both traditional and hypersexualised forms of femininity are celebrated, yet the shadow of feminism past contributes to a sense that women (now liberated) can freely choose to adopt traditional behaviours and roles, or sexualised styles of the body. However, in her view, what is (seemingly freely) chosen by these women is antithetical to their flourishing. She contends that there is a contemporary "ideal" of feminine appearance that is making girls physically sick, with eating disorders like anorexia operating as markers of femininity and sexual difference (2009, 97). McRobbie's claims here sit within a body of work which argue that there is a contemporary epidemic of young girls with eating disorders (see for example: Martin 2007). However what many approaches erase is the voices of those living through eating

disorders in the first instance (Ferreday 2012). McRobbie similarly describes contestants from the BBC reality show *What Not to Wear* as "victims", reinforcing the notion that women are actively injured by the operating norms of femininity within a postfeminist context (2009, 128). This view echoes the sentiments of Levy, Power, and Walter: contemporary women are both victims and perpetrators in a sexualised regime that is physically and psychically damaging.

McRobbie is particularly critical of the role played by evoking "choice" in postfeminism, which she sees as synonymous with a kind of masquerade in which artifice is proof of liberation. She states that "the woman in masquerade is making a point that this is a freely chosen look" (2009, 66). Importantly, McRobbie rejects this logic of choice, instead recasting it as a mark of oppression and false-consciousness. The solution is a neo-second-wave intervention into the "third wave model", which suggests a return to choosing to *reject* a particular form of femininity (McRobbie 2009, 156). Levy also discusses the phenomenon of choice, particularly women choosing to engage in raunch culture. She suggests that sexual expression and embodiment might be experienced differently if women were *taught* how to choose differently. For example, in the chapter "Pigs in Training", Levy contends that young women need to learn how to connect with their own sexual desires, rather than desire sexual attention. She cites the work of psychologist Deborah Tolman, who interviewed teenage girls and found that their thoughts on sex revealed a separation between bodily arousal and their beliefs about what should constitute desire (2005, 163–164). Levy goes on to argue that although "everything we do with sexuality is *intimate* and *personal*" (2005, 166; emphasis added), children need sex education in school to teach them "how to cope with and enjoy their sexuality" (2005, 166). The lesson from Levy here is that though education is needed around sexuality, ultimately the onus is on women to manage their sexual expression in an appropriate, and private, way.

Along these lines, in marking out "raunch" as a "culture" in her text, Levy suggests that certain expressions of female sexuality are always already problematic within the *public* realm. Levy relies on a critique of representational "plastic stereotypes" (2005, 197) and marks the revealed body in the public sphere as evidence of raunch culture. She also identifies bodily "trends" as a key aspect of raunch, stating: "Elective cosmetic surgery – implants for straight women, mastectomies for FTMs ["female-to-male" transgender people] – is popular to the point of being faddish" (2005, 138). These bodily practices are not seen by Levy as private decisions simply becoming more public over time, but rather as things that are being paraded within a public sexualised culture. Within Levy's system of signifiers, revealed parts of the female body (such as nipples or labia), stockings, high heels, breast implants, and short skirts constitute elements of an oppressive whole: they are signs that women are in troubled times. Levy thus creates a representational bind between the sexualised revealed body and oppression, suggesting that sexuality must only be explored in private, as the revealed body in the public sphere is always a signifier of oppression.

Also suggesting that public exposure is oppressive, Power offers a short reading of Alain Badiou on the issue of Muslim women wearing headscarves as evidence

that there is a coercive norm of revealing the body in Western society. She quotes Badiou:

> Basically put: [feminism contends that] these girls or women are oppressed. . . . Wait a minute: do you mean it isn't the symbol of male oppression after all? . . . [T]he problem with the hijab is that it is conspicuously religious.
> (2009, 13)

Power contends that "the law on the hijab [in the West] is a pure capitalist law. It orders femininity to be exposed" (2009, 15). Power uses this as her key point, reading the hijab story from Badiou as meaning (in extension to women generally):

> The imperative for girls to show what they have to sell, to "hint at undressing", to have the female body circulate as part of a strategy of employability and consumerism renders the hijab an object of angry, law-obsessed confusion.
> (2009, 15)

Power's reading of Badiou is a critique of the capitalist demand to reveal the female body. However, it is interesting to note that Power elides a point made in Badiou's original piece: that *feminist discourse* plays a major part of this demand to expose flesh, to liberate women from the shackles of patriarchal religious practices. Returning to the original work, we see that Badiou writes:

> Starting off with women's liberation, nowadays feminism avers that the "freedom" acquired is so obligatory that it requires girls (and not a single boy!) to be excluded owing to the sole fact of their dressing accoutrements.
> (2004, para. 20)

Badiou thus suggests that feminism, under the rubric of liberation, often inculcates itself in the regime of demanding the removal of the headscarf. However, in Power's work, we see again that modern femininity *forces* the "choice" of exposure. In contrast to Power, Badiou makes the point that it is not the extremes that are most detrimental – he refers to this as the binary of the "mother" (covering up) or the "whore" (exposing too much) – but it is in fact the naturalised middle ground between these two points that we should be most concerned about: "it's the alternative between the two which must be rejected" (2004). While Power does not advocate covering up, she suggests that women ought to *choose* a different form of (non-superficial, non-exposed flesh) feminism, to "shuffle off its current one-dimensionality for good" (2009, 69).

Walter, too, focuses on the problems of false choice and seemingly oppressive body exposure. She writes: "We are currently living in a world where those aspects of feminine behaviour that could be freely chosen are often turning into a cage for young women" (2010, 14). Walter makes a very similar claim to McRobbie,

arguing that the language and ideas of a previous era of feminism have influenced a language of choice that has now been co-opted:

> It is modern feminism that created this rhetoric that foregrounds self-expression. . . . But that focus on independence and self-expression is now sold back to young women as the narrowest kind of consumerism and self-objectification.
>
> (2010, 65)

Compared to Power, McRobbie, and Levy, Walter leaves more room for the possibilities of self-expression and the enjoyment of femininity, yet she argues that the problem is that women are currently being told that these pursuits are compulsory: "there is a huge difference between taking pleasure in such pursuits and believing that the only route to confidence and power for a woman lies through constant physical vigilance" (2010, 67). Here Walter's conclusion suggests that, while the real problem is gender expectations, we ought to hark back to the original "feminist dream" that "tells us that rather than modelling themselves on the plasticine charm of a pink and smiling doll, women can aim to realise their full human potential" (2010, 238). This dream, as Walter casts it, again refers to the problem of the doll-like body and the falsity and restrictiveness of this embodiment. Where Walter discusses the highly physical activities of pole dancing, stripping, and burlesque, she reads these activities in terms of restriction; thus for Walter pink in childhood, the imperative to emulate a doll-like existence, and to partake in activities that would otherwise be seen as hyper-sexual, are all related to the same phenomenon. For example, she reports her discussion with an actress, who explains how she learned to strip for her husband and "sexily" remove clothing: "You hook your thumbs into the top of your knickers and start to slide up and down, then down a bit more. It's the stepping out of them that is the real triumph. It's like a dance" (2010, 42). Walter frames this report as an example of how a hyper-sexualised culture is influencing not just women's public image, but their personal relationships too. Again we see the claim that feelings of pleasure indicate that false-consciousness is operating. In Walter's account there is little to no room to imagine the possibility of agency or non-alienated pleasure.

Under these accounts exposure of the body is always marked as revealing a lack of agency. Particularly in returning to Badiou's discussion of exposure and the veil, we are left to wonder whether many Western feminist accounts are also involved in enforcing a norm of exposure that is neither too much nor too little – a norm of modesty that perhaps circulates implicitly in critiques of "raunch culture". They suggest that the rhetoric of choice ought to be rejected, but only insofar as choice is related to adoption of feminine styles of the body. These accounts offer an analysis that casts women as both active in the sense of choosing "raunch" embodiments and passive in terms of their false-consciousness about these activities under wider structures of oppression. This returns us to Bartky's claim which marks the feminine body as an active adoption of passivity: "The technologies

of femininity are taken up and practiced by women against the backdrop of a pervasive sense of bodily deficiency" (1997, 139), as described in chapter one. Levy's "female chauvinist pigs", Walter's "living dolls", McRobbie's "phallic girl", and Power's "one dimensional woman" all reiterate this focus on the individual woman who chooses her passive feminine sexualised fate. Choosing to reject these styles is thus seen as essential to the future of feminism. Paradoxically, under these accounts, authentic "choice" can *only* occur if these styles are rejected, and not if they are embraced.

The performance of sexuality

The final theme evident in each of these accounts is the way that legitimate pleasure in public displays of sexuality is rendered an impossibility. The authenticity of participating in public sexual displays such as "same-sex" kissing is questioned because the authors tend to cast sexuality in the public sphere as a problematic attention-seeking performance rather than genuine or otherwise enjoyable. The actions of the body are interpreted as performance, and the pleasures and sensations of the body take second place to a focus on the *representation* of the body (what the acts *looks like*, what it *means*). This view limits further examination of the experiences of women performing sexual acts in public, and erases the possibility of recognising the pleasurable aspects of these encounters and the space that they might offer for sexual exploration.

We see, for example in Levy, a preoccupation with the dangers of experimenting with sexuality within the social milieu of "raunch culture", where women are called upon to enjoy their objectification and men and women are encouraged to enjoy looking at and consuming women's bodies. As noted, Levy focuses much of her critique on the show *GGW*, which stars ordinary women taking their tops off and flashing their breasts to the camera. Levy recounts one key episode to demonstrate the way women are duped by the show to engage in sexual activities that are entirely constructed for the pleasure of the viewer:

> The trio [of young women] started making out in a ravenous lump, grabbing at each other's rears and rutting around while trying to remain upright. Ultimately, one girl fell over and landed giggling on the floor – a characteristic endpoint for a GGW scene.
>
> (2005, 11)

Levy argues that the women depicted were merely acting for the benefit of male viewers – the male gaze – thereby eliminating any possibility that they may have gained visceral enjoyment from involvement in the scene of intermingled bodies. Levy follows this description by noting that the woman who had fallen over laughing that night later called her up to say that she was upset about what had happened (2005, 11). Levy includes some of the phone call with one of the women involved: "I'm not at all bisexual . . . not that I have anything against that.

But when you think about it, I'd never do that really. It's more for show" (2005, 11). In this snippet of conversation, the event is fixed to a level of pure sexual objectification separated from the experience of the body. Levy later clarifies her stance that these women are *compelled* to perform: "For women, and only for women, hotness requires projecting a kind of eagerness, offering a promise that any attention you receive for your physicality is welcome" (2005, 33). She states that the women involved only experience a kind of false satisfaction to the extent that they are successfully performing self-objectification, driven by a desire to be like men. As she explains, "[S]o to really be like men, FCPs [female chauvinist pigs] have to enjoy looking at those women, too" (2005, 99). Levy's analysis elides any pleasure that may have been experienced by the women involved from their encounter of skin, limbs, mouths, hands, and buttocks, as described – or, indeed, any that the reader may have experienced in reading the erotic details Levy conveys. Levy instead supports the notion that later reports of distress reconfigure the past as always already traumatic, and constitutes the report of one of the women involved as a distressing tale of objectification even where her own comments do not make the story this simple. Here the public display of sexuality is not only a performance, it is seen as one entered into unwittingly, causing trauma and scarring. There is no room in Levy's analysis to take account of the experiences of the women involved as complex or shifting over time.

Similarly, Walter describes how engaging in sexualised activities such as burlesque can at first seem empowering and liberating, but with hindsight become understood as traumatising. Walter describes her encounters with several women who enjoy performing in burlesque troupes, and who describe their choices to engage in these performances as "powerful" and something that can "feel very good" (2010, 44). She quotes one woman, Ellie, on first starting lap dancing: "I didn't really reflect on it. As soon as I started to reflect on what I was doing, I left" (2010, 45). The same woman also suggests that her friends still in the profession are tied to finding it empowering because if they admit it was degrading this would be humiliating. As in Levy, we see that the act (here, lap dancing) is recast after the event as negative, and any reports of enjoyment as evidence of false-consciousness. Even if engaged with "positively", the argument is that these women are duping themselves. There is a sense that enjoying particular activities is always a performance involving false-consciousness (they are not *truly* enjoyable), and that once "tainted" with negative feelings they can never be understood as anything other than oppressive.

On the subject of "same-sex" desire, McRobbie imagines a limited space of possibility for genuine experiences in the public realm. Returning to the phallic girl, McRobbie inscribes masculinity as those elements of behaviour relating to sexual pleasure, aggression, and enjoying the spectacle of the female body, while femininity relates to an appearance which is ultimately about submission to the interests and viewing pleasures of men. McRobbie reads the actions of the phallic girl, or ladette, as "provocation to feminism, a triumphant gesture on the past of

resurgent patriarchy" (2009, 85). On the subject of lesbians or "same-sex" desire, McRobbie imagines a limited space of possibility, stating:

> A version of lesbian desire can be accommodated within this space of female phallicism, as long as it remains visually coded to conform to the requirement of the fashion and beauty system which . . . sits in judgement, substitutes for hegemonic masculinity and presides over the capacity, in this case sexual capacity, with which young women are endowed.
>
> (2009, 84)

Here McRobbie paints a picture of the "fake" lesbian, who undertakes sexual acts with other women for the benefit of men. McRobbie contrasts the fake lesbian with "the 'real lesbian' [who] is reviled in much the same way as the repudiated feminist" (2009, 86). In viewing the phallic girl as a "provocation to feminism", entry into "same-sex" experimentation is viewed only as a way in which to appropriate masculine sexuality (as a woman) for the viewing pleasures of men. For McRobbie, then, the existence of a "true" lesbian ladette is impossible. Here, "same-sex" activities are always a performance if executed by women whose feminine appearance and attributes perceptibly conform to that of the phallic girl.

Similarly, in her critique of the consumerist models of happiness presented in women's magazines, Power describes the magazines' representations as encouraging women to adopt the male gaze (2009, 31). From Power's perspective, the female viewer is seen as always having a heterosexual gaze, even in cases of "same-sex" viewing. Power argues that women's magazines are extremely confusing because of the mixed messages they send and the ("same-sex") desires that they encourage. Her key point is that this confusion is cultivated to boost the overconsumption of fashion items. Power also describes "the vexed role of the performance of lesbianism to titillate straight male friends", and argues that a recovery of genuine sexual enjoyment may not be possible under the present conditions of capitalism (2009, 33).

The position expressed in many of these texts is similar to critiques of the so-called heteroflexibility often represented in popular culture (Diamond 2005), which refers to the way that characters are made "temporarily" gay or lesbian but soon return to the safety of heterosexual life. Arguing against heteroflexibility, Lisa Diamond critiques instances in popular shows such as *Sex and the City*, where characters are shown to "try" homosexuality but not settle in this position. Katy Perry's song "I Kissed a Girl" has been critiqued along similar lines, for recovering heterosexuality from the otherwise lesbian narrative with the line "Hope my boyfriend don't mind it" (Onick et al. 2009, 4). What these analyses of so-called heteroflexibility miss is the important experimental space that may be provided for women to precisely "try" out homosexual desires, where no space might otherwise be possible. We might for example well imagine young women singing the chorus only ("I kissed a girl!") without realising the heterosexually recuperative lyric. Young women may use this space as a starting point for trying out otherwise unthinkable pleasures, within a context that does not make grand

demands for categorisation. Indeed, as Perry herself revealed at the Human Rights Campaign Gala in 2017, " 'I kissed a girl and I liked it.' Truth be told, I did more than that" (Britton 2017).

In each of the feminist texts discussed here, space to account for the pleasures, dangers, and complexity of "same-sex" sexual experiences, the viewing of "same-sex" bodies, and the feelings around being made object are severely constricted. Sexuality in the public sphere is seen as always disingenuous, always a performance, and often harmful. Under this rubric, there can be no lesbian ladette, no legitimate "same-sex" desire in viewing representations of female bodies in magazines, and no pleasures experienced in acts of performing sexuality publicly. Moreover, they miss the space that some scenes may make for sexual exploration and forays into new desires, *even* if within the realm of the objectifying and heteronormative.

Femininity and consumption

Lastly, it is helpful to consider how *consumption* and the postfeminist female body is also a major focus for these authors. The relationship between the concepts of femininity and consumption is not new (Bordo 1993), and indeed is intimately connected with the history of feminism's relation to femininity sketched so far. Many argue that increasingly femininity is a site of consumption (Ringrose and Walkerdine 2008), and, as touched upon, femininity under third wave feminism and postfeminism has often been seen as connected to a *celebration* of consumption (Kinser 2004; Banet-Weiser and Portwood-Stacer 2006, 269; Evans, Riley, and Shankar 2010). As queer femme ethnographer Ulrika Dahl also notes, critically, "high femininity is [conceptually] tied to wreckless consumption" (2014, 613). However, while many accounts illuminate a perspective on the relation between capitalism and expected styles of the body, they render these stylings as driven by *no more than* capitalism. Thus feminine stylings are presented as something that should be rejected because of their association with consumption, as if femininity occupies a unique position under capitalism while other gendered stylings are somehow outside of these forces. Furthermore, compassion for a new generation of young women and the attachments and pleasures they might have for either "girly" or "raunch" interests is overlooked in these analyses. Femininity is marked as intimately bound to and inseparable from capitalism, in a way that does not target capitalism per se, but rather critiques the women attached to femininity under capitalism.

For example, McRobbie focuses on the female body as sexualised for profit and catering to a male gaze; she writes: "[W]e are witness to a hyper-culture of commercial sexuality" (2009, 18). McRobbie argues that women are complicit in this regime of looking. She states that in a backlash against the feminism of the 1980s, advertisements in the 1990s played on the idea that feminism had restricted the possibility of enjoying female bodies, a pursuit now acceptable under postfeminism: "[e]veryone and especially young people can give a sigh of relief. Thank goodness, the image seems to suggest, it is permissible, once again, to enjoy looking at the bodies of beautiful women" (2009, 17). This theme of images

and looking as consumption runs throughout, with McRobbie arguing that images and modes of the visual are essential to "the formation of feminine subjectivity" (2009, 108). She argues that there is no masculine equivalent to the obsession with looking found in women's glossy magazines. Outlining the attempts of third wave feminists to recuperate and "own" particular feminine styles, she argues that "this pro-capitalist femininity-focused repertoire plays directly into the hands of corporate consumer culture eager to tap into this market on the basis of young women's rising incomes" (2009, 158). In other words, according to McRobbie, pleasure in viewing particular feminine formations is a corrupt form of consumption, and any attempt to celebrate or enjoy particular feminine stylings is complicit in the machinations of capitalism.

Power also characterises particular styles of the body as distinctly tied to capitalism. She argues that there is an increasing demand on women to show more flesh, as she writes that, to display "what they have to sell" involves an "imperative that all femininity be translatable into the logic of the market" (2009, 15). As aforementioned, Power's work is in part inspired by Marcuse (1964). Marcuse's idea is that the body absorbs and becomes an extension of the commercial world. Accordingly, Power extends this argument to an assessment of contemporary women. Though Power's focus is on wider structural issues, her critique nonetheless remains preoccupied with the "one dimensional" women of the present. She writes:

> I contend that much of the rhetoric of both consumerism and contemporary feminism is a barrier to any genuine thinking of work, sex and politics that would break with the "efficacy of the controls" that Marcuse identified. What looks like emancipation is nothing but a tightening of the shackles.
>
> (2009, 2)

Power argues that women are popularly represented as superficial and driven by consumption, and that – most importantly – women have bought into this image. She agrees with Levy's assessment of raunch culture, writing, "[Raunch culture] is perhaps not so new . . . but Levy is right that this has taken on a peculiarly pornographic taint in recent years" (2009, 32). For Power, pornography is the textual form that is emblematic of present conditions under neoliberalism. How pornography represents bodies and, in turn, how these images proliferate and are consumed in ordinary society is her major concern.

Returning to a theme of loss, Power argues that "vintage" pornography is superior to contemporary pornography because it shows a diversity of bodies, enjoyment in the activities and "genuine" emotion (2009, 53). Wishing to avoid being categorised as an anti-pornography feminist, she advocates a recovery of "vintage porn", porn that "participate[s] fully in human practice", a harkening back to a pornographic form in which bodies were seemingly real and sex was more fun (2009, 49, 52). As Power remarks of this bygone era of pornography: "All the participants genuinely seem to be enjoying themselves" (2009, 53), suggesting that contemporary pornography is devoid of similar pleasures. This is a call for a

return to a golden age of more democratic and feminist sexual entertainment, in the same vein as the more general call to return to feminist activism as also seen in Levy, McRobbie, and Walter. Importantly, critiques of the contemporary situation focus on the commercialisation of bodies and pleasures for consumption, particularly through the pornographic form. While Power presents a solution to the pornography problem she explores, her solution explicitly fixes on a return to the past – as an escape from the perceived problems of the present.

A critique of dominant consumer capitalist circulations of femininity is also evident in Walter. Walter contends that contemporary women are being compelled to conform to particular bodily and social norms, influenced by the kinds of products they are exposed to in childhood. Walter's work reinforces Levy on raunch culture while extending the question of raunch to the realm of childhood. Again the focus is on the body, in particular the exposure and shaping of the body to societal norms. She argues that feminist terminology of past eras has been appropriated through commercial processes and sold back to women, corrupting ideals such as empowerment. For example, Walter refers to an "undressing-as-empowerment rhetoric" represented by the rise in popularity of activities such as burlesque dancing. She argues that these activities do not deliver liberation, evidenced by her discussions with some burlesque performers who have left the scene (2010, 43–44). The idea that things are getting worse and that there is a crisis of sexualisation because of the products girls are being encouraged to consume are repeated throughout Walter's text. For example, she contrasts the innocent magazines of her girlhood with contemporary publications:

> While the magazines I read at school were never feminist tracts, they were not littered, as girl's magazines are now, with page after page of expensively dressed and made-up young girls exposing such skinny, airbrushed bodies. They did not so relentlessly encourage their readers to measure up to a raft of celebrities whose doll-like looks are seen as iconic and whose punishing physical regimes are seen as aspirational.
>
> (2010, 67)

Again there is a harkening back to the past, and the author's childhood memory is presented as a straightforward counter to contemporary experiences of readership.

Similarly, Levy focuses on pornography and the representation of women, also particularly in magazines, to illustrate the problems of raunch culture. She highlights the fame achieved by celebrities such as porn star Jenna Jameson and heiress Paris Hilton (who became famous following a leaked sex tape): "Paris Hilton isn't some disgraced exile of our society. On the contrary, she is our mascot" (2005, 28). Levy suggests that the hypersexuality embodied by Jameson and Hilton is inauthentic and renders women as objects for consumption by men and women alike. She writes: "The women who do go into careers outside the sex industry will never be seen by the millions of men – and growing numbers of women – who read *Playboy* as actresses or mothers or lawyers or executives; they will never be seen as themselves" (2005, 41–42). Thus the prolific consumption of

images of women leaves women identified as *merely* bodily/sexual, existing only for the purpose of being consumed. Further, Levy argues that "the women who are really being emulated and obsessed over in our culture right now – strippers, porn stars, pinups – *aren't even people*" (2005, 196; emphasis in original). Though Levy is attempting to talk here about the dehumanising effects of "raunch culture", she inadvertently reiterates the idea that these women "aren't even people". Importantly, in Levy's account women are not only being consumed, they are the consumers of this new gender regime, encouraging the perpetuation of raunch culture. Thus, in her text, we see most clearly how a critique of the perceived issues of the present is directed at individual women. Here women are not only subject to the problem, they are part of creating and perpetuating it.

Consideration of the classed elements of feminist discourse is helpful to provide a further way to understand the problems of these dominant feminist critiques here. Skeggs' investigation into ways of responding to feminine gender presentation demonstrates that "class underpins any reading of bodies on the basis of appearance" (2001, 295). As Pierre Bourdieu explains:

> The denial of lower, coarse, vulgar, servile – in a word, natural – enjoyment, which constitutes the sacred sphere of culture, implies an affirmation of the superiority of those who can be satisfied with the sublimated, refined, disinterested, gratuitous, distinguished pleasures forever closed to the profane.
>
> (Bourdieu 1984, 7)

While we often see acknowledgement of the classed elements of certain modes of femininity in feminist discourse, working-class femininity is often read as aspirational and therefore dismissed as little more than an effect of market mechanisms. For example, illustrating the problems of the beauty industry, Greer remarks: "Poorer women fake it, ape it, pick up the fashions a season too late, use crude effects, mistaking the line, the sheen, the gloss of the high-class article for a garish simulacrum" (1970, 58). While Greer's account acknowledges the ways working-class women are disadvantaged in achieving a higher-status version of femininity, which accounts for how these women are *perceived*, her account does not explore the possibility of working-class women enjoying femininity or having other experiences of femininity other than related to status failure. Similarly, McRobbie, drawing on Skeggs' work, argues:

> White working-class femininity is associated with failure, and as a result working-class women increasingly feel they need to identify with a more aspirational and glamorous femininity made available in profusion across the world of media, on TV and in magazines in particular.
>
> (2011, 68)

But while there is some acknowledgement in feminist texts that working-class femininity is often perceived as failed femininity, with lower status and respectability, this rarely reduces or changes the direction of the derision levelled toward certain

feminine embodiments in these same texts. For example, as discussed, McRobbie cites the hypersexual phallic girl, the ladette, as an example of the problem with women today. We also see in McRobbie a reading of the working-class ladette as the worst mix of the feminine and the masculine: "this is a young woman for whom the freedoms associated with masculine sexual pleasures are not just made available but encouraged and also celebrated" performing masculinity "[w]ithout relinquishing the femininity which makes them so desirable to men" (2009, 83, 84). Here it is evident that, although McRobbie takes into account the ways that femininity is classed, she does not take into account the way her critique also aligns "most problematic" femininity with "working class women".

McRobbie, Power, Levy, and Walter argue that not only are certain feminine styles always problematic and anti-feminist, they are also pro-capitalist. Though each of these authors gesture to wider structural neoliberal forces that determine particular stylings of the body, their critiques remain focused on female bodies and women themselves. In some accounts, such as Levy's, this fact is more obvious than in others, as Levy marks women as the problem par excellence with the phrase "female chauvinist pigs". What is absent is a generosity to, or even curiosity about, the experiences, attachments, or desires that might be experienced by women around femininity. These critical perspectives cannot help but reflect negatively on the women – and styles of the body – described.

Femininity lost in critique

The points of critique covered extensively in this chapter illuminate various issues for feminism at the beginning of the twenty-first century – problems to do with postfeminism, expectations placed on women and their bodies, and issues of objectification. However, as this chapter has elaborated, much of these analyses are filtered through examples and symbols that are problematically limited. Emergent across all texts, there is a strong sense that the issues with contemporary femininity are heavily connected with the female body as styled and presented in the world; that is, the current state of (lost) feminism is evidenced by the new bodily styles of women. Though the language of "raunch culture" may be used less frequently than when Levy's book was originally published, the analysis presented here suggests that at any time when discussion turns to feminism lost, the embodiment and gender presentation of women is used as "evidence" of failed activism. In other words, the emphasis is not placed on what women are *saying* (after all, they might be insisting that they are feminist), but how they *appear* publicly and what they are *doing with their bodies* in this realm. The loss of feminist sentiment is brought back to the body with the fake breast made emblematic of false or evacuated feminism. Each author is also highly concerned with the connections between consumer society and femininity but sees femininity as peculiarly tied to consumption. Here, the falsity of the "choice" to engage in raunch culture is also a concern, and the exposure of bodies in the public realm is seen as a problem of false-consciousness. Following this, public displays of sexuality are viewed by the authors as always inauthentic, with other dimensions of these encounters dismissed.

Though Levy, Walter, McRobbie, and Power should not be dismissed for being merely unhappy feminists/"feminist killjoys", the anti-feminine strands of their critiques deserve scrutiny. We must ask: in critiquing femininity, what might be lost? These accounts are restrictive in their attitude to the feminine body, creating fixed representational relationships between femininity and such ideas as loss, stupidity, danger, illness, and façade. These texts overlook or dismiss the possible capacities engendered by feminine embodiment, moments of unusual pleasure, a generous understanding of why women might remain attached to these embodiments, and an imagining of the future that does not altogether eliminate the styles of the body they describe. As the next chapter reveals, exploring femininity from different perspectives allows room for critical inquiry, while also opening up ways of seeing the kinds of phenomena described by Walter, Levy, McRobbie, and Power from a different angle.

3 Feminism without anti-femininity

Toward the end of the first decade of the twenty-first century, the discussion of feminism lost began to turn toward the question of how to resuscitate feminism. This isn't to say there was a *sharp* turn in feminist writing from 2010 onward, indeed the shift was gradual. For example, Peggy Orenstein's (2011) work *Cinderella Ate My Daughter: Dispatches from the Front Lines of the New Girlie-Girl Culture* follows very closely behind the work of Walter in discussing the "pinkification" of childhood, and Levy, in referring to the epidemic of "raunch culture". Perhaps then it is more correct to say that toward the end of the 2000s, some feminists began tracking not only how feminism had been lost, but also centring more strongly on places where feminist activism was beginning to flourish again (for example see: Appignanesi, Holmes, and Orbach 2013). For example Monica Dux and Zora Simic's (2008) *The Great Feminist Denial* considers how, despite many women actively repudiating feminism, feminist communities continue to flourish, particularly in online spaces. Though these works remain framed around the central concern of loss, they also mark a transitional period: a move from declaring feminism lost, to an attempt at feminist revival. Interestingly, since this time, though many feminist writers continue to call upon the notion of postfeminism, "raunch culture" has fallen significantly out of favour. Valenti's work *Full Frontal Feminism*, which is given special attention in this chapter, is interesting because it was first published in 2007 and re-released in an updated edition in 2014, and thus spans this shift from feminist loss to feminist renewal. As some of these texts reveal, there may be ways to articulate feminism without the pervasive anti-femininity of McRobbie, Power, Levy and Walter.

Feminism in the second decade of the twenty-first century has been (and continues to be) mixed in its approach to questions of femininity. For example there continue to be works published that focus on femininity as a signifier of oppression, such as Rhiannon Lucy Cosslett and Holly Baxter's (2014) *The Vagenda: A Zero Tolerance Guide to the Media* and Andi Zeisler's (2016) *We Were Feminists Once: From Riot Grrrl to Covergirl, the Buying and Selling of a Political Movement*. On the other hand, there have also been works such as Laurie Penny's (2014) *Unspeakable Things: Sex, Lies, and Revolution* and Laura Bates' (2014; 2016), *Everyday Sexism* and *Girl Up*, which focus on questions of sexism and how to fight structures of oppression, with only minimal concern to talk about gender presentation and femininity. Similarly Roxane Gay's (2014) *Bad Feminist*

looks less at femininity and more at practices such as enjoying popular culture. These latter texts reveal a recent shift away from focusing on women's bodies as being at the centre of the political problematic.

This chapter gives particular time to work from Valenti and Moran who have been particularly helpful in articulating a new way of talking about femininity that continues to have influence today. Specifically I consider Moran's autobiographical *How to Be a Woman* (2011) and Valenti's *Full Frontal Feminism* (2014). These texts offer a point of departure and comparison with the feminist texts considered in the previous chapters. Valenti and Moran are successful columnists, with Moran writing for *The Times* in the United Kingdom, and Valenti for *The Guardian US*. Both Moran and Valenti are highly visible contemporary public feminists, active on social media. Both authors have published other books that may have also been considered here, including Moran's *Moranthology* (which she describes as "a manifesto for joy") (2012, 14) and *How to Build a Girl* (2014), and Valenti's *He's a Stud, She's a Slut: And 49 Other Double Standards Every Woman Should Know* (2008) and *The Purity Myth: How America's Obsession with Virginity Is Hurting Young Women* (2010). However, *How to Be a Woman* and *Full Frontal Feminism* have been chosen as the authors' respective seminal texts, which serve here to illustrate an alternative approach to feminism with femininity.

Some may see the positions of Valenti and Moran as a return to or continuation of third wave sentiment (and indeed, considering the age within which Valenti and Moran emerged into writing the influence of this line of thought cannot be underestimated). However, this chapter argues that they present a distinctly different kind of sensibility to that of "girl power" and femininity as empowerment. Namely, Valenti and Moran *do not* place political emphasis on the power of femininity to change things, even as they look at how surface and presentation is intimately bound up with the political. It is a unique position that deserves careful unpacking in this chapter, to better understand the implications of this perspective for feminism's approach to femininity going into the future. Importantly, while they tend toward defending femininity on the basis of "choice", a close reading of their texts reveals that this is an unnecessary step.

Moran and Valenti as counterpoint

Moran's *How to Be a Woman* is autobiographical, and perhaps for this reason, she focuses extensively on the body with humour and irreverence. For instance she uses chapter titles such as: "I Start Bleeding!"; "I Become Furry!"; and "I Need a Bra!" (2011). Moran explicitly argues that all women can and should be feminists – for example she urges her readers to stand on a chair and shout, "I AM A FEMINIST" (2011, 72). This is in contrast to Valenti, who uses her experiences to illustrate points but only in between lengthy issue-based discussions. In other words, while Valenti provides a *guide* to feminism, Moran provides a feminist *memoir*. As Jennifer Anne McCue notes of Moran's use of this approach: "The memoir does not discriminate or determine how to be a feminist, but rather allows for broader understanding and acceptance through raising important issues, both

personal and political" (2014, 9). This type of work has also been a feature of books by popular feminist celebrities in recent years (for example see: Fey 2011; Poehler 2014; Dunham 2014). Despite Moran's popularity, she has been criticised by other feminist authors such as Gay, who writes in *Bad Feminist* that Moran's work hides casual racism (with Moran comparing her reclamation of "feminism" to reclamation of the term "nigger" in black communities) under a veil of humour, and as such deserves greater critique (2014, 104). Moran also frequently refers to the science of sexual difference in terms of neurological brain imaging and evolutionary hard-wiring, as underlying the gender binary: a view of gender that feminist authors such as Walter spend much time challenging (2010, 129–238) and that certainly ought to be interrogated.

Notwithstanding these significant problems, Moran's style and approach allows for a different view of femininity than that offered by Levy, McRobbie, Power, and Walter. Given that Moran's work emphasises play, fun, and enjoyment with a focus on the body throughout, her argument being that these elements are crucial to determining the feminist agenda, it is readily unpacked using an affective approach. Moran's account highlights the imperfections and failings as well as the pleasures involved in her experience of femininity, making it an ideal text to reveal queer dimensions of femininity. The personal nature of Moran's work allows for a greater understanding of the attachments at play in embodying feminine styles of the body. Her work opens up femininity to affirmation, generous understandings of feminine embodiment, and the imagining of a feminine feminist utopia, surprisingly without reducing the personal to *the* political.

Similarly, though publishing her guide to feminism slightly earlier than Moran Valenti is often identified as part of the third wave of the feminist movement. Her work documents and reflects the changes that took place in feminism in the later part of the twentieth century (Renegar and Sowards 2009, 2). Valenti also refers to herself as part of this wave, insofar as the wave can be said to exist:

> The third wave (which I suppose I'm part of) also has a bunch of unsavoury stereotypes attached to it. We're supposedly the flighty, unserious feminists. 'Cause we like makeup and heels and talk about pop culture. Silliness.
>
> (2014, 179)

Described as a "pop culture feminist" (Armstrong, Hamilton, and England 2010, 23), Valenti's style is informal and she includes frequent expletives. This is a method that Sara Mills and Louise Mullany note "breaks down traditional language and gender stereotypes", also helping her engage with a younger audience (2011, 32).

Valenti has been celebrated for her aim to make feminism more appealing to encourage a new wave of youthful, enthusiastic feminism (Lee 2009, 129, 625). Stylistically, *Full Frontal Feminism* reads as an address to the audience, encouraging, discouraging, and informing the reader on various topics. As Michelle Miller reflects on the book: "It seamlessly melds theory and practice together, relating them through politics and Valenti's personal experiences" (2008, 19). Miller also

describes the work as a guide to feminist activism that is simultaneously "empty of any potentially alienating feminist theory" (2008, 19). *Full Frontal Feminism* reads as a manual for young women interested in feminist activism. This is in contrast to the popular and academic texts of Levy, Walter, Power, and McRobbie, who offer critiques rather than explicit guides (though notably Valenti praises Walter's work). Valenti is also well known as the founder of popular blog Feministing. She started Feministing in 2004 because she was "working for a national women's organisation and was feeling like the mainstream feminist movement wasn't really interested in hearing younger women's voices" (cited in Baumgardner and Richards 2010, 340).

In response to Valenti's success, she has been criticised for being a popular White woman who identifies as heterosexual and embodies conventional beauty standards. In other words, Valenti's privileged social position has been pointed out by some commentators as a limitation to her contributions (Dux and Simic 2008, 68). For this reason it might be asked why these texts by Moran and Valenti have been chosen for comparative inclusion, given that their authors do not diverge from a norm of White (ostensibly) middle-class femininity. This decision is precisely because Moran and Valenti fulfil the criteria of femininity critiqued by the feminists outlined previously. Though they identify *explicitly* as feminist, Moran and Valenti can also be grouped with the women subject to critique in the texts examined in chapters one and two. That is to say, they are part of a new generation of young women who endorse normative feminine embodiment in their own presentation (even as they may remain critical of it). This has led to their "feminist" credentials being dismissed or disparaged (Dean 2012, 319). For example, as noted earlier Power derides Valenti as part of the new wave of "positive, up-beat feminists" that she warns against (2009, 1).

Importantly, I do not wish to argue that either of these authors is *exemplary*. Rather, the perspectives that they offer, and the form in which they are communicated, serve as a good basis for the exploration of other theoretical approaches to femininity. Here we might take seriously people's identifications while maintaining a critique of the theory and politics that are frequently built around these identities. The texts by Walter, Levy, Power, and McRobbie on the problems of the feminine body are limited because they draw clear and narrow boundaries around how the phenomena of femininity might be approached. This is similar to Dean's observation that the focus on loss in many feminist texts has led to "erasing the possibility of a more hopeful affective orientation towards the feminist present" (2012, 320). In this way, the focus on the negative aspects of the feminine body (including in relation to the theme of loss) limits the possibility of an affective, queer, generous yet critical – perhaps even utopian – orientation toward femininity.

The key difference between the text considered here and the texts considered previously is that Moran and Valenti place minimal emphasis on the body – specifically feminine styles of the body – as *the site* for change. Though Moran discusses the body at length, for example focusing on menstruation, sex, and

pregnancy, she does not identify it as the primary site of political transformation. Similarly, Valenti discusses issues such as sex and pregnancy but only focuses on the body as a site for change insofar as she argues for a structural overhaul of how society shapes and controls women's bodies (for example, with abortion laws). Both texts emphasise the potential of the feminine body, its queer possibilities and the pleasures to be had, while remaining critical of cruel promises, and the need for a different mode of enacting the present. In this way they serve as useful texts for illustrating a different approach to the femininity that does not accept the logic that contemporary feminine styles of the body ought to be inscribed with negative values, nor indeed that they are representative of a crisis that must involve critiquing women themselves.

Affirming the present: potential, play, and joy

In chapter two, the substantive focus of the feminist authors discussed was on the negative and unhealthy aspects of the feminine body in contemporary society. This is a position that – despite centring on the body – relies on the foregrounding of representation rather than physicality, feelings, or sensations. Attending to affect offers a way to move beyond this representational focus, instead looking to the pre-cognitive, bodily, and sensate (Seigworth and Gregg 2010; Puar 2011). Applied in this context, an affective lens suggests that we put aside asking what the feminine stylings of femininity *mean* (are they good/are they bad for feminism?) and instead consider how we might reconceptualise femininity – what can the feminine body *do*?

Moran's *How to Be a Woman* it is a good case study for what an affective approach to femininity might look like. Moran acknowledges the relevance of materiality through discussions of things such as makeup, lingerie, and other fashion items. Moreover, she illustrates the affective assemblages between object and flesh that constitute "woman", and considers objects not simply as add-ons that foreclose female possibility but instead imagines the potential that these intertwinings between flesh and accessories might open up. She therefore produces a nuanced critique of femininity under present conditions, which offers flexibility rather than prescriptive rules. Moran asks new (affective) questions about old (bodily) problems. For example taking a unique approach, Moran rejects the mythical notion that feminists are bra-burners to discuss the bra extensively as an object full of bodily potential, troubling where skin ends and material begins. Moran remarks, "[W]ith the right bra you can put whatever is left of your mammaries into them – maybe with the help of a spade, or loved one – and they will mould the raw material into two lovely lady-lumps" (2011, 100). While at face value this sentiment might seem to suggest a normative approach to forming the appropriate female body through the bra as a tool, Moran goes on to reveal that the bra is not simply about control but *possibility*. She remarks of her breasts:

> On their own, I'd just be kicking them in front of me, like an overly long dress. But with a Bra, I can place them anywhere. . . . If I don't have my

> contact lenses in, they could end up anywhere. I fully expect to leave the house one day, hungover and in a hurry, with my tits on my head.
>
> (2011, 101)

Moran's approach to breasts is in direct contrast to Levy's, Walter's, Power's, and McRobbie's, as she imagines the unruly nature of her breasts and the potential to control and shape them – make them – through the use of the bra. Here the breasts have a fun-loving quality to them, which departs from the focus on the fake "idiotic" breasts seen in chapter two.

It is also evident here that Moran uses humour to explore issues – indeed, as Littler notes, Moran attempts to reinvigorate feminism "through comedy" (2013, 239), a tendency also noted by Anthea Taylor (2013, 760). Rather than seeing Moran as merely using humour to "sell" her feminist ideology, we might see the way that she uses humour to affirm the possibilities of the feminine – as made emblematic here in the figure of the unruly breasts and the welcome bra – rather than dismissing the bra along moral lines. This is not to say that the feminine accoutrement of the bra is deemed as always good or necessary under this approach. Along these lines, Ahmed also argues notably for the necessity of silliness in any account, even that of the killjoy. As she writes: "To embrace silliness is to embrace affects that would not ordinarily participate in an affirmative or happiness ethics" (2010a, 222). Ahmed's point seems to surround the "freedom" to be unhappy, to express anger and critical judgement, and enjoy silliness and the unexpected. However, as we have seen, this aspect of openness is missing from the accounts analysed in chapter two. In contrast in Moran's work, silliness is fundamental. We see the object of the bra cast in another, humorous, light – the assemblage of the bra'ed-body – and we are made to altogether rethink our assumptions about what is "good" and what is "bad".

We can take from Moran that it is our *approach* to the bra'ed-body that warrants reconfiguration. Moran advocates for rejecting that which limits bodily capacity, but contends that capacity might at times be enhanced by bodily encounters with items such as bras. Indeed, capacity becomes her central framework for assessing what is "good" versus "bad"; for instance, she writes on the topic of choosing shoes that enhance rather than hinder her capacities. As Moran expresses it: "That's the minimum I ask from my footwear. To be able to dance in it, and for it not to get me murdered" (2011, 205). Similarly, on the subject of taking off a particularly painful bra, Moran recalls: "I would *hurl* it to the floor, and rub the red welt that it had left, like a monk tending the after effects of a cilice belt"; but later on the same page she states, "bra is my friend" (2011, 102). We see here a shift away from a search for meaning, reason, or discrete answers. For Moran there are "bad" bras – those that would reduce bodily capacity – but this does not entail a prescriptive approach that would suggest bras are *always already* bad. Further, the striking element of this is the focus on the assemblage between the body and object. The "bad" bra is said to leave a "red welt" on Moran, a reminder of the blurred boundaries created through this particular relationship, where the material takes on an agency of its own. This resonates with Kathleen Stewart's

commentary on agency, which she describes as "not really about willpower but rather something much more complicated and much more rooted in things" (2007, 86). Moran writes: "As one would expect from an item capable of such powerful magic, sometimes the bra is prone to suddenly turning evil and attempting to destroy you" (2011, 101). Echoing Power's account of breasts, but construing this in a neutral if not positive light, the bra is at once an object separate from the body with its own active capacities, and an object that concomitantly melds with the body.

The importance of joy in this account of the bra becomes apparent in Moran's discussion of the pleasures of unravelling the interlacing of body and object. Peeling off the bra as if shedding a second skin becomes a ritual: "[I]t is almost impossible to describe the sheer raw pleasure that comes with taking off certain bras" (Moran 2011, 101). In taking this perspective, founded on questions of bodily joy, Moran presents a critique of sexual expression within society that allows a more nuanced approach to what has otherwise been labelled "raunch". Furthermore, Moran emphasises joy as the evaluative tool par excellence, commenting that strip clubs, for example, aren't problematic because stripping is *inherently* bad, but because "there's no self-expression or joy in these joints" (2011, 172). For Moran, joy is essential to defining feminism: "Any action a woman engages in from a spirit of joy, and within a similarly safe and joyous environment, falls within the city-walls of feminism" (2011, 174). Feminine accoutrements such as bras do not function as *signifiers* of the bad (or good), but as items that contain within them a kind of (unlimited) material possibility for transformation.

Valenti makes a similar case for what she terms "feel good feminism". With regard to sexual displays of the body she prioritises the question "Does it feel good?" (2014, 7, 59). Valenti's "feel good" approach sits in conflict with the work examined in the previous chapters which marks positive feelings as unreliable and associated with a kind of false-consciousness. Like Moran, Valenti also uses humour as a way to open up issues for reconsideration, the humour being most evident in the titles that she gives to the discussion of serious topics such as "If these uterine walls could talk" (an allusion to the 1996 film *If These Walls Could Talk*) for her chapter on the policing of women's bodies in legislation in the United States (2014, 85). Given that Valenti's work is intended as a "young woman's guide", it eschews the kind of elaborate descriptions employed in Moran's memoir. Valenti's work is more focused on discussing issues such as "sexual harassment" rather than offering an autobiographical account of these kinds of experiences and the sensations and feelings involved. However, Valenti's approach remains sympathetic to the desires of women – who might be otherwise described as "female chauvinist pigs" by Levy – focusing on pleasure as central to her feminist appraisal. She writes: "Wear high heels, mascara, and whatever else you want. I sure do"; and "Have orgasms. By any means necessary. ☺" (2014, 251, 246).

While stressing pleasure, Valenti's account also emphasises the importance of having *consciousness* about the kind of activities and accoutrements that are enjoyed, and in this way her text remains tied to the representational. The problems of adhering to a representational meaning-driven approach are made

apparent in the updated 2014 version of *Full Frontal Feminism*, in contrast to the more "raw" expression of the original edition. For example, Valenti explains that since the previous edition the cover design has changed:

> The original art – featuring a toned white stomach with the book's title scrawled across it – centred a particular kind of woman as "feminist" and perpetuated the idea that feminism is largely for white women. At the time, I looked at the cover image and thought of Kathleen Hanna [of punk band Bikini Kill] writing the world "SLUT" on her stomach. I thought of it as reclaiming the female body.
>
> (2014, 2)

The new cover shows a white brick wall spray-painted with the title, "feminism", appearing in pink, cursive writing. The change, and Valenti's inclusion of an explanation of it, reveals her desire to get the representation "right", even though the new cover does not remove the possibility of visual critique (perhaps only a blank cover or no cover at all could remove this risk entirely). What we see is the elimination of the body, albeit a White "normative" one, as a correction – a setting-things-straight. Valenti seems to chide her younger self for being so foolish on this front, and on many other aspects of the original, despite its great success. Here we see that Valenti's approach, though different to the other texts discussed, still remains tied to concerns of representation. Regardless of Valenti's corrections, the body of the work as a whole remains affirmative in the sense that it does not devalue or disregard femininity and instead makes a case for women to embrace themselves, their bodies, and their modes of gender expression.

Queering the present: failure and pleasure

There are also queer dimensions evident in Moran and Valenti's reflections that highlight the unexpected pleasures of femininity. As discussed in chapter two, Levy, Power, McRobbie, and Walter cast the exposed female body against a heterosexual framing. This posits a pervasive male gaze even where a female viewer is engaged (the "female chauvinist pig"). This sees female "same-sex" interactions as locked into a heterosexual bind whereby (public) lesbianism is seen as always performed for the benefit of men. However, utilising an approach that recovers possible sites of queer pleasure as well as queer failure (Halberstam 2011) enables a different reading of these presumed unhealthy performances of female heterosexuality. Such sites of pleasure and failure are clear in the work of Moran and Valenti.

The theme of failure is sustained throughout Moran's work, and her descriptions of moments of rupture reveal a queer underbelly. Returning to Moran's description of breasts, she writes: "If I don't have my contact lenses in, they could end up anywhere. I fully expect to leave the house one day, hungover and in a hurry, with my tits on my head" (2011, 101). A queer analysis of this segment connects us with Halberstam's (2011) focus in *The Queer Art of Failure* on the opportunities

that things going "wrong" can engender. While, on the one hand, Moran can be seen to support the normative benefits of the bra as helping to sculpt the body into an acceptable shape, on the other she leaves us imagining radical new possibilities of the body arising humorously and unashamedly through mistake.

In Moran's account, it is not the breasts or bra per se that are the sites of a problem of reinforced normative restrictions. Cloth is inextricably melded with flesh; in fact, the bra yields pleasures that might be overlooked from the feminist perspectives considered previously. This is strikingly apparent in her discussion of lingerie, which again evokes a sense of the affective blending between object and body:

> So let us hymn a while on lingerie . . . French knickers in peach satin, with ruffles all up the back. Cami-kickers in outrageous colours, flashing under basques: kingfisher blue; rose-red; gold, like the wedding ring on the floor. The frothing, cloudy, egg-white joy of tulle. The way silk slip-slides over you, like a sheet of oil. Watching the blood rush through the semi-visibility of lace. The black line from calf to thigh. The hook-and-eye, with flesh swelling beneath. Torn buttons. The hem.
>
> (2011, 93–94)

Here Moran reflects on her lingerie-clad body, previously cast as a site of potential failure, as simultaneously a site of pleasure that deserves a "hymn". Interestingly, Moran's sentiments are echoed in Rachel Wood's study into women's lingerie-wearing practices, which found that women's experiences were diverse and included feelings ranging from anxiety to playfulness (2013). Moran's description hints at the naughtiness associated with undergarments, which for her yields pleasure – the "wedding ring on the floor" signifying extra-marital sex; the "egg-white joy" suggesting the possible pleasures of being fragile and vulnerable; "blood"; "the black line"; "flesh"; "torn buttons" operating to induce an allusion to bondage and sadomasochism – all adding up to a queer sense of the joy to be found in dangerous sex, sex that is not "vanilla", that does not align with normative understandings of heterosexual monogamous sex as "making love", which we might otherwise imagine.

Most importantly, pleasure here is found in the relation between object and body; a heterosexual pairing need not be present. Moran's ode to lingerie exists as a relation of her lingerie-dressed body to itself. Rather than reducing the reader's pleasure and enjoyment of descriptions of the feminine styled body to a narcissistic male gaze (that of the "female chauvinist pig"), we can read this scene as queer rather than simply heteronormative. This is a queer sexuality that evacuates the need for a man, let alone the male gaze; the only external gaze present is that of the reader of Moran's hymn. This connects with Halberstam's work in *Gaga Feminism*, which suggests that we ought to "turn our attention to the heterosexual woman, who, after all, so often has been forced to function as a model of conformity, a symbol of subjugation and the whipping girl for anything that goes wrong with sexual morality" (2012, 82). Interestingly, a quote from Levy is included on

the front cover of *Gaga Feminism*, which reads: "[A] Provocative and pleasurable romp through contemporary gender politics, *Gaga Feminism* is as fun as it is illuminating". This serves as a reminder that the text (*Female Chauvinist Pigs*) and author (Levy) are separate, and while the text stays still, the author does not. Halberstam remarks: "Going gaga means letting go of many of your most basic assumptions about people, bodies, and desires" (2012, 27). Reading Moran's scene, then, as an act of Gaga feminism where heterosexuality is disrupted and ruptured, allows for an altogether radically different understanding of femininity as one that is full of queer potential rather than mired in inauthentic performance.

On a related note, Valenti acknowledges and makes a case for "same-sex" pleasures and the re-reading of sexual experiences that are claimed to be inauthentic by other feminist perspectives. The feminist texts discussed in chapter two suggest that women are forced, under "raunch culture", to perform a fake version of homosexuality. But as Valenti notes, dominant understandings also judge sex as real or not real depending on the presence or absence of a penis. In other words, Valenti highlights how sexual experiences often aren't seen to "count" as real sex if they occur between two women. While Levy, for example, marks "same-sex" encounters in the public sphere as always false performances for a male audience, Valenti points out a general blind spot in relation to female "same-sex" sexual activity. Along these lines, Valenti makes an argument for claiming the positivity of the word "slut", and specifically endorses queer sluttiness. She writes: "So should lesbians rest assured that they're not the nasty sluts their hetero sisters are? If I get oral from every girl on the block, am I slutty? (Or just smart?) Sorry, it makes me crazy that whether I'm a whore is completely dependent on cock" (2014, 36). On the question of false performances of sexuality, Valenti also makes a case that performing can be part of the pleasure to be had: "Sometimes performance can be a cool thing when it comes to sexuality", also stating: "If you want to show your tits just for the pure fun of it – go for it" (2014, 56, 57). On this note, in specific response to Levy and her analysis of *GGW*, which posits women as peculiarly at the mercy of the male gaze, Valenti interrogates assumptions about the false-consciousness of the women involved, instead arguing for the possibilities of pleasure in this realm. Valenti comments: "Levy says that the joke is on us, and that we're really just fooling ourselves"; and, further, on *GGW*: "Do we really have to be on point and thinking politics *all* the time?" (2014, 49, 50; emphasis in original). Valenti questions Levy's assumption of the false sense of empowerment with which women enter into the displays of sexuality described, but further suggests that it is okay to sometimes put aside a sense of knowingness: that we might sometimes fail as feminists and simply take pleasure in the present. Despite Valenti's suggestion that one ought not to *have* to be "on point" at all times, she does make a somewhat contradictory claim that "choice" of one's actions is key. In making this argument, Valenti is also pointing out that "same-sex" displays cannot simply be reduced to a performance that is always false, and indeed she argues that the kinds of displays that Levy critiques might indeed yield queer pleasures, or at least be exciting experiments in sexuality. She writes: "While a lesbian make-out session may be a fake

expression of lust to some, it's an awesome, authentic experience to others, so if you want to make out with a girl, go for it. It's about the consciousness behind your decisions" (2014, 54). With the problem of "choice" aside for a moment, what Valenti presents here is an affirmation of the possibility that what might seem fake to some is enjoyable and real for others – and that this differentiation cannot be determined from the outside.

Like Valenti, Moran encourages her readers to try different forms of sexual and gender expression, but she focuses less on *consciousness* than on *joy*. In evaluating strip clubs, Moran centres her ethical analysis around a question of pleasure; she writes: "[T]here's no self-expression or joy in these joints . . . inside them, no one's having fun" (2011, 172). This same perspective allows Moran to argue that, although strip clubs aren't "good", activities like pole dancing and stripping can be – a point that seems contradictory, but makes sense in light of her ethical evaluation, based on the principle "so long as women are doing it for fun" (2011, 174). Valenti remains more cautious, though similarly suggests: "[I]f you're going to 'go wild', think about why you want to. If it's honestly for your own pleasure and enjoyment, cool beans" (2014, 246). What these two authors have in common is that they focus on seemingly heterosexual women, attending to their possible adventures in finding joy and pleasure and queer experiments in sexuality. In this way, Moran and Valenti are Gaga feminists, of the kind Halberstam describes: "This punk or wild feminism hints at a future rather than prescribing one; it opens out onto possibilities rather than naming them; it gestures toward new forms of revolt rather than patenting them" (2012, xiii). Specifically on the topic of interviewing the celebrity Lady Gaga, Moran expresses similar views to Halberstam. Evaluating Gaga as a model for a queer and powerful feminism, she writes, "Gaga is not there to be fucked. You don't penetrate Gaga" (2011, 260). Far from seeing Lady Gaga as a vacuous pop star subject to the dominant paradigm of consumer capitalism, Moran highlights the queer ruptures she engenders. Though the authors offer critiques of some of the scenarios one might encounter – such as entering a strip club where "no one's having fun" – any evaluation of what is "bad" is related to overarching structures and is based on an affective evaluation of what women can *do*, rather than seeing the "badness" as signified by the body of the individual woman herself. In this way they queer the discussion of the "straight" girl, by making room for her to be considered otherwise.

Can femininity be utopian?

As we have seen so far, Moran and Valenti produce an affective ethics and re-read the "straight" girl of Levy's, Power's, McRobbie's, and Walter's critiques, offering insights into the value of pleasure in particular. This focus on pleasure – what feels good and indeed "knowing" what doesn't – can, and possibly should, be interrupted. The affirmative positivity of these accounts can be called into question using Lauren Berlant's thesis of cruel optimism. Berlant describes cruel optimism as occurring when desires are antithetical to "flourishing" (2007, 1). From this perspective we can challenge Moran and Valenti's emphasis on pleasure

and personal desires, given that these attachments might inadvertently contribute to the problem of women's oppression. Indeed, this is the critique of individual women that Levy provides. By terming women "female chauvinist pigs", she argues that women have become attached to promises of empowerment through raunch despite it being ultimately bad for them. Further, an ethical evaluation based on feelings and sensations (what *feels* good) might be problematic insofar as we risk precluding a political focus or wider social critique if all we attend to are individual desires and emotions. As Berlant writes in *The Female Complaint*, the danger of focusing on emotion as the ultimate guide to what is good is that:

> This very general sense of confidence in the critical intelligence of affect, emotion, and good intention produces an orientation toward agency that is focused on ongoing adaptation, adjustment, improvisation, and developing wiles for surviving, thriving, and transcending the world as it presents itself. (2008, 2)

In other words, Berlant warns against adopting an orientation that simply adapts to toxic circumstances, rather than challenging them.

However, while we may take some issue with Moran's and Valenti's pleasure principle, they do not fall into the trap of ignoring structural issues that Berlant warns of. They provide structural analysis of the present, which indeed attends to problems rather than falling into an affirmative spiral. The difference between the mode of critique that Moran and Valenti offer and those of the previous chapters is that the former locate the problem not in the feminine body but in a broader social structure. There is a different target used for the site for change. While Power, Walter, McRobbie, and Levy take into account structural features of oppression to some extent, in their accounts the feminine body is used as the main signifier of the social problems at hand. In contrast, Moran and Valenti deliver critique with a more generous approach to the individual women who might embody or replicate particular norms, while focusing on a broader picture. For example, rejecting the terminology of the "female chauvinist pig", Valenti discusses the ways that sexual women – "sluts" – are in fact punished in society, for instance where laws dictate that unmarried women do not have control over their bodies in the same way married women do (2014, 108).

Moran and Valenti appear to value and indeed unpack the attachments that women (themselves included) have to femininity. They are generous to the ways individuals might take up aspects of femininity – such as wearing makeup – while maintaining a broader critique, such as on the problems of the beauty industry. For example Valenti notes: "I'm a fan of makeup and heels" (2014, 180); yet she discusses at length how the beauty industry promotes consumerism and unhealthy and unrealistic standards (2014, 214). Valenti manages to condemn this industry while allowing room for individuals to engage with it, without judgement. Specifically, she highlights the cruel optimism of the beauty industry without holding back: "It's important to remember why some folks need us to feel ugly. It serves a specific purpose: to make us spend, to distract us, and ultimately to make us

disappear" (2014, 215). This argument echoes Berlant's suggestion that we ought to pay heed to the kind of attachments that constitute the present and, in particular, that help maintain the present. Rather than targeting the individual, Berlant suggests looking at the everyday attachments that support a problematic system, but looking at these broadly rather than specifically. As she writes in the introduction to *Cruel Optimism*: "This book thinks about the ordinary as a zone of convergence of many histories, where people manage the incoherence of lives that proceed in the face of threats to the good life they imagine" (2007, 10). In other words, the normative, which has been the focus of so much academic critique and focus, ought to be considered differently, as a set of attachments and promises:

> [*Cruel Optimism* is] an account of normativity that sees normativity as something other than a synonym for privilege. Rather, in my view, to understand collective attachments to fundamentally stressful conventional lives, we need to think about normativity as aspirational and as an evolving and incoherent cluster of hegemonic promises about the present and future experience of social belonging that can be entered into in a number of ways, in affective transactions that take place alongside the more instrumental ones.
>
> (Berlant 2011, 167)

While Levy, McRobbie, Walter, and Power clearly attend to a set of "false" promises that assist in maintaining the problematic postfeminist raunch culture that they target, these promises are considered via female embodiment. In contrast, Berlant's intervention takes the pressure off individuals burdened with their attachments to a notion of the good life, and refocuses on the wider picture. Similarly, Valenti acknowledges women's attachments to the problematic aspects of femininity, while her analysis does not target their forms of embodiment as part of the problem. This approach also resonates with Stewart, who argues, "Ideologies happen. Power snaps into place. Structures grow entrenched. Identities take place. Ways of knowing become habitual at the drop of a hat. But it's ordinary affects that give things the quality of a something to inhabit and animate" (2007, 15). Here, Stewart reflects upon the elements of life that provide structure – identity formations and so on – but suggests that it is the affective dimensions that "give life" to the everyday. In the same way, Moran and Valenti discuss the wider structures of life that impinge upon women but give time to describing the sensations and feelings that animate the experience of being "woman".

Furthermore, Moran and Valenti highlight areas of life in the present that we should not readily accept. For example, Valenti focuses on gendered violence as one key issue. She writes: "We're so accustomed to seeing violence against women that it's become normalised. We accept it as an inevitable fact of life, rather than an epidemic that we need to fight on a large scale" (2014, 66). Yet even in offering this view, noting that individual women might not pay much attention to the issue, she recognises the attachments that might be maintaining this status quo – namely that it's scary for women to face how bad things really are. She writes: "Maybe it's just too difficult to acknowledge that as it stands, we're

not safe anywhere" (2014, 67). Overall Valenti paints a picture of a bleak society where many laws and standards have negative effects on women, such as laws about abortion, marriage, and rape in the United States, but she acknowledges how difficult it is to fight these institutional controls on women. Valenti uses all of this to illustrate the toxic present that requires feminist intervention; as she states: "The fight is far from over" (2014, 82). Similarly, Moran reveals her personal attachment to wearing fashionable clothes in the chapter "I Get Into Fashion!", yet remains critical of the "imaginary woman" of the fashion industry, arguing that clothes aren't really made for actual bodies (2011, 211). She talks explicitly about having to "learn" to be fashionable, and how fashion items such as designer handbags function to reinforce status; she comments on how her proclivity for the cheap and practical is "just further confirmation that I am resolutely of the underclass" (2011, 207). Meanwhile Moran points out the structural issues involved in maintaining women's attachments to fashion, without admonishing the enjoyment of fashion. As Berlant reminds us: "The neoliberal present is a space of transition, not only between modes of production and modes of life, but between different animating, sustaining fantasies" (2007, 261), and indeed Moran and Valenti highlight "sustaining fantasies", directing their criticism at the wider social structures that maintain them, not at the women who entertain these fantasies.

In application, Berlant's work encourages attention to the attachments involved in maintaining the present, the potentially cruel optimism involved in these attachments, and the structural elements that sustain problematic fantasies. But what are we to do with this present, and how might we move toward the future? The work of José Esteban Muñoz is a useful complement to Berlant here, as it provides an orientation toward seeing utopia in the present, as a mode of splitting, resisting, and transforming. Muñoz presents us with a "politics of the here and now" that is not mired in a focus on the negative aspects of practical realities (2009, 10). Muñoz's method of finding the utopian, or reading the utopian in the present, revolves in part around the notion of astonishment. The theme of astonishment is present throughout Moran's work in particular, as evidenced by exclamations at the end of her first eleven chapters such as: "I Am Fat!" (2011, 103). Each of these titles evokes a sense of astonishment as Moran moves throughout various life stages from: "I Start Bleeding!" to "I Encounter Some Sexism!" (2011, 15, 119). Moran's sense of surprise in these ordinary life experiences recalls Muñoz's description of the importance of "astonishment in quotidian things" (2009, 5). Moran's astonishment functions as the spark for each chapter's elaboration of and exploration into the ordinary elements of her own life. She explores her past but also her imaginings for the future and for how things might be different. For example, "I Start Bleeding!" explores her realising her own sexuality and ends on her desire to see pornography where women enjoy themselves: "I just want to see a good time" (2011, 39). She provides a critical analysis of the present – "It's the porn *industry* that's the problem" – and encourages readers not to feel bad – "pornography is just 'some fucking', after all" – but also explores a utopian vision of what pornography could be – "[I]magine if it were about desire" (2011, 35, 38). Moran's point can be linked to the argument made by Power, who argues

for more "authentic" pornography to fill our screens. The difference is that Power argues for a return to a golden age of "sweetness and silliness" and a lessening of the "hardcore obsession" (2009, 56). In contrast, Moran argues for a wilder future sex, "a fuck so spectacular, all-encompassing, cinematic and intense" as to represent the kind of sex that she says she herself has experienced (2011, 38–39). While Power argues for a nostalgic return, Moran argues for a vision of the future, a glimpse of which she has experienced in her present.

Muñoz's idea that "the future is in the present" is also seen in Valenti. Valenti's "full frontal feminists" are perhaps the equivalent of Muñoz's "sexual avant-gardes", whose work he explores in detail as the vanguard for utopian thinking. At the end of Valenti's book she outlines "Five Ways Full Frontal Feminists Are Bucking the System", describing women who are currently making space for women and for the debate around feminism (2014, 254–255). For example, Valenti discusses rock camps for girls that have started up in Oregon, stating: "Full frontal feminists rock out" (2014, 255). In this way Valenti highlights possibilities for the future that are already perceptible in the present. We might liken this strategy to that seen in Walter, who, as discussed in the previous chapter, also highlights contemporary feminist projects that show promise for a more hopeful future. However, in Walter's account the overarching frame involves the rekindling of and return to a feminist past. While Walter looks to the past for hope in the future, Valenti looks to the future in the present.

Affirmation . . . or liberalism?

Though the works of Moran and Valenti function as good examples in this discussion of different ways to approach femininity, it is helpful to further consider how they interact with the perspectives outlined in chapters one and two. Returning to the perspectives of other feminists can serve as an important counterpoint to the claims made by Moran and Valenti and can sustain dialogue on these issues. Viewed through Ahmed's call for feminists to kill joy, some gaps can be identified in Moran's and Valenti's approaches which highlight why they are not "better" texts than the ones previously analysed, but differ in important ways.

How might Power, Walter, Levy, and McRobbie respond to the work of Moran and Valenti, who so readily champion a particular style of the body as congruous with feminism? Power explicitly questions Valenti's positivity and the extent to which she is complicit in endorsing capitalist modes. Power's perspective would also challenge the way Moran, though acknowledging her "underclass" status readily accepts the accoutrements of the beauty industry under capitalism. Walter might object to Moran's admission in the chapter "I go lap-dancing!" that "this chick has an arse like heaven" (2011, 168) for its seemingly unashamed objectification of women. Levy might reject Moran's contention that "pole-dancing, or lap-dancing, or stripping, aren't inherently wrong – it's just some dancing. So long as women are doing it for fun. . . . Feminism is behind you" (2011, 174), and might highlight this as a new, problematic approach to feminism. Levy might also object to Valenti's argument that it might be okay at times for women to get their

breasts out – and even enjoy this activity – for cameras or otherwise. McRobbie might question Moran's claim that particular sex work, like stripping, is "just some dancing", rather than stopping to acknowledge the historically gendered power dynamics and economic realities that encourage women to join this line of work in the first instance. McRobbie might also encourage us to acknowledge the race-related elements of these texts and the White feminist milieu under which they are produced. In sum, the previously outlined approach might seek to challenge the extent to which being sexual or normatively feminine in ways found traditionally appealing to men can *actually* be congruent with the promise of liberation, the *actuality* of feminism.

All of these points are useful to keep in mind, so as not to too readily champion Moran or Valenti as superior or unproblematic. Both Moran and Valenti demonstrate a liberal endorsement of "choice", which ought to be questioned. For example, *Freedom Fallacy: The Limits of Liberal Feminism*, edited by Miranda Kiraly and Meagan Tyler, criticises the kind of liberal feminism evident in Moran and Valenti along the lines that "there can be no freedom, no liberation, when the available choices are only constructed on the basis of gross inequity" (2015, xii). However, while the feminist critiques outlined in chapter two offer some analysis of feminist liberalism, they predominantly centre on the false-consciousness of women themselves, inadvertently targeting individuals rather than broader structures. While Kiraly and Tyler critique feminist liberalism on the basis that "liberation cannot be found at a purely individual level, nor can it be forged from adapting to, or simply accepting, existing conditions of oppression" (2015, xii), what they do not recognise is the necessity for adaptation as a mode of survival. Importantly, Moran and Valenti offer both an endorsement of adaptability *and* a critique of the wider machinations of oppression. Nevertheless they do not avoid going "Gaga" as Halberstam would have it: "Gaga feminism advocates for being the fly in the ointment, the wrench in the machinery, the obstacle to the smooth, the seamless, and the quiet extension of the status quo" (2012, 141). Moran and Valenti demonstrate adaptation, but not resignation.

Feminism, not lost

Crucially, what all of the criticisms that might be made of Moran's and Valenti's work have in common is that they adhere (as criticisms) to the representational understanding of what being a feminist or what inhabiting spaces of normative femininity or embodying feminine styles of the body *means*. Instead, as this chapter has outlined, it is helpful to take a break from the representational politics of feminism to consider affective and queer dimensions evident in these works to see what being feminist and feminine can *do*. As elaborated, Moran and Valenti focus on joy, capacity, possibility, structural limitations, and hope, all of which open up spaces where flesh and objects are refigured as agential in new and exciting ways, where queer desires are acknowledged, and where attention to transformative possibilities is focused on. For Moran and Valenti, feminism is not lost in the feminine body. Breasts are pleasurable and humorous objects, rather than

being seen as symbolic of a lost era of activism. Performances of sexuality, or experiences of sexuality in public, are imagined as possibly exciting rather than inauthentic. Feminine styles of the body are not dismissed for their relationship to consumption, but the *capacities* engendered by fashion and beauty objects are highlighted instead. Despite the history of feminism's attachment to critiquing feminine styles of the flesh as outlined in chapter one, Moran and Valenti embrace rather than reject feminine styles of the body and champion feminism *anyway*.

Though Moran and Valenti turn to a model of "choice" to justify adopting feminine styles of the body, this defence becomes unnecessary when we shift focus from *meaning* to affective *doing* and queer *feeling*. In other words, the need for justification falls away when we move from meaning making to examining the affective and queer dimensions of femininity as illustrated in Moran's and Valenti's work. While some see the present as having lost all hope and thus look to an imagined past to find optimism for the future, Moran and Valenti look for the future via the now. The main point of difference is that while Moran and Valenti are generous to individuals and critical of wider structures, other strands of feminist have seen these two elements as inextricable, with individual embodiments needing to be tackled at the micro level. Clearly, these approaches elicit important (but very different) sets of questions, tactics, and conclusions. Furthermore, while some are attached to a model of feminism past, Moran and Valenti are attached to feminism in the present with its openings and uncertainty – its shifting "gaga" elements – that can be folded into a feminist future.



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

4 The invisible femme

The problem of reading femininity as always already coded along lines of oppression becomes strikingly apparent when we consider the experiences of those identifying as queer femme within the LGBTQ community. In this chapter I explore why femme highlights a need to revalue and rethink the possibilities of femininity, through looking at the issue of invisibility experienced by many queer femmes, who are not recognised as queer either within LGBTQ or heterosexual spaces. Analysis in the following chapters focuses on scholarly and popular writing on femme, as well as interviews conducted with self-identified femmes in Sydney, Melbourne, and Canberra in Australia in 2013. Interview data is read here in combination with other texts, in order to mix cultural and textual analysis with the study of people's perspectives on their own identities and experiences.

Twelve interviews with self-identified queer femmes were conducted as part of this research, which function as rich and dynamic texts alongside the existing texts on femme. Participants were recruited through femme networks online and through advertising at the Sydney Femme Guild's *Unpacking Femme* conference in 2013. The interviews were semi-structured, following a recursive conversational model of interviewing (Minichiello et al. 1995). This allowed participants to self-guide the discussion toward issues they felt were most relevant to their queer femme identification, though some questions were prepared ahead of time to help start conversation. These questions included, for example: "In as much or as little detail as you like, what does queer femme mean to you?"; "What is your relationship to queer femme or how do you relate to the term queer femme?"; "What is it about the identifier femme that is appealing to you (if at all)?"; and "How do you think about femininity in relation to queer femme?" The target participant group involved individuals aged over eighteen who self-identified as queer femme.

The interviews allowed room for an empathetic understanding of the femme perspectives, but as someone also employing the identifier, produced a kind of distance as I discovered how others talk about femme. This allowed me to see femme – an identity I had been identifying so strongly with – through different eyes. When I first set out on this project, I believed that I would find femme provided an antidote to the assessments of femininity that have come from the feminist perspectives, as explored in the first part of this book. However, as I delved deeper into femme discourse, I noticed that femme distanced itself from "normal"

femininity in a way that was *not* at odds with the limiting feminist critiques of "raunch culture" and certain ways of defining "postfeminism".

Discussion begins with a broad examination of how and why queer femininity has remained largely unthinkable even within queer theory. I then consider how the issue of invisibility plays out for femmes and how this contributes to an emphasis on representational strategies that inadvertently feed back into femme marginalisation. The following chapter looks in more detail at how femme's connections to feminist discourse paradoxically contribute to devaluing femininity. The final chapter in this section proposes a way of understanding femme that attends to its sensate and material dimensions as a way to try and overcome the idea that bodies must always be enrolled in a politics of identity.

Queer theory's attachment to masculinity

Before turning to consider work on queer femme identity, it is important to note that one of my main aims is to challenge queer theory's broader tendency to overlook femininity. As Dahl suggests:

> One could argue that the current dearth of research on femmes reflects a continued broader contempt for femininity, or at least that the "normative" feminine aesthetics associated with both femmes and women more broadly conjure up less fascination than more visible gender transgressions do.
>
> (2014, 608)

Not only is femininity largely absent in queer theorising outside of discussions of queer femme, but where it is considered it is generally only read as subversive or as something of interest for queer theoretical investigation if analysis is framed in terms of masculinity. In other words, the potential for seeing femininity as anything other than already oppressed is *only* read relative to a flipping or inversion of gendered expectations, where femininity continues to be understood as a masquerade (McCann 2013). For example, while there are countless instances of queer theory texts attending to ostensibly feminine icons, this usually occurs with reference to terms such as "camp" and "drag", which suggests identifying an underlying masculinity. For example, many have analysed popular country singer Dolly Parton in terms of drag aesthetics (see discussion in Patrick 1997) rather than centring her queerness around a peculiar female femininity; this is in spite of the fact that, as Rosi Braidotti notes, Parton herself claims: "It's a good thing I was born a woman, or I'd have been a drag queen" (1996, 2). Figures such as Mae West and Madonna have also frequently been analysed in terms of the aesthetics and practices of gay male subculture (Robertson 1996) and more recently, Lady Gaga has been discussed as epitomising the parodic and ironic elements that constitute queer camp (Horn 2010). All of these accounts focus on stars who are ostensibly demonstrating extremes of female femininity, yet what is seen as interesting or "queer" about them is understood in terms of masculinity. As Halberstam argues, it is femininity that is the source of shame for both gay

men (in their embodiment of "the sissy") and lesbians (in their "failure to become properly feminine") growing up (2005, 226). The abundant lack of queer focus on femininity demonstrates that this "shame" associated with femininity that Halberstam describes persists within the academic community.

Indeed, there is a lack of terminology for understanding female femininity outside of discussions of camp or drag – terms historically connected with discussions of *male* performances of femininity. Ferreday explains that feminine excess is always read as crossing over into masculinity:

> By aspiring to the iconic status of a Marilyn Monroe, the woman who assumes that she can cope with an excessive "high-maintenance" look is heading for a fall. She is destined to exceed her boundaries, to "bleed everywhere" and ultimately to embody an abjected form of masculine cross-dressing.
>
> (2008, 56)

In other words, where "femaleness" is understood as exaggerated this is seen as a gender crossing toward the masculine, without reference to the feminine. Though it has been argued that camp is not gender specific (Horn 2010, 6), as Susan Sontag writes in the seminal *Notes on "Camp"*, camp is a sensibility related to gender *crossing* or "going against the grain of one's sex" using artifice and exaggeration such as "corny flamboyant femaleness" and "exaggerated he-manness" (1982, 108). However the term is most commonly used in reference to gay male subculture and the connection between camp "taste" and homosexuality is often referred to (Robertson 1996, 3; Horn 2010, 2). As Biddy Martin notes, there is "a tendency to assume that when [femininity] is not camped up or disavowed, it constitutes a capitulation, a swamp" (1996, 73). In other words, where femininity is not overdone (to the point of being read as involving a masculine layer underneath), it is seen as submissive to oppressive gender norms.

While a small number of theorists such as Mimi Schippers have called for "the feminine other [to be placed] in the centre of a theory of gender hegemony" (2007, 86), such theorisations are scarce. Furthermore, where femininity *has* been explicitly theorised in terms of its queer potential, masculinity is still often perceived as a crucial element. Schippers' own work on femininity, for example, employs the term "pariah femininities" to describe those femininities that are "contaminating to the relationship between masculinity and femininity" (2007, 95). Pariah femininities involve women adopting stereotypically masculine traits that challenge gender norms, for example, a woman expressing violence. Although Schippers focuses on femininity, her theory essentially suggests that female *masculinity* is the key to gender subversion. We might also note here that where discussion has been directed toward the topic of male embodiments of femininity, these portrayals are often positioned as subordinate or *alternative masculinities* rather than being described in terms of the feminine (Newton 1972; Schacht 2000; Taylor and Rupp 2004; Connell and Messerschmidt 2005). In these accounts too, femininity is a mark of submission to a hegemonic norm, whereas masculinity is understood as a dynamic and potentially queer embodiment. Although there have

been theorists such as Leo Bersani who have called for a refiguring of the radical aspects of subordinate positions (1987), this call has largely failed to manifest into wider examination of the queer potential of femininity.

A history of femme texts

Lillian Faderman's historical analysis *Odd Girls and Twilight Lovers* is one of the earliest texts to discuss femme identity at length (1991). As Faderman outlines, femme identity emerged as a "white working-class lesbian subculture" as early as the 1920s, though was most prevalent in the 1940s and 1950s (1991). As Rebecca Jennings details, this scene did not easily extend to places like Australia until the 1960s, with smaller populations providing less capacity for public spaces to emerge around lesbian identity (2015, 53).

A reinvigoration of butch/femme occurred in the 1980s, largely emerging in response to lesbian feminist politics where there was a rejection and erasure of questions of radical sexual politics, desire, and roleplaying within lesbian communities (Carter and Noble 1996). In response to this debate, theorists such as Gayle Rubin called for a place for thinking and speaking about sexuality outside of these feminist discussions (1984). Around this time, explicit articulations of butch/femme desire began to emerge (Nestle 1992). Following shortly after this, *The Persistent Desire: A Femme-Butch Reader*, edited by Joan Nestle (1992), is often cited as the central work highlighting the need to take seriously butch/femme identity in feminist and queer realms in the contemporary era (Albrecht-Samarasinha 1997; Walker et al. 2012; Eves 2004; Dahl 2014; Rosario et al. 2009; Levitt and Hiestand 2005). Nestle later described the rationale for *Persistent Desire* as the 1982 Barnard Conference on Sexuality, the height of the so-called feminist "Sex Wars" (Duggan, Hunter, and Vance 1985). At this conference, a number of butch and femme identifying women were shamed by anti-pornography feminists for their sexual practices. Nestle writes:

> We needed this vast archive, I believed, because one of the goals of *Persistent Desire* was to reconstitute lives fragmented by the small-minded, by those trapped by gender or class conventions, by those so taken with prevailing ideologies of liberation that they repeated new mantras of dismissal.
>
> (2011, 17)

The collection explores the history of butch/femme identities, and personal reflections on desire, relationships, sex, and gender presentation from people identifying as butch or femme. As Sue-Ellen Case writes: "This is a book guided by the principles of community-based scholarship, as established in lesbian herstory archives and grass-roots histories" (1993a, 79). This mode – collected personal reflections on butch/femme identity – is replicated in almost all subsequent books on the topic. Since this time, discussions of queer femme identity have gained some prominence, though much of this still remains on the margins of LGBTQ agendas.

There is a great deal of intertextuality between publications on femme, with titles and contents often referring to older texts (which can make them difficult to discuss and discern from one another). Following Nestle, Leslea Newman released *The Femme Mystique* (1995), a reference to Friedan's *The Feminine Mystique*. Like Nestle's work, this comprises a collection of personal reflections but focuses solely on femme. Reflecting on *The Femme Mystique* Connie Carter and Jean Noble argue that:

> Many of the pieces gathered under this title reiterate the pain and confusion of that moment for dykes who identified as femme. It seems that for many, femme is structured by a painful split between femme and lesbian identities. (1996, 26)

This split, and the sense of marginalisation experienced in lesbian communities, is also echoed in later reflections on femme. Laura Harris and Elizabeth Crocker's subsequent title *Femme: Feminists, Lesbians, and Bad Girls* consists of essays from a diversity of femme-identifying women (1997). The lesser known *Butch/Femme: Inside Lesbian Gender*, edited by Sally R. Munt, was also published the following year with greater focus on the butch/femme binary (1998). Munt describes the motivation for the collection as emerging from "my own frustration with the apparent lack of critical work on butch/femme emanating from Lesbian and Gay Studies or Queer Theory" (1998, 1). Around this time femme was also being discussed – though not focused on – in work on butch identity such as Halberstam's *Female Masculinity* (1998), and in fiction pieces such as Leslie Feinberg's *Stone Butch Blues* (1993).

Away from the trend of investigating femme through multiple contributors, *A Femme's Guide to the Universe* has a sole author, Shar Rednour, who focuses on "life skills" for femmes, including romance, cleaning, and cooking (2000). *Brazen Femme: Queering Femininity* followed, edited by Chloë Brushwood Rose and Anna Camilleri, returning to the collected multi-author approach (2002). *Brazen Femme* consists of poetry, essays, and other forms of reflection on femme identity, and includes some of the same contributors as *Persistent Desire*, for instance Amber Hollibaugh. Brushwood Rose and Camilleri attend to the way femme has been "made manifest" in the writing of women in the lesbian community, citing Nestle, Dorothy Allyson, Jewel Gomez, Chrystos, and Minnie Bruce Pratt (2002, 13). Released in the same year, *Femme/Butch: New Considerations of the Way We Want to Go*, edited by Michelle Gibson and Deborah Meem, is a collected series of reflections on femme (2002). In their introduction, Gibson and Meem described butch/femme as styles of "lesbian gender", and despite acknowledging the history of femme distancing itself from lesbian-feminism, describe themselves firmly *as* feminists (2002, 4, 8). Notably the majority of the femme texts have emerged from North America, predominantly the United States. Thus not only is femme distinctly Western in its origin and circulation but it is specifically formulated in a United States context. As one local participant at the Femme Hive Conference in Berlin remarked to me: "You are lucky in Australia, you import the femme politics from America faster than we do".

With a growing distance from the original split between butch/femme and lesbian-feminism, post-2002 there is a trend in the literature toward a reintegration of femme into a new language of feminism, meshing queer theory with ideas of a new feminist era. *Femmes of Power: Exploding Queer Femininities* demonstrates this integration and continues the growing trend of considering femme as a concept separate from butch (Dahl and Volcano 2008). Furthermore, *Femmes of Power* focuses heavily on the aesthetic and academic aspects of femme. Co-editor Dahl's background in academia is evident as she curates the femme excerpts according to concepts drawn from queer theory. For example, the chapter titled "Epistemology of the Femme Closet" references Sedgwick's *Epistemology of the Closet* (1990), and "Copies without Originals: On Femme Drag" is a reference to Butler's work in *Gender Trouble* (1990). *Femmes of Power* is thus indicative of the growing trend of framing femme in relation to queer theory as well as to new conceptions of feminism. While earlier works were created as a response to a perceived lack of attention to butch/femme identity, *Femmes of Power* marks itself not simply as a *response* to a gap in knowledge, but as an integral *part* of current queer and feminist conversations. Also notable here is the documentary *FTF: Female to Femme* (2006), directed by Kami Chisholm and Elizabeth Stark, which explores the emerging femme scene in San Francisco. This film places femme within a language of queer theory, positioning it as a queer gender category.

Similarly, the reflections included in the two volumes of *Visible: A Femmethology* edited by Jennifer Clare Burke refer to concepts that place imaginings of femme against and *within* dominant queer and feminist discourse (2009). In both volumes, the front covers use an extreme close up of red lipsticked lips with a stubbled upper lip, combining familiar signs of the masculine and feminine in an image of a single face. The back cover also refers to challenging "LGBTQI community . . . prejudice" and to considering intersectionality emergent from earlier feminist discourse, as keys to understanding femme (Burke 2009). Similarly, *Persistence: All Ways Butch and Femme* (Coyote and Sharman 2011) identifies itself as breaking down the butch/femme binary. The front cover image depicts a person, with short hair and a neck tattoo that reads "butch", applying pink lipstick. The back cover states: "The stories in these pages resist simple definitions. The people in these stories defy reductive stereotypes and inflexible categories" (Coyote and Sharman 2011). The foreword by Nestle describes *Persistence* as a kind of sequel to *Persistent Desire*, albeit produced by the voices of a new generation. Nestle claims that a new generation of queer voices has led to a proliferation of identities who "have cast off the anchors" (2011, 21). The influence of queer theory and feminist texts of the 1990s is evident throughout the reflections, with references to Halberstam, Butler, and indeed Nestle's work as forming a butch/femme canon. Unlike *Persistent Desire*, *Persistence* contains no images of people from the butch/femme community, only written reflections. *Persistence* reflects the increasing challenge of adequately representing femme, a theme discussed in more detail shortly.

Only a limited number of journal articles have been published on femme. They do, however, follow a similar chronological trajectory to the books in terms of a split from lesbian feminism and then a return to the feminist femme. There was some proliferation of academic interest on the topic of femme specifically between the early 1990s and late 2000s, with works increasingly promoting it as a uniquely queer and feminist identity (Dove-Viebahn 2007; Dahl 2010; Walker et al. 2012; Dahl 2014). This is with the exception of research done within the field of psychology, where articles continue to reflect on butch/femme without recourse to feminist or queer theory (see for example: Rosario et al. 2009; Levitt, Gerrish, and Hiestand 2003; Levitt and Hiestand 2005). Earlier works sometimes use the terminology of "lipstick lesbian" (Bell et al. 1994; Clark 1991). This term was used before the resurgence of popular reference to femme. Earlier articles on the topic of femme consider it relative to butch and hint at the need for discussing these identities as marginalised by the broader queer community (Walker 1993). Lisa Duggan and Kathleen McHugh's "A Fem(me)inist Manifesto" is often cited as a key article in defining femme, and covers similar ground to Harris and Crocker's *Femme*. Here, femme is a response to a lesbian feminist orthodoxy that promotes androgynous style over enjoyment of femininity (1996, 154). As Alison Eves explains in her exploration of femme identity in queer spaces: "The feminist critique of beauty discourses and practices has privileged an androgynous style and contributed to a suspicion and misunderstanding of femme and feminine lesbians" (2004, 490). Case's chapter in *The Gay and Lesbian Studies Reader*, "Toward a Butch-Femme Aesthetic", is also frequently cited in academic work on femme. Here, Case describes the importance of "bring[ing] the lesbian subject out of the closet of feminist history" (Case 1993b, 295), noting the same problems for lesbian-feminism as had sparked Nestle's *Persistent Desire*. While works by Duggan and McHugh, Case, and so forth inform the background of my work on femme in important ways, they are not, as a group, the focus of analysis. These works are relatively inaccessible to non-academic parts of the queer community; thus it is the butch/femme *books* that are more frequently mentioned (and sometimes sold) at community gatherings on femme or queer identity. As described below, books on femme are frequently mentioned by femmes as keys to understanding and "discovering" the term.

Given my own identification as a queer femme woman, I have also taken part in several community projects on femme identity, providing overviews of my views on femme across several formats. Therefore included in my discussion is analysis of two personally produced texts on femme identity (outside of academia): a video filmed for the Canberran queer women's radio show *Friday Night Lip Service* ("*FNLS* Event 1 – The Canberra Femme Collective Spring Picnic at Floriade" 2012) and a short memoir piece, "Finding Femme", published by online feminist journal *Feminartsy* (McCann 2015a). These works demonstrate ideas on femme similar to those found in the literature and expressed by interview participants. They illustrate that I do not sit as an "outsider" to the research and that any criticism of the dominant discourse of femme reflected in this book is also applicable to my own personal descriptions of femme.

What is femme today?

In the context of the early twentieth-century lesbian bars, femmes were expected to pair up with more masculine "butch" partners (Dove-Viebahn 2007: 73; Dahl 2010: 146). More recently, the term has become conceptually untied from this binary pairing with a masculine other. Femme today is used within LGBTQ communities as an identity term that refers to embracing feminine gender presentation in some form or another, which does not rely on who you are attracted to, partner with, or have sex with. Dahl provides a helpful definition of femme culture:

> The contemporary femme movement, if it can be called that, consists of lesbians and other queer sexual subjects, most but not all of who identify as women and above all, to whom feminine gender expressions and the politics of visibility and femininity are central to their body politic.
>
> (2014, 607)

Though there is only limited literature on the topic as outlined here, much of what is written about femme comes from the archives of personal experience. In this, we find an emphasis on the intentional, political, and subversive aims of femme identity. Speaking with those who identify as femme reveals that they feel invisible within both the LGBTQ community and the broader community, where they are always viewed as "straight". Within these spaces, the femme who presents as "normatively" feminine is inevitably read as heterosexual. Femmes face criticism and marginalisation in multiple realms because of their perceived femininity.

Despite this, there is a notion circulating in some feminist and queer commentary that femme lesbians are in fact *the most* acceptable form of LGBTQ embodiment (Halberstam 1996; 2011). This view is closely related to the pervasive notion that public intimacy between women is a celebrated feature of "raunch culture" (Levy 2005; McRobbie 2009). For example, Halberstam argues that the popular show *The L Word* erases butch identity and reflects acceptable lesbian identity as distinctly femme. Halberstam writes:

> What *The L Word* must repudiate in order to represent lesbian as successful is the butch. The butch therefore gets cast as anachronistic, as the failure of femininity, as an earlier, melancholic model of queerness that has now been updated and transformed into desirable womanhood, desirable, that is, in a hetero-visual model.
>
> (2011, 95)

While representations of lesbianism as seen in *The L Word* may indeed exclude the figure of the butch, it is not clear that it makes space for femme either. Indeed, as historians of butch/femme argue, butch/femme presentation has generally been adopted by working-class women, and rejected by upper-middle-class lesbians (Faderman 1991; Dove-Viebahn 2007; Ward 2009), of the kind represented in *The L Word*.

In any case, the idea that femme is the most celebrated form of lesbian identity is highly questionable when considering the norms that operate in LGBTQ communities, not just on television shows. This is not to deny the benefits that femmes might also enjoy in "passing" as straight, as historically butch queer women have been subject to greater discrimination on the streets and in the workplace due to their gender presentation and sexuality (Levitt and Horne 2002; Levitt and Hiestand 2004). However, it can be said that femmes also generally experience discrimination, not just invisibility, within lesbian communities (Nestle 1992). This is sometimes described as "femmephobia" (Blair and Hoskin 2015; Stardust 2015). Butch women in queer communities are often subject to homophobia in the broader community, but paradoxically this also entails a certain level of recognition *as* queer. Laura Harris and Elizabeth Crocker note that "the very visibility as lesbians that makes butches targets of homophobia in public space also makes them more visible as 'real' lesbians" (1997, 2). This point however ought not to be used to pit the stakes of femme identity against that of butch. Indeed in many of these conversations the underlying *common* experience of homophobia is often forgotten, and butches are positioned as erasing femmes or vice versa (as Halberstam's point intimates). Though homophobia unmistakably plays out differently for different persons, the feelings of exclusion from "normal life" experienced by butches and femmes alike surely are connecting to a common root. Where butches visibly fail the imperative connection between sex and gender, clearly breaking expectations and thus signalling "queer", femme *appears* to meet the rule thus failing to signify otherness. The femme encapsulates both the inauthenticity and façade straight feminine women are assumed to embody, and thus remains inconceivable as potentially queer.

Appearance and the invisible femme

Because femme fails to signify a breakdown between the expectations of sex and gender as related to sexuality, many femmes associate femme identity with *appearance*. Yet in spite of reports of invisibility, many femmes describe the identity as involving a peculiarly "queer feminine" look. As Dahl writes: "To most femmes I have interviewed, a feminine aesthetic – that is, clothing, garments, accessories, make-up and so on, is central to a femme expression" (2010, 146). Here the importance of appearance to identifying as femme can also be understood as connected to more general anxieties about aesthetics in the queer community. As others have argued, there are many concerns with appearance and body image to be found across LGBTQ communities (Atkins 1998). Of the self-identified femmes I interviewed, all spoke about the visual elements of appearance connected to representing their femme identity. Paradoxically, many of the femmes simultaneously emphasised that femme was *not* all about appearances. As Julia expressed:

> I've had very short hair and I don't think that you need long hair to be femme, or you can't be femme if you have a shaved head. Like it's at once about appearance and then at the same time not at all about appearance.

Participants sometimes alluded to an innate inner femme-ness that was independent of feminine appearance. For example, as Monique stated, "Whether I'm wearing jeans and a t-shirt and no make-up . . . I'm still femme". These sentiments clearly express that femme is understood as an *identity*, not just a *style*, and that as an identity it therefore must exceed mere appearance.

There was also a strong sense from femme participants that visual elements are key to communicating queerness, with so-called heterosexual feminine aesthetics seen as a general hindrance to being able to communicate effectively. For instance, as Monique identified: "[P]articularly when you look feminine, you're more likely to be seen as being a 'tourist'". Here, Monique referred to the perception that if you are feminine presenting you are not fully "committed" to queer life, and that you might leave and rejoin the non-queer world after a brief visit. Gemma also expressed: "[B]ecause I know that I'm never going to be read as queer, in a more traditional sense . . . I feel like I really have to turn up the volume on my femme, so that there's . . . so that I do get noticed". This difficulty of expressing femme despite how queer one feels on the inside – thus having to "turn up the volume" – suggests how femme can be seen as *at once* and *not at all* about appearance. In other words, though the femmes felt that their identity was deeper than their surface appearance, they also recognised that their gender presentation was the main and most immediate way to communicate their identity to others. Despite Barbara's Creed's claim in 1995 that "[t]oday, with the liberating influence of queer theory and practice, almost any form of dress is acceptable" (1995, 102), the idea of "anything goes" was not reflected in the feelings of the femme interviewees, who consistently reported feeling invisible and/or rejected within LGBTQ spaces.

As Rebecca Ann Rugg notes, there is a dilemma for femmes between looking the way they want and presenting an image that communicates how they feel (1997, 188). Rugg argues that "props do matter; they can be a means to power" (1997, 188). The tension here seems tied to the question: how does one communicate a rebellion against gender norms through the repetition of normative codes? Dahl sums up this concern in her statement:

> In a heterosexist world that continues to tell us that femininity is the ultimate available object for universal consumption and contempt, taking a stand on and through (queer) femininity, as we all do and know, is both intense pleasure and clear and present danger. Who will understand and who will misread?
>
> (2008, 18)

Here Dahl clearly locates the problem of miscommunication in the perceiver and not the perceived, making the issue of femme identity rest – at least in part – on being *correctly* understood. As Monique commented: "I'm still femme, but I may not be read as such, but that's a sort of external thing rather than an internal thing". However, as Samantha Brennan reflects on her experiences as a young woman identifying as lesbian, "Fashion achievements require the right community. It

can never be an individual enterprise" (2011, 127). Brennan adds that "fashion is essentially communicative and what's possible as identity will depend in part on what identity categories exist in the community in which you find yourself" (2011, 127). Though some accounts posit that invisibility is a result of incorrect or unfair ways of seeing in LGBTQ communities, Brennan's remarks remind us that it is inescapable that there are certain communicative codes that we exist within. Following this, the question becomes: how can we shift these codes, so that people see differently?

Along these lines, of changing perceptions, many femme communities around the world advocate explicitly for femme visibility. For example, the Australian Sydney Femme Guild motto is: "Visibility. Solidarity. Celebration" (2016); and the Femme Hive group in Berlin describe one of their key functions as: "[C]reating dialogue, visibility and allyship for femme" (2015). Many of the participants talked about not "fitting in" to the lesbian or queer scenes where they lived; as Chloe stated: "I've had someone say 'oh no no, you can't be a lesbian, you just don't look like a lesbian. Lesbians don't look like you'". Or, in the case of Liz: "You can go to some things and just feel like you're not a real lesbian, or you're not a real queer". In the stories of the femmes there is a sense of a crisis of queer legitimacy particular to their gender presentation. As Chloe also remarked:

> I guess being queer makes me conscious of my gender identity as well. Because lots of my friends who are straight, they're feminine but they wouldn't even question that they're feminine, like "yeah, of course I'm feminine, I'm a girl". Whereas, I think I could not be feminine. So then why am I feminine? And I'm aware of being different from other lesbians sometimes. Like I walk into, like a lesbian group, often I won't really look like everyone else. And I kind of wonder, yeah, why that is.

Femmes often find themselves caught in a divide: their queerness is unrecognisable as anything other than performance in the straight world, and their femininity is unrecognisable as legitimate in the lesbian/queer world. As Gemma stated: "I think it shouldn't be anyone's business, how I identify or who I have sex with, but it is, and I don't really know how to piece that together yet. Notice me!"

This theme of anxiety relating to not being noticed as queer was pervasive throughout many of the interviews. As Chloe suggested: "It's hard to be feminine and still scream out 'queer' sometimes. So I feel like if I don't do something special then I might just be not noticed. Like people think I'm straight I guess". This idea was also very much related to a weariness or frustration over having to "come out" frequently, as Monique stated: "[I]t is frustrating having to kind of clarify things with people, or to be put in the position where you have to 'oh, I have to come out again'". Some femmes like Monique reported that it was easier to be understood as queer when with a partner: "It's a lot more easy to be visible when there's someone to be visible with". For femmes, there is a problem of being invisible within typical lesbian/queer contexts, given a pervasive lesbian/queer norm operating that sees femininity as not properly queer.

It is important to note, however, that in the interview data there were two exceptions to the persistent concern with invisibility and recognition. This included one trans participant, Rachel, who discussed the desire to live in "stealth" and to avoid visibility around their gender and sexuality – their desire for recognition was not to be noticed as different, but rather to be perceived as normal. The other was a participant, Ana, who was critical of the focus on hypervisibility which they felt worked against feminist critiques of objectification. As Ana stated: "[B]eing able to be vocal [is] more important than being visible". Ana also suggested that their primary queer "home" was not to be found in the femme community, but rather in queer people of colour groups. As they reflected:

> I think that we, in the people of colour, queer people of colour groups that I work with, we already have a really strong diversity of genders and gender presentations and I don't feel like I need to have femme visibility there.

These two exceptions raise an important point that while "visibility" is a central concern for many queer femmes, this is not applicable to all, particularly when intersectional considerations around gender and ethnicity are also taken into account. Indeed, as Dahl highlights in her examination of "vintage" styles in femme communities, modes of representing femme sometimes inadvertently harken to the normative adornment of imperialist and nationalist pasts (Dahl 2014). While "visibility" emerges as a key part of dominant femme discourse, these two alternative perspectives also reflected in the interviews highlight the need to interrogate the emphasis on visibility and recognition in femme discourse.

Strategies of representation

Despite the important exceptions to concerns over visibility (which I return to shortly), a general "unease" with femme identity was evident throughout many of the interviews. This was not only related to a sense of rejection in the queer/lesbian community, but also a feeling of sadness about femininity being an unshakeable veil of "normality" in any context, forever refracting any sense of queerness. As Gemma expressed:

> I guess that maybe someone who is femme and queer and someone who is easily read as queer, we just have different battles, that's all. . . . I really cannot even imagine just walking around the world and people *already knowing* that about me. Like already being like, "oh well", and maybe that's a terrible thing to have someone be like, "yeah I know that person's queer or they're a lesbian or whatever" but I will probably never know that, what that feels like.

The issue of visibility communicated by many femmes reveals issues of recognition, and for many femmes raises the question: how does one *represent* femme? Though many emphasise invisibility as an act of misrecognition on the part of the receiver,

many femmes also continue to express a desire to sufficiently represent their femme-ness in order to assist in the reading process.

Along these lines, many of the femme participants described specific representational strategies for communicating femme identity. For participant Julia, part of her approach involved getting a tattoo that included the word "Femme":

> I got it [the tattoo] about three years ago I think. And at the time . . . I just wanted something to be there kind of permanently because I was so frustrated with trying to express my femme identity. And yeah I just wanted to say look this is who I am, and it's on me and it's not going anywhere. I think that was a big part of making it easier as well, because I didn't feel like I had to constantly . . . be pushing . . . my label out onto people. I could just kind of have it there and then people who get it get it, and you know people who don't go "oh, it's French" [laughs].

Similarly responding to the issue of communicating queerness and trying to make space in lesbian/queer communities, some femmes advocate a strategy of appropriating heterosexual femininity with "mistakes" to signify queer difference. As Chloe stated: "I feel like being feminine in a more theatrical way, like making a statement can kind of be interpreted as queer". As Freeman suggests, many femmes have taken up forms of "temporal drag", repeating styles from eras past to highlight their purposive attempt at subverting present-day norms (2010, 62). Rebecca Ann Rugg also refers to strategies of queering femininity as "something wrong with this picture", the practice of which, aside from fashion choices, may involve presenting as typically feminine but with other signifiers of nonconformity such as tattoos and piercings (1997, 186). Looking for strategies of self-presentation is seen as a way to overcome the need to continually come out and inform people, an act viewed by many femmes as laborious, frustrating, and discriminatory.

Many of the participants reported negative feelings even when attending community events specifically for/targeting queer femmes, where they felt anxiety about being inadequately femme. As I myself experienced at one femme conference, one feminine-presenting attendee put up their hand to ask, quite earnestly, "What is femme?", and they were subsequently shouted down by another person in the audience who did not read them as a potential "femme". Instead they were told they ought to "do their homework". This example reveals that although femme is seen as an identity that is largely internal, it also involves a particular "knowledge" and ability to articulate that subject position. As the example of the woman in the audience asking, "What is femme?" shows, however, is that as communities solidify around identities such as femme, so too do rules of identification congeal. While this audience member may well have discovered femme at another time and felt that it was a descriptor that fit with her feminine presentation yet queer feelings, in the context of the femme conference she was told that she was an outsider to femme, lacking the sufficient knowledge of the identity for it to be a space she could occupy.

Many of the interview participants noted that they often had to be very explicit in verbally *stating* their identity in order to be recognised, as Chloe for example illustrated: "I find that people always assume that I'm straight, so I usually have to say [I'm not]". Yet despite these pressures and negative feelings of not being recognised, many of the femmes were adamant that they would continue their feminine gender presentation. As Chloe stated: "I think this general area [LGBTQ politics] is very focused on being yourself. And I always felt like, if I'm going to be myself, I just shouldn't be what everyone else thinks I should be". In other words, despite the difficulty of negotiating and appropriately "knowing" femme identity, many femmes were keen to persist with the gender presentation that had led them to consider themselves femme in the first instance.

Despite communicating a deep attachment to their identification, many participants also reported that they adopted different styles when first entering the LGBTQ scene. In particular, many femmes talked about their hair and the changes they made when they first came "out", with short hair seen as a key signifier for identifying as a queer woman. For example, Daria described cutting her hair short when first coming out as a lesbian:

> I wasn't really as scared as I thought I'd be, but I think it was sort of a symbolic thing, yes, I'm ok with this, I'm ok that I'm gay, and I'm comfortable with people being able to tell. Yeah so it was really cool. It was kind of like a catharsis sort of thing. But yeah it was a bit scary at first, not having any hair. It was a bit weird. But, yeah it was a good feeling.

For Daria and many of the others, having short hair was the signifier par excellence of queer female identity. The expectation that lesbians have short hair has been noted by many (Hall 1986; Faderman 1992; Valentine 1993; Zipkin 1999; Krakauer and Rose 2002) and can be understood as the underlying factor that informed participant decisions to present differently when first out. Daria described the tension of identifying as femme, but also wanting short hair to assist in her recognisability as a queer woman: "Sometimes it's hard having short hair. . . . I feel like I want to look more feminine than I do". Reflecting on this focus on the visual in discussions of femme, Gemma also stated:

> This is the first time in my life I've ever had long hair, like I've always had short hair but I've still been femme. No matter what. Like I think there's *something* in the image stuff, but it's probably not as important as like maybe it *feels* like it is. It's just, probably an easier way to process, as something visual.

For other participants, identifying as a "fat femme" was an essential part of their queerness. Here, being "fat" yet "feminine" functioned as a visual indicator of queerness. As Liz identified:

> Femme for me is about being a fierce fat chick too. It's not just about the thin privilege, or the idea of what a woman is in its perfected constructed social

> sense. And so that's another one of my bits of femme [laughs] is y'know like being in a different body. Being in a different body and being sexy in that feminised body. Despite what all the dominant culture's messages are, about what is ok or beautiful or sexy, as femininity or femme.

The term "fat femme" has been brought into sharp focus by sites such as Bevin Branlandingham's Queer Fat Femme Guide to Life (2015). Branlandingham connects her identification as fat as essential to her identification as femme, as she explains on her page, "Why Queer Fat Femme?":

> None of these identities exists in a vacuum. Coming out as fat made being femme possible, which made being queer make more sense to me. Acknowledging an intersectionality of identities – both privileged and marginalized – is very important to me. Other ways I identify: Feminist, currently able-bodied, grew up working class, currently artist class, white, ally, a daughter, a friend, culturally lesbian, community leader, activist, Capricorn.

The idea of fat femme identification has great traction in the femme world, with many community groups organising their own fat femme meet-ups, and broader femme groups using images of fat (but often otherwise traditionally feminine-presenting) women in their group materials. For example, the Femme Hive Conference that I attended in Berlin used fat femme imagery in much of their advertising. Such imagery has often been used as a signifier of femme in an attempt to reject the idea of a "normative" thin feminine woman. As Piepzna-Samarasinha states in the "Femme Shark Manifesto!": "Femme sharks don't think anorexia is cute. We think eating a big-ass meal is sexy" (2011, 286). Just as many queer women have traditionally used short hair to signify crossing gender and thus sexuality, there is also now a sense that presenting as fat femme means inherently breaking from the boundaries of normal femininity, and therefore representing an essentially queer position. This is also undoubtedly connected with a broader trend in feminism toward considering the politics behind – and radical and resistant possibilities of – fat identity (Murray 2004; Murray 2005; Murray 2008; Cooper 2010; Cooper and Murray 2012; Saguy 2012).

However, despite the space that recognition of fat femme provides, the danger of *prescribing* how to represent femme contains the ever-present risk that subversive signifiers will be reabsorbed into mainstream norms. As Butler reminds us:

> Just as metaphors lose their metaphoricity as they congeal through time into concepts, so subversive performances always run the risk of becoming deadening clichés through their repetition. . . . The effort to name the criterion for subversiveness will always fail, and ought to.
>
> (1990, xiii)

The difficulty is that subversive representational strategies can also be adopted more broadly, and are not stable signifiers. Indeed, as Sullivan notes, tattoos have

historically been understood as symbolic of deviance (2009). However today tattoos are prevalent in the mainstream and are not exclusive to queer communities. Along these lines, Rugg comes to the conclusion that the tactic of "femininity with mistakes" is a dangerous one, as it reinforces the idea there is a "correct" way to do queer, thus risking a new set of *queer* norms (1997, 186).

Indeed, for some participants it seemed that there were emerging rules for femme presentation, perhaps driven by an attempt to resist what might be seen as a "heteronormative" pairing between butch and femme. Despite the difficulty of creating "something wrong with this picture", many femmes appeared to persist in the search for signifiers. As Natasha stated: "I don't wear dresses; I date girls who wear dresses kind of thing. But even then I'm still wearing makeup, and I have pink hair and I'm covered in glitter at most times". Or, as Monique recalled, some norms and codes for communicating femme have emerged simply out of the desire for recognition:

> I guess also a part of it is wanting to be read as queer. So now that there is more awareness around femme, femme lesbians or femme queers, there's certain ways of presenting femme I guess, that are more read as queer than as just being feminine.

Awareness of these emerging femme norms caused anxiety for some of the femmes, such as Gemma, who stated: "I think that if I was going somewhere queer that I would freak out a lot more about what I was going to wear. Like, if I looked, like, femme enough or something". All of this reveals that despite the many proposed methods of queering femininity, without *stating* one's queerness you always run the risk – no matter your authorial intentions – that particular styles or acts may continue to be read as "normative".

Undoing femme representation

Precisely because of the feelings of invisibility and rejection experienced, many femmes claim that there is a power in feminine presentation as it resists the LGBTQ norms that promote femme exclusion. For example, though Rugg acknowledges the limits of representing femme, she concludes that femme femininity is the source of femme's resistant power:

> So, dress up, ladies, objectify yourselves. In order not to be perceived as the face of assimilation, speak out to say you're a big dyke even as you paint your nails and get out the fuck-me pumps and turn heads. . . . In order to fight the new gay right, answer a personal ad and get a glossy assimilationist lipstick lesbian to pay for an expensive lunch and drop the 411 on her (that is, give her the information) about why her politics suck. . . . By running in loudmouthed packs, we will give each other strength to put forth politics that work against assimilation and for a vision of a future that includes us and those (stereo) types we love.
>
> (1997, 188)

In these approaches we see that femme is not simply a form of identification, but that it also functions *as* political. That is to say, one does not simply "identify" as femme, it is seen as inherently political to *be* femme, as a disruptive force within queer and non-queer spaces. Interestingly, as we see in the excerpt from Rugg, this political femme can be distinguished from the "glossy assimilationist lipstick lesbian" who lacks the sufficient politics around their identity in order to effectively mobilise. Here femme empowerment relies on drawing a distinction between the feminine lesbian who mimics heterosexual femininity versus the queer femme.

The perceived connection between femme and empowerment leads to a number of problems, the most significant being that it invests in femme as a political position that can effect transformation *through* identification and representation. As Gemma reflected:

> It's quite a conscious thing, even if it doesn't seem like it all the time, but that it does sort of come from me really thinking about how I want to be a woman or a person or something. And that I think that it's like a political act. It just maybe doesn't always get received [laughs] in the right way.

Investing in femme as a politics that is resistant via aesthetics necessarily leads to a sense that to be effective, representations of femme ought to encompass the *most* challenging and the *most* diverse presentations of femme possible. That is to say that the idea emerges that if femme is represented in a way that reinforces norms of either queer or broader society (for example, if femme is associated with slim bodies as seen in the world of heterosexual feminine fashion magazines), it risks advocating for the "wrong" kind of political transformation. Here there is a premium placed on femme to remain representationally open in order to be politically efficacious – which presents a conundrum anytime "one" representation of femme must be communicated (on a poster, for example). The increasing anxiety around this is reflected in the changing representations of butch and femme on the covers of key texts over the last two decades. For example, the *Persistent Desire* from 1992 features two sets of intertwining legs on the cover (one wearing pants and boots and the other in a skirt, pantyhose, and heels), while the more recent *Persistence* from 2011 (positioned as a "follow-up" to *Persistent Desire*) depicts a single figure (a short-haired person applying lipstick). The changing representation of butch and femme on these covers demonstrates a trend toward representing femme (and butch) as ever-complexifying.

However, the representational strategies associated with femme are necessarily destined to be unsuccessful in being permanently and exclusively resistant. Though femme has managed its own reinvention several times – from its first incarnation as a working-class lesbian subculture in the 1940s, then as a rejection of lesbian-feminism in the late 1980s/early 1990s, and finally as the queer feminist femme we see now – femme will be doomed to fail at describing this resistance in the present because what this "looks like" can never stay fixed. There is a

clear recognition of this conundrum in the femme community: where despite the clear focus on aesthetics in discussions of femme, there is an unwillingness to provide even a loose sense of how to describe the aesthetics of femme without a great number of qualifiers. We see this, for example, in the apprehension expressed by Daria as she attempted to describe why she identifies as femme:

> I don't sort of, I don't really see it as much about clothing and that kind of thing. That's not really the part that I identify with, it's more the female experience I think. And yeah, I don't know. It's hard to describe.

Furthermore, the positioning of femme as essentially and always political isolates some people who do not see their gender presentation in these terms. As Rachel explained, she is hesitant to apply the label of femme (or other labels) to herself:

> In the words of other people, I would be queer, bisexual and polyamorous. But I don't use those words because it just seems normal . . . it's almost like they're political terms, and I'm kind of apolitical. I used to be very political, because I was so irritated and angry with the world. No one listens to hardcore Marxists nowadays.

We see here that Rachel is not devoid of political beliefs, but because she does not invest political power in her identity, she assumes she must be apolitical altogether – in other words, Rachel feels she is somehow missing the point, but doesn't quite know why, as she continued:

> I'd rather not be known as trans either, which is another thing, not being political. Some people who lived in stealth can understand it, I have lived in stealth.

While femme continues to be promoted as an identity politics that promises empowerment, it will necessarily become ever more representationally fractured as new norms emerge and it is forced to position itself against these.

The conundrum of representation

A most striking case of the difficulty of the politics of representing femme occurred in February 2013 at the Sydney Femme Guild's Unpacking Femme conference. A community-organised event, the conference ran over two days and was attended by people from the broader queer community and the academy. Amongst the other sessions, a Femmes of Colour autonomous group assembled on the final day. The penultimate all-in presentation – an overview of Matt Format's drag performance art presented by the artist – featured images of "oriental" drag and a costume with multiple eyes on it (symbolism used by various West Asian cultures). During this presentation, the Femmes of Colour group left the conference room, and as the next speaker began, conference organisers stopped proceedings. There

was confusion from some in the room over "who" was offended and "why". This confusion was also met with derision and anger from others. After a period of time, the Femmes of Colour group re-entered the room and took to the stage to read out a list of demands. The primary demand focused on the Sydney Femme Guild's logo, which featured a power fist wearing a white lacy glove. The group demanded that this be taken down, and argued that concerns about the logo had been ignored previously by the Sydney Femme Guild steering committee. Many of the femmes that I interviewed had been in attendance at the event and shared their reflections. For example Liz noted:

> It was just such an obvious example of our own racism and our own classism and our own privilege, that we refused [to take down the logo previously]. And even when challenging that in conversation, women would refuse to hear it, "it's just a logo". But it's not just a logo, it has connotations of White power, it has a long history of racism, of Whiteness. You can't remove that history from what it actually means.

After the event, the steering committee of the Sydney Femme Guild attempted to address the issues raised by removing the logo, staging meetings, and conducting a survey. Many people also left the Guild after this time, refusing to take the critiques on board, and the group only gained momentum again with new committee members in mid-2014.

With regards to this concern over the White bias of femme, Dahl argues that, particularly in Australia, there is a nostalgia in femme communities for a 1950s vintage aesthetic that is coded as White: "[T]he feeling of vintage as nostalgia is tied to 'a white bourgeois fantasy of the past' that was and remains far from universally available or interesting to all femmes" (2014, 605). We might also think to Amber Jamilla Musser's point that femme often reproduces dominant significations of femininity that problematically attempt to enact a "postracial logic" (2016, 78). In the example from the conference and in terms of suggesting the Whiteness of femme, the white-fisted vintage femme logo is a failure of representation and thus a political failure. As Ana expresses, the situation was felt by her to be related to some of the deeper emotions that had already been in circulation before that session, and which erupted all at once:

> People were talking a lot, and I really enjoyed that. But everything that people said was so heartfelt, and, personal. But I feel like people were already in this really tender situation. Like a couple of people I went with had just had people they love die recently. I feel like all that stuff had been brought up and then that session, that Matt Format did . . . it was really painful but also rubbed at something that was already very raw in all the conversations that people had had prior.

We see in this example that because femme is not just seen as an identity positon that one occupies, but rather as something that one effects politics through, debates

over representation take on a sense of urgency deeply connected to distress over histories of oppression and how to challenge those histories.

As a strategy to fight oppressions related to wider structures of injustice, identity politics turns these debates inward to the level of interpersonal relations. As Nancy Fraser explains: "The recognition paradigm . . . targets injustices it understands as cultural. . . . Examples include cultural domination, non-recognition and disrespect" (1999, 26). Thus, while some demands are directed toward broader culture, many of the demands are made *within* the group and around issues of recognition and respect. In the case of Sydney Femme Guild, this strategy importantly raised awareness of some of the concerns felt by Femmes of Colour in the group. This is not to claim that the imagery used by Matt Format was not perpetuating racist stereotypes or problematic in other ways, but what it does reveal is that the emphasis on the importance of the representational meant that the images were made emblematic of deeper perceived problems in the group. In other words, it was *images* that triggered the need for a discussion about racism, rather than any other aspect of the organisation.

Despite the apparent desire of many in the Sydney Femme Guild to respond effectively to the issue of racism, their purpose in the very first instance was to address representations within and of the group rather than to look at wider issues of race or disenfranchisement as felt by members. The logo was replaced by the text "Sydney Femme Guild" with no imagery, which reflects the difficulty of representing femme graphically in a way that is norm-free. While to some degree consciousness was raised within the group through this issue, the internal nature of the debate accords with the belief that politics is conducted at an individual level. Furthermore, this example demonstrates the general orientation of femme toward a politics of representation rather than one of broader transformation. Indeed, the collective will always be rendered impotent at communicating an ultimately resistant picture of femme because, if politics is seen as embodied through the individual, the whole will always be understood as *less* than the sum of its parts.

Femme versus femininity

While many seem initially drawn to femme for its ability to "fit" and represent their experiences of femininity and marginalisation, the dominant discourse here suggests that one cannot simply "be" feminine and femme. Rather, femme is understood as a more active identification that requires special knowledge, daily negotiation, and a specific political positioning. One cannot simply be a feminine femme because femme is seen as always enrolled in a politics of resistance enacted at the level of identity. Femme requires feminine embodiment with a certain political awareness.

As reflected by the participants I interviewed, norms about being "queer enough" or "femme enough" paradoxically and readily form in femme spaces. Although femme communities try to respond to the sense that femme ought to be resistant to norms, this necessarily leads to a fracturing and an inward turn of

political attention to how group members oppress one another, rather than looking to how division filters in from broader society or considering common experiences of oppression. In other words, in positioning femme as a resistant, unsettled identity, this philosophy of femme *undoes* the possibility of feminine appearance carrying queer potential. In the end, this leaves little space to imagine the queer possibilities of femininity.



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

5 The feminist femme

Many of the interviews and the more recent texts on femme attest that there can be agency over femininity as *chosen* rather than *assigned*, and this is imagined distinctly in terms of femme *as* a feminist mode. Harris and Crocker, for example, position femme as "a radical feminist position, and a subversive queer model" (1997, 10). This is in contrast to earlier accounts of butch/femme identity that describe femme as a response to the limits of radical feminism in relation to queer identity. For example, as Nestle argues in the introduction to *Persistent Desire*, "[I]n the lesbian-feminist world, femmes have had to endure a deeper attack on their sense of self-worth" (1992, 15). In these earlier texts, many femmes identified as feminist but were also highly critical of the limitations of the lesbian feminist beliefs of the time.

In recent years, and along with changing currents in feminism, many femmes have moved to focus on what are perceived as femme's explicitly feminist qualities, in spite of many simultaneously reporting feeling marginalised by feminist attitudes toward femininity. Furthermore, where femme femininity distances itself from normative heterosexual femininity, it works through a similar feminist logic where femininity is only coded as oppression, as described in the first part of this book. In order to overcome the oppressive qualities of heterosexual femininity, femme discourse today often proposes the *mindful* adoption of feminine styles. However, as this chapter explores, support for this particular rationale ultimately scaffolds an inability to see the queer potential of femininity that leads to the conundrum of femme in the first instance.

The role of femme literature

Before looking to how femme works along similar logics to some of the problematic views of femininity already outlined, it is helpful to examine the major role that written publications (as cited in chapter four) on femme have played in shaping a dominant femme discourse. Many interview participants discussed how they first came across the term "femme", and in more cases than not this occurred via femme literature in print and online and through contact with community groups (such as the Sydney Femme Guild). Many participants recalled coming across the term in the first instance in cited femme texts; this discovery became integral to them and opened their world to a new category of self-understanding.

The theme of self-epiphany through engagement with femme literature is common within the femme literature itself. For example, in her piece "On Being a Bisexual Femme" in the collection *Femme*, Leah Lilith Albrecht-Samarasinha notes that after reading Feinberg's novel *Stone Butch Blues* and the collection of personal experiences on butch and femme in *The Persistent Desire*, they felt the identity femme allowed them to be part of something: "[Femme] let me know I was part of a historical category of women, not a sexual freak" (1997, 139). Similarly, in *Persistence*, Zena Sharman discusses "reading my way into femme" with the explanation:

> It was in books like *The Persistent Desire* and *Brazen Femme: Queering Femininity* that I found words for who I was, and through these a lineage, a community, my heroes. Nearly ten years later, femme is more than just a word on a page, it's who I am.
>
> (Coyote and Sharman 2011, 24)

In *Brazen Femme*, Katherine Payne also describes this phenomenon of finding identity through others as "a glimpse of the things perceived in others that allow us (always momentarily) to understand ourselves as fitting somewhere in the world" (2002, 47–48).

Interview participants similarly described finding the work of authors on femme as having a major influence on how they understood themselves. For example, Ana notes the importance of Albrecht-Samarasinha, Brandlingham, and Dahl to their connection with femme:

> I think the first time I came across femme as a particularly queer, y'know, identity that was something people were starting to gather around was when Ulrika Dahl's book came out, and my friends and I went to the launch of that and it was really exciting and y'know we were writing and blogging as well and we were reading like, I was reading *Queer Fat Femme* at the time and yeah all of these femme texts. I think I discovered Leah Lakshmi's *Femme Shark Manifesto*, all these things. It seemed really exciting and it seemed like, something that fit me really well at the time for where I was in my gender presentation and also y'know, finding a space in the queer community for myself.

Like Ana, other participants repeatedly mentioned books that they had come across, or groups that they had found online or in person, that had contributed to their understanding that femme was a legitimate queer identity. When I asked participants: "Do you remember when you first came across the term 'femme'?" many had a readily available answer related to femme literature. As Chloe remarked:

> I was in Canberra for the holidays, and I was in the Borders bookshop and I found a book called *How to Be a Lesbian* [laughs] in big bright red letters. So I bought that. And it had kind of a list of the stereotypical categories. That's when I found out what the term was.

Or as Julia recalled:

> There was a book review in the newspaper, which was for *The Femme's Guide to the Universe*, which is this book by Shar Rednall, who's kind of this famous pornographer slash femme person. And I ended up buying that book, and it really kind of influenced . . . the way I viewed life. And my philosophy. I think it really inspired me to enjoy my life rather than to live in fear and to kind of succumb to the social pressures of being a teenager.

Julia later revealed that the book allowed her to gain a sense of control over her queer identity and gender presentation and remarked: "I stopped being passive in my life". Other femmes such as Claire talked about groups in the community that impacted on their sense of self-identification as femme: "When Canberra Femme Collective happened in Canberra, I thought *finally*. That's really good news. Because I'm not the only one that's struggling within this particular community to feel that I belong". Or, as Liz remarked of *The Persistent Desire*, "I was lovers with butches only. And I was attracted to them, so I just kind of knew that's who I was and that's how it worked. I just didn't have a language. And then I read Nestle's book and I just thought oh my god!"

The argument that the experiences of others allow a sense of belonging in commonality as made by Payne (2002) rings true here. However, what the exchange between femme texts and identifying as femme also demonstrates is that a dominant and self-reinforcing femme discourse has emerged over time. In other words, thoughts on femme are highly informed by the texts already produced on the topic of femme, and these are fed back into further literature in a round process. This isn't necessarily problematic (or different to how other discourses travel), but it does mean that particular logics have emerged within the community. These continue to inform and structure articulations of femme in its specificity, and in order to provide differentiation of femme's unique identity position this discourse has increasingly borrowed from a feminist logic that repeats that there is a problem with femininity. Just as Foucault proposes that discourse produces what is knowable (1972), the emergence of a dominant femme discourse continues to produce certain limits to imagining the queer potential of femininity.

Queer femme meets feminism (again)

Many of the interview participants described identifying as "very" feminist and this as key to their femme identification. For example, when asked about the relationship between femme identity and feminism, Natasha remarked: "I identify really really strongly as a feminist". Similarly, when asked to explain femme femininity, Daria explained that her femme identity was not merely about feminine appearance but feminist approaches to femininity, as they affirmed: "I think of it [femme] as being closely related to feminism now". Daria also added that while feminist approaches toward femininity might have been antagonistic in the past, there was now a sense that the two were commensurable: "I think it's about

owning your femininity and making it a statement and . . . making it clear that you can be a feminist and be feminine, that the two aren't mutually exclusive". Gemma also suggested that feminist identification is essential to identifying as femme, as they stated: "I feel like if you are femme, then you also have to be a feminist". Chloe similarly reported that: "I feel really offended if people say they're not feminist, like lesbians, like no I'm not a feminist, and I'm like yes you are, please be a feminist". Julia also expressed, "[B]eing femme . . . is a feminist act". Furthermore, as Kate noted, one of the reasons she wanted to be part of the study was to discuss the connections between lesbian femme identity and feminism: "I really feel like it's one of those topics, part of the reason I'm here talking to you is the links, the obvious links with feminism"; and also added: "I much prefer to talk about feminism than high heels".

While expressing the importance of feminism to their femme identification, many participants also talked about the marginalising effects of some feminist approaches to femininity. For example, Liz recounted that her identification as femme garnered responses such as: "[Y]ou're not a real feminist, you can't be attractive for men, you're just living in a heterosexist world where you're just doing all this stuff to pass, like you just want the privilege as passing as a heterosexual person". This rejection was also expressed in Audrey's recollections, when she discussed feeling marginalised within "a feminist separatist sort of environment". Similarly, Monique discussed the difficulties of identifying as both femme and feminist: "[I]t was sort of something I sort of struggled with, initially. Because I do identify as a feminist. And I guess feminism generally teaches that women have been oppressed by femininity, and by certain roles". Yet in the cases where participants reflected upon the tension between presenting as a feminine femme and identifying as a feminist, there was still a sense that feminism was the key to their femme identity being differentiated from "normal" femininity. As Monique explained:

> I find myself and the vast majority of femmes that I know are quite educated, particularly in feminism, and are choosing how to present themselves with the knowledge, that's how we choose to express ourselves rather than blindly following what's given.

The difficulty of being a feminist femme for these femmes means having to grapple with a history of feminist scholarship and activism that has actively targeted feminine styles of the body. Indeed, during a session on body image at the Femme Hive Conference in Berlin, an audience member spoke about the complications of growing up with a "feminist mother". She spoke of the difficulty inflicted upon her by her mother who saw feminine styling as distinctly anti-feminist. The audience member described maintaining an attachment to feminism despite the conflict she had experienced. These reflections suggest the difficulties femmes face because of their feminine appearance in justifying themselves as not only queer but also feminist. Yet it is also evident that there is an attachment felt by many to maintaining femme as a feminist identity.

There have been a handful of articles that have explored feminism and femme in ways that extend out toward femininity broadly. For example, Elizabeth Galewski

explores the possibility of seeing femme as manifestly feminist, and as a subject position that might help us to appreciate the subversive potential of femininity more generally (2005). As Lisa M. Walker also highlights:

> To claim femininity for gender insurgency, femme theory is compelled to distinguish queer femininity from the femininity of the oppressed, but first it must construct the oppressed. It does so by mapping the oppressed and the liberated onto the existing dichotomy between the heterosexual and the queer, without always exploring the social circumstances that might shape expressions and experiences of femininity.
>
> (2012, 798)

Like Galewski, Walker argues for a re-conceptualisation of heterosexual femininity in light of femme. However, there are few accounts that follow Galewski's or Walker's suggestion to link femme to heterosexual femininity and queer femininity broadly. There is an emphasis, in much of the literature (as there was in the interviews) on viewing femme as distinctly feminist *without* extending the question of gender presentation to broader discussions.

Femme as given, femininity as choice

One dominant feature of the femme discourse in the interviews was that femininity was seen as an aspect that was assigned but that could be reclaimed by being mindfully chosen. On the other hand, femme was identified as a form of gender embodied by participants that pre-existed their finding the term. Indeed, the term femme was seen to allow participants to communicate their ownership and control over feminine appearance, in a way not open to heteronormatively feminine women. The differentiation between heterosexual femininity as assigned and femme femininity as chosen is also a major theme found in femme literature (see for example Ward 2009, 102). With the majority of participants, femme was also discussed as a category that inspired and "fit" them. Embracing the term was seen as choosing one's gender presentation in the world despite, paradoxically, feeling that the identity of femme itself was not a choice.

For Julia, like many of the other femmes, discovering femme was described as finding "something that fit". This experience is also reflected in my memoir piece for a feminist arts blog: "Finally I had found a term that reflected my experiences, a term that fit me. Things started to fall into place" (McCann 2015a). Similarly, Natasha noted: "I really like that it's for me, and to be a queer femme is sort of . . . rejecting that male gaze, but also being like fuck you, I'm going to be feminine in some of traditional ways"; she later added: "I feel really comfortable in it cos I feel like I found an identity that fits me really nicely". Daria also conveyed the contrast between choosing femininity but being femme already, and stated that "it's about dressing the way that you want to because that's the way you feel". This sentiment was also reflected in Gemma's comment: "I guess I sort of see being femme as a way of choosing my femininity, or choosing the way that I'm a woman really, I guess". Claire stated that "femme is . . . something I've always . . . been. And I don't think

necessarily always as a societal pressure". Similarly, Monique commented: "I guess in discovering femme, it kind of has given me a lot more space to be myself . . . [h]aving more consciousness around things and doing things out of choice", and: "I don't feel that I'm never not femme [laughs]". As Harris and Crocker contend, femme is about "chosen rather than assigned femininity" (1997, 5). Here we can see that for the most part participants reflected that their feminine presentation was chosen but that they had *always* been femme and that the term was simply found as an identifying category that "fit" with this underlying femme self.

A small number of the femme participants described having less personal attachment to the identifier femme because they felt it was a term forced on them by others. In other words, ambivalence was related to a sense of *lack* of free choice over the identity. As Kate described when asked about what "femme" means:

> It's another label. It's another brand. And . . . it's a label that I've only . . . come to know through being out. It wasn't a label that I'd ever heard of prior to coming out. It's a label that was applied to me, which I guess is part of the reason why I'm here I guess, because someone said "oh this person you know fits that" like someone would have thought that I fit that criteria, so here I am.

Similarly, Rachel stated that "liking [dresses] and being bi, or mainly attracted to men, would tend to put me in the femme category for other people. So I should be there, but, I just don't instinctively put myself there". For these participants, femme was seen as a label given to them based on others' assumptions or expectations about their appearance. As Gemma reflected:

> For ages I didn't identify as femme, and for a while I was like, "no, I'm not femme, I'm not like that", because I think that I'd like . . . made a lot of, I dunno. I think that because I was so used to people telling me I was femme, and I don't think it's about that at all, like I don't think anyone can tell somebody that they're a femme, I think you kind of like, decide that for yourself.

Here we see that Gemma's decision to identify as femme was distinctly related to her sense of agency over the term, at first rejecting it as a label given to her, and later adopting it as an empowering term: "[B]eing femme is *so* exciting and fun". These discussions with femmes suggest that having come across the term "femme" provided space for enjoying and exploring identity, but only specifically if they felt that the term was *chosen by* rather than assigned to them. Here we see a certain pleasure that femme provides but that is potentially limited by the fact that the command for "wilfulness" demands a perceived split between femme and femininity more broadly.

Intentionality, knowingness, and agency

Despite the possible difficulties of *visually* differentiating femme femininity from heterosexual femininity, femmes often continue to position themselves in

distinct contrast to heterosexual embodiments of femininity. Aviva Dove-Viebahn outlines the importance of specifically identifying as femme thus: "If a woman dresses in feminine clothing and is a lesbian (or bisexual, an even more fraught identity position) but does not identify, critically or otherwise, as femme, where is her political potency?" (2007, 74). As Natasha also expressed:

> It's also such a queer thing as well. I've had some cis het [cis-gender, heterosexual] people try and describe themselves as femme, and it's like, you can't have that identity, it's ours! It's not a straight identity. If you're feminine and you're a straight woman, you're just a woman. That's how people read you, and there's no, there's nothing subversive about it.

Alternatively, as Eves notes in relation to interviews with butch- and femme-identifying people: "Heterosexual femininity, which is portrayed as conformist and unthinking, was contrasted with a femme emphasis on gender performativity, subversion and choice" (2004, 490). As Ann Tweedy writes: "If I had to sum it up in one sentence, I would say being femme denotes conscious, empowered adoption of one's femininity" (2009, 66). This dominant argument for femme embodiment as different from heterosexual femininity relies on a notion of intentionality: femme femininity is seen to be mindfully adopted as a way to *deliberately* perform femininity. As Tweedy compares the straight feminine woman to the queer femme: "I think that queer, i.e., female femmes, take it up a notch in 'occupy[ing] normality abnormally' " (2009, 69). In other words, femmes wish to be read as intentionally feminine and authentically queer but not necessarily authentically feminine; in this "putting on" of femininity, femmes aim to communicate intentional inauthenticity.

The majority of interview participants argued that knowingness ought to be a key element of femme presentation to distinguish it from heterosexual femininity. Chloe remarked: "I think purposeful femme-ness is really important, but I think other times, like there's nothing wrong with just being unconsciously feminine I guess"; however she later added: "Some aspects of femininity can be a little bit oppressive. So it's good to be aware of that and to realise that you can play around with it and make it not oppressive". Similarly, Julia argued that it is often difficult to see the differences between femmes and other feminine women – "I don't think that femmes have an exclusive right to femininity, that's ridiculous. Everyone should be able to express themselves however they like, even if they don't identify as femme" – but she also explained that knowingness is certainly the key to liberation from the oppressive elements of femininity:

> If you're dressing a certain way or wearing makeup or whatever because you think that's what you have to do and you're not taking any joy in it, then that's oppressive. But if you go "I really love this", it's like creativity. You take pride in what you're doing and it's a source of joy, it's not a chore or y'know a necessity. I mean it is a necessity, but not because they say it is, it's because you want it to be. So it's just about taking back the power really.

The sense of ownership over feminine presentation evident in femme accounts is distinctly linked to identification as feminist. Here we see in Chloe's and Julia's accounts a sense of the oppressive potential of femininity, which can be ameliorated through knowingness. The latter is seen as awareness provided by feminist understandings of women's oppression and the relationship of feminine presentation to this history. However, it is also understandable that femmes would aim to distance themselves from "normal" heterosexual femininity because the key crisis of recognition that femmes face is this: to be understood as *not* heterosexual. In a milieu where femininity is seen as a marker of oppression (within the history of feminism) and as a sign of heterosexuality (within the queer community), it is no wonder that femmes seek to mark out their presentation as unique compared to "normal" femininity. To claim difference on the basis of sexual preference is not enough because femininity as a gendered style has not yet been untied from its perception as a problematic representation. If the assertion that femininity is an inauthentic form of gender masquerade remains unchallenged, it makes sense that the only solution for femme must therefore be to embrace this form of presentation as *intentional*.

However the appeal to femme intentionality is undone by recognising that authorial aims do little to control the ways in which texts (in this case, the body) are read and received. As Ferreday notes in the case of burlesque femininity's positioning of itself as radical: "No matter how 'alternative' or 'subversive' burlesque femininity may feel . . . it is held to fail as long as it is capable of being (mis)read as a reproduction of normative heterosexuality" (2008, 53). The extent to which femmes achieve intentional inauthenticity is questionable. For example, when interview participants described their practices of "getting ready" to go out to present their femme-ness to the world, they talked about activities such as showering, putting on makeup, and getting dressed. Many of the participants expressed difficulty in explaining their daily getting-ready habits and practices and described a presentation that was not readily distinct from so-called heterosexual femininity. As Gemma expressed: "Maybe I would have a shower, I dunno, maybe I wouldn't, maybe I'd be sweaty". Monique describes her process similarly: "I won't wear any makeup, or maybe like a little bit of lipstick or a little bit of something, and . . . so I guess I'm more likely to be during the day wearing something either stockings and a skirt, fairly plain skirt, or jeans". With the high risk of being "mis-read" combined with daily practices that do not necessarily communicate strong authorial intent, it is curious that *intentionality* is often the central line of defence for femme style. Thrift sums up the problem of a focus on knowingness and agency in relation to embodiment:

> Too often, the recent turn to corporeality has also allowed a series of assumptions to be smuggled in about the active, synthetic and purposive role of embodiment which need closer examination. In particular, it is assumed that bodies are bodies-in-action, able to exhibit a kind of continuous intentionality, able to be constantly enrolled into activity. Every occasion seems to be willed, cultivated or at least honed.
>
> (2008, 10)

Defending femme as intentional in comparison to heterosexual femininity contributes to the sense of femininity generally as involving an oppressive and inauthentic masquerade. This way of arguing inadvertently contributes to the existing challenges faced by those presenting as feminine in the broader community, which in turn contributes to the invisibility and marginalisation faced by femmes in the first instance.

As highlighted, the dominant discourse of femme distances it from heterosexual femininity and insists that it is not simply about feminine presentation. This contributes to the creation of exclusionary community norms that femme also purports to challenge. As Natasha explained, femme in her queer community is seen as more than just "normal" feminine dressing, which leads to the exclusion of some lesbians:

> There's a really judgment of girls who want to be really femme but conventionally mainstream kind of attractive. Who want to not be either 50s style . . . not like that . . . but just standard fashion, normal people fashion. And there's a really kind of judgment in that in [Melbourne]. It's like if you're not queer enough and you go to a queer night or a lesbian bar and people will look at you strangely if you're wearing a dress and ballet flats as opposed to a dress and ripped tights and docs.

In promoting "queer resistance as best", and rejecting the femme connection to broader debates around femininity, this form of judgement involuntarily but actively contributes to the rejection of feminine presentation in queer realms.

Indeed, many femmes align their intentional femininity with drag and camp, which have associations with subcultures of alternative masculinities rather than focusing on femininity as a centralising principle. For example, Albrecht-Samarasinha writes: "I have come to feel that femmes share more with drag queens and MTF transgendered people than we do with straight women" (1997, 141). However as participant Ana noted, their sense of identification as femme decreased precisely as norms became distanced from heterosexual femininity:

> I'm pretty suspicious of whether queer femme movements have power to subvert a devaluation of femininity more generally, especially when queer femmes are so often really keen to prove how queer they really are and not align themselves with straight women and not align themselves with other women, more traditional femininity. So I don't think that's really powerful for challenging how femininity is perceived more widely, which I kinda thought was the point of having a femme movement.

To argue for the resistant or rupturing potential of the feminine, we must go past the justification of femme femininity as intentional and consider femininity more broadly, outside of an easily identifiable "queer" realm. The perception of femininity being able to "do" more than simply reflect gender oppression must be considered if there is to be greater room for queer femininity.

"My femme is not your femme"

As the discussion so far indicates, dominant femme discourse calls upon a feminist logic that designates heterosexual femininity as always already oppressive but responds through advocating for the adoption of a mindful femininity for femme to be successfully achieved. However, in contradiction to this prescription for femme subversiveness, much of femme discourse (including my own previous expressions around femme) focuses on the radical indefinability of femme, as a *wholly individual* pursuit.

The majority of interviews opened with variations on the question: "In as much or as little detail as you like, what does queer femme mean to you?" Many participants cited struggling to define femme and noted its slipperiness and multifaceted nature, which made it hard for them to put into words. The specific aspects of identity that participants saw as related to femme were diverse and at times contradictory, suggesting that femme is dynamic rather than static, and is imagined and embodied in different ways by different people. As Brushwood Rose and Camilleri claim in their introduction to *Brazen Femme*, this complexity can be understood as meaning that femme by its nature resists discrete definition. They write:

> Femme is inherently "queer" – in the broadest application of the word – as bent, unfixed, unhinged, and finally unhyphenated. Released from the structures of binary models of sexual orientation and gender and sex. Released from a singular definition of femme.
>
> (2002, 12)

Many participants emphasised the idea that they could not *wholly* describe femme, based on the premise that the term is related to identity, and identity is a subjective experience. For example Gemma remarked: "Anyone can probably identify like how they want to, and it has nothing to do with me. It has nothing to do with anybody else".

Similarly, when participants mentioned the term "femininity" and I asked them to provide a definition, responses were often indefinite and participants were careful to draw boundaries that might be seen as too distinct or concrete. As Chloe suggested: "I feel like I shouldn't define it too much because there might be people who don't fit my idea of femininity who actually think that they're feminine". Participants marked their own opinions and definitions as only provisional.

While participants spoke of the difficulty of providing a definition, they frequently related femme to ideas of the *individual* and *choice*. For example, Julia referred to the importance of providing individual definitions, but, applying this to her own sense of femme as gender, she stated:

> I think sexuality is less about the individual in some cases, it becomes a part of how they relate to other people. Whereas gender I think is something that is a personal thing, and for me being femme is very personal. It's not about other people, it's about me.

Julia communicated the idea that femme is only definable by the individual, being distinctly located with/in the individual. Similarly, Liz emphasised her definition as her perspective alone, suggesting that femme is individually founded:

> Femme is so complicated isn't it? It's such a, it's like a spider web. For me, it's like the centrality of each individual woman's femme-ness, if she calls and identifies herself as that, that's hers and is. There may be things that we relate to with each other that are exactly the same. We go "oh my god I feel like that" with each other, and then there are other things that are completely our own that are just our things about being femme.

Here, Liz communicates femme as multidimensional across individuals. This is an idea also reflected in Dahl's research and phrased in *Femmes of Power*: "I might be able to [define femme] if I was to speak only for myself, but femme never sits still and she is always in relation" (2008, 20). Here, although there is a proposal that femme is relational, femme also paradoxically operates as a particular identity category only ever defined by the individual. We see this also reflected in early accounts that focus solely on femme (away from butch), such as Newman's introduction to *The Femme Mystique*. Here, she argues that every femme is unique and must "find" her own mystique (1995, 13).

Indeed, into the 2000s we see in the femme literature a growing focus on *individual specificity*. For example, Brushwood Rose and Camilleri write that femmes "cannot be domesticated" (2002, 11–12), and Burke argues: "Above all, my femme is not your femme" (2009, 11). Similarly, in my own previous commentary on femme, when asked "What is a femme?", my response was: "I don't want to speak on behalf of other people . . . because I think femme is very hard to define. So I can say what femme means for me" ("*FNLS* Event 1 – The Canberra Femme Collective Spring Picnic at Floriade" 2012). This resistance to settling on a definition for femme creates a locus around the individual as the ultimate creator of femme meaning.

This individualised focus connects with new forms of identity politics that began to emerge in the 1990s. Prior to this time, identity politics was considered in terms of earlier New Left activist movements, such as women's liberation (Alcoff and Mohanty 2006). Seen from this perspective, scholars such as Kimberle Crenshaw argued that identity politics was problematic because it *eliminated* individual differences within groups instead of highlighting them (1991). However, as postmodernism and queer theory became abundant in the 1990s, and with the release of texts such as *Gender Trouble* (Butler 1990) that proposed a deconstructionist model of gender, there was a struggle within identity politics between maintaining useful categories of identity and attempting to undo them altogether (Gamson 1995). Postmodern theories of gender like those proposed by Butler were interpreted in a way that maintained identity politics, but with greater fracturing; as Rosalyn Diprose explains, "Under the weight of individualism and identity politics [Butler's] critical intervention into disciplinary production of body-identity has tended to be reduced to superficial pluralism" (2002,

67–68). As Fraser also suggests, the late twentieth century saw a shift following " 'post-socialist' conflicts" from collective struggle for redistribution, to individual struggle for recognition (1995, 68). In the 1980s there was a shift in feminism from arguing for redistribution to recognition, which came to a head in the 1990s within the context of growing neoliberalism in the West (Fraser 2005). She refers to this as feminism's "identity-politics phase" (2005, 299), distinguished by its shift entirely away from demands for redistribution (1999). Indeed, from this perspective earlier movements such as women's and gay liberation which were labelled "identity politics" can be understood as based around identity but still working within a framework of collective struggle. In contrast, later articulations of identity post-postmodernism have focused more on the individual than the collective. This latter formation of identity politics was reflected in the femme interviews and texts.

Along these lines, the more recent focus in femme communities is *not* on sexual practices or the relationality between bodies (for example looking at butch-femme desire) but rather on gender presentation and individual identity. Indeed, we see recognition as a central demand in femme writing from the 1990s – as Nestle expresses in the introduction to *Persistent Desire*, "[T]he femme voice is underrepresented in historical records" (1992, 15). Yet, while these earlier demands were about recognition of desire, particularly sexual desire, the demand for recognition is now about visibility in terms of *appearance* in the LGBTQ world. "Desire" has been dropped from the agenda, as we see reflected in *Persistence* (2011), with the single figure able to contain both butch and femme with no outward relationality. In other words, femme has shifted from a focus on sexuality to an emphasis on gender presentation. Appearance and individual identity, not desire, is seen as the central site of resistance, further individualising the political struggle that is imagined.

Here it is useful to recall Foucault's claim in *The History of Sexuality Volume 1* where he argues, "The rallying point for the counterattack against the deployment of sexuality ought not to be sex-desire, but bodies and pleasures" (1976, 157). Foucault's point here is to remind us that sex cannot be untangled from the discursive regulation of sexuality and therefore ought not to be made the foundation of sexual resistance. Foucault's positon posits the possibility of pleasure not wholly structured by mechanisms of power (McWhorter 1999, 184). However we might remain sceptical of this claim to pleasure's pre-originary status. As Butler has pointed out, too readily embracing pleasures and bodies and forgoing sex and desire might miss the opportunity to unpack how pleasure is also determined and constrained, and is indeed inextricable from desire (1999, 20). Indeed, in this book I use and describe pleasure and desire as intimately intertwined concepts. But where Butler works through these normative constraints by looking to how norms might be repeated differently, this lends itself easily to arguing for a politics done *through* and *with* the body. Indeed as critiques of Butler have argued, part of the problem with her theory of performativity in *Gender Trouble* is the inability of this to recognise the trans desire for the material inscription of sex on the body as an end in itself, and not as a transgressive act (Prosser 1998, 33).

Instead, we might consider what returning to sex-desire might look like if neither sex-desire nor pleasures and bodies are enrolled as a rallying point: to return to desire as a site of significance that may be, like femininity, the product of larger machinations, but it is nonetheless anarchic, messy, interesting, significant, and deserving of our attention.

The limits of femme

Femme appears to present an interesting case through which to explore feminine embodiment free from the assumption that femininity is always a mark of oppression. However, as we see in many discussions of femme by femmes, femme discourse often actively distances itself from connection to broader questions of femininity. While femme began as a style adopted by working-class lesbian women in the 1940s, it has come to be seen as a site of active resistance. As time has progressed, we have seen femme discourse's political claims around the power of identification sharpen, with femme repositioning itself in line with feminist discourse that is wary of normative femininity. With this repositioning has come a greater focus on the individual and a distancing from questions of desire, coinciding with a separation of the butch/femme binary. There is now an increasing reluctance to define femme, and a greater emphasis on femme as resistant, because it is said to refuse discrete identification or representation. Thus femme is a site of much contradiction: femme femininity is seen as reclaimed and embodied with agency, yet the idea that there is a "normal" and oppressive femininity remains, even though the radical indefinability of femme means that these different styles of presentation may look the same.

Claiming that femme embodiment is essentially political and separate from heterosexual femininity on the basis of embodiment means that femme necessarily meets its limits and turns back against itself. As one delves into the literature on femme or joins femme communities, the overarching message is that femme cannot be defined. The upshot of all of this is that there is a desire to be radically differentiated from heterosexual femininity at the same time as there is insistence on the radical indefinability of femme. This perspective insists that while femme and non-femme styles *may* look the same they must be understood differently. In response to this conundrum, there has been an increasing trend in femme texts toward employing complex images that are not easily "read" along binary gender lines. However, as femme communities try to respond to this sense that femme ought to be always and in every way resistant to norms, there is fracturing and an inward turn of political attention to the level of the individual. In other words, in positioning femme as a resistant, unsettled identity, the philosophy of femme in fact undoes the possibility of a femme identification that looks normatively feminine. This ironically leaves little space for individuals to ever be considered legitimate as queer femme if they are read as "the same" looking as heterosexual feminine women.



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

6 Feeling femme

As discussed so far, femme discourse reveals a hope to offer a space for understanding the queer potential of femininity and insists on the radical indefinability of femme. Yet paradoxically the insistence on femme enacting politics at the level of the individual body – where femme femininity is seen as radically different from "normative" femininity – means that the queer possibilities of femininity and broader solidarity are foreclosed. Given that discussions on femme increasingly locate themselves within a discourse that constitutes identity *as* politics, there is a sense that femme not only *must* be political, but *is already* political as a marginal subject position. Thus, femme's currency lies in its maintaining marginal status, differentiated from heterosexual or "ordinary" femininity. As explained in the previous chapter, this requirement inadvertently reproduces a view of femininity as an inauthentic masquerade.

However, as the previous two chapters explored, femme as a category provides a sense of legitimacy and a space of belonging in queer realms, where femme embodiment is otherwise frequently dismissed and erased. What then, are we to make of the experience of femme, and (or "versus") feminine embodiment, and how might we imagine femme and femininity differently in ways that make space for femininity, rather than shut it down? This chapter proposes how we might look at femme differently, in a way that breaks down the emphasis on queer versus heterosexual and that transcends representation and the logic of empowerment versus disempowerment. Utilising similar theories as those proposed for looking at feminism without anti-femininity in chapter three, this chapter examines how we might talk about and understand femme without anti-femininity.

This is also an attempt to break down the barriers between queer femme and the heterosexual femininity of "raunch" culture discussed in the first part of this book. This chapter argues that, in seeing these embodiments as related rather than distinct and separate styles of gender presentation, we are better able to challenge assumptions about feminine presentation. In this way, femininity is not always seen as already oppressed/oppressive, and a way is forged to find commonalities that promote collectivity and a return to questions of sex and desire.

Re-reading femme

This chapter offers a re-reading of the femme interviews and femme literature, as discussed in the previous two chapters. Here, femme is not justified via claims to

intentionality or through its distance from ordinary femininity. Echoing chapter three this alternative perspective gives consideration to a range of topics: the emergent affects arising within the interview process; affective aspects of femme visible in the transcripts and texts; the affective aesthetics involved in communicating femme; perceptible moments of or references to queer failure and pleasure; unpacking what constitutes possible cruelly optimistic attachments in femme; and the possibilities of utopian femme horizons.

Rather than dismissing the femme perspectives reflected in the interviews and texts, this re-reading is posed as a way to draw out the contradictions in femme reflections, in order to see them as productive. As Michael Pickering states:

> We talk of "lived" experience, but experience always involves interpretation of what happens in life, of what makes our perceptions, feelings, and actions meaningful. This depends on how they come into expression and are conceptualised, organised and given temporal identity, or, in other words, how experience is given the quality of narrative.
>
> (2008, 19)

In this way, these interviews are approached as interpretations rather than "raw" or unmitigated data – that is, as narratives for exploration, alongside the other theoretical works and femme texts. The contradictions evident in discussions of femme can be seen as a critical indicator that we ought to consider femme away from the dominant discourse that claims femme as always powerful, resistant, feminist, and inherently queer.

Given femme's history of "reclaiming" femininity in spite of its simultaneous distancing from heterosexual femininity, rethinking femme also means rethinking femininity. This approach allows for a new set of questions that diverge from concern with agential notions of "choice" and "empowerment". We might ask: what is going on aside from or behind the dominant femme discourse that rejects non-femme femininity? What does the experience of femme involve outside of queer feminist identity politics? And, rather than asking what femme *means* for politics, we might ask: what does the femme body as feminine *do?*

The re-reading in this chapter is conducted in order to consider what the femme body *does*, leaving aside the claim that it is an identity position liberated from the oppressive elements of "normal" heterosexual femininity. This chapter explores the possibility of taking a break from femme as a site of identity politics to consider what femme embodiment "does" in terms of affects, pleasures, failure, and reimagining possibilities, rather than assuming or claiming what it "ought" to do to be resistant to the "normal". It is also an argument for queer theory seeing femme differently, albeit a somewhat ironic application, namely, queering a subject position that is currently being undone by its desire for queerness.

Stripping back femme

As the previous chapter illustrated, femme is seen as an empowered identity category. It enrols the body in a politics of challenging expectations of gender and

sexuality in both queer and non-queer communities. Femme involves a political demand of "visibility", and thus it is an identity highly preoccupied with representation, signification, and meaning. Taking up this angle of "visibility" alone, questions remain stuck on how to unpack the meanings of femme and how femme can best effect change via political demands. These lines of questioning put to one side the physicality, feelings, and sensations of femme embodiment, which may or may not be related to effecting resistance. Here we might be reminded of what Elspeth Probyn argued for in the 1990s: "to think about the production of a sexed lesbian space in terms of bodies: actual bodies together, or bodies that miss another body, that long for a woman's body" (1995, 83). In other words, setting aside questions of visibility allows for considering "actual bodies", namely the experience of being femme.

Taking into account the affects of femme experience allows us to think through the bodily and material aspects that might disaggregate the strictures of identity. Here we adopt the position that identity is an emergent *effect* that follows from material processes, rather than seeing identity as something one can rationally *choose*. This "I" as epiphenomenon resonates with Butler's claim that there is no doer behind the deed; it suggests the very impossibility of a wilful "I" behind the machinations of gender (1990, 195). This outlook falls in line with participant reports that their femme identity preceded their "discovering" the term, though they emphasised their feminine presentation as chosen. Seeing identity as emergent also helps to understand why many femmes identify certain aesthetics as central to femme but paradoxically as not always necessary. For example, as Natasha states, "[I]t's kind of like I always feel femme. Sometimes I don't feel like putting on makeup on the day or something or I don't feel like wearing something colourful, I'll just wear jeans and a t-shirt or whatever". If we let go of the demand for femme to be a wilful subject position where femininity is empowered because it is "chosen", we can re-read these kinds of statements without perceiving a contradiction between the views that femme is innate and that femininity is something that is chosen. Rather, we can understand femme as something that emerges via a collected sense of material and affective qualities over time. That is to say, one is not born femme, one becomes femme. More than that, it is to say: femme does not exist as an identifier that one steps into and takes charge of; femme is in a perpetual state of becoming, emerging as a way to describe a particular set of material and affective relations. Indeed, a common remark from interviewees was that when they "discovered" femme it was a term that "fit" or that felt "comfortable" – in other words, the term "femme" came after a felt mode of embodiment. Accordingly, we can re-read Claire's comment that "[f]emme is . . . something I've always . . . been [a]nd I don't think necessarily always as a societal pressure" *not* as evidence of femme as essential, but of the sense of feeling oneself as some ephemeral *something*, with the descriptor "femme" following after the fact. As Daria suggested, "[I]t's more about dressing how you *feel*" (emphasis added).

Seeing identity as the effect of a more material basis does not render the "I" impotent, nor does it mean that other interpretations of experience offered by individuals are irrelevant. It simply suggests that we can step away from the idea that the meanings we assign to experiences are the only way to understand them. As

Gilles Deleuze suggests, we might value corporeal experience without deference to the limited meanings we can ascribe to it. He states: "Only empiricism knows how to transcend the experiential dimensions of the visible without falling into Ideas, and how to track down, invoke, and perhaps produce a phantom at the limit of a lengthened or unfolded experience" (1969, 20). From this kind of perspective we might focus on the *capacities* of the feminine femme body, not just the meaning behind it. While this argument for a version of radical empiricism might seem to deny the importance of identity as no more than an idea, this perspective can be entertained as an experiment in understanding the body in relation to surface effects. As Butler suggests: "The reconceptualisation of identity as an *effect*, that is, as *produced* or *generated*, opens up possibilities of 'agency' that are insidiously foreclosed by positions that take identity categories as foundational and fixed" (1990, 201; emphasis in original). Considering femme affects allows for an extension of Butler's performativity to consider the particular dimensions of the sensate and bodily that contribute to shaping seemingly coherent and naturalised identity.

Assemblage and feeling femme

Here, we might understand feelings of queer "difference" as emergent from the femme body as *assemblage*. We can then begin to unpack the various material and affective aspects of femme that might contribute to a perspective that does not rely on notions of agency and the sovereign will to differentiate femme femininity and "normative" femininity. Assemblage refers to a dynamic flow of movement, of affect, and of potential (Kennedy et al. 2013). Assemblages are also inherently restless and therefore resistant; they are "always coming together and moving apart" (Wise 2005, 79). For example, in *Terrorist Assemblages*, Puar focuses on the item of the turban as part of the material affective assemblage of the figure of the "terrorist". Puar contends that for Sikhs wearing turbans in the United States, exclusion is not merely a case of different appearances but is more deeply rooted in differences between the sensorial and tactile bodies that are inhabited, and which prevent notions of sameness (2007, 177). Further to this, Puar notes that the turban exceeds being simply symbolic and instead highlights the importance of:

> Thinking of the turbaned man as an assemblage [not turban as appendage] . . . that fuses, but also scrambles into chaotic combinations, turban into body, cloth into hair, skin, oil, pores, destablising the presumed organicity of the body.
> (2007, 193)

In other words, the turbaned body is queer not because it involves the object as an *addition* to a queer body, nor because the turban is simply symbolic of the queer/other; rather, the turbaned body is queer because a blurring of boundaries occurs in this body. The turbaned body raises questions of what is outside versus inside, what constitutes the organic versus non-organic, and what is human versus what

is object (hair versus cloth). The turbaned body is queer because it involves a troubling of distinct boundaries (Puar 2007, 195). Though imagery is important to the question of what the turbaned body *looks* like, it is not the "meaning" conveyed by the images but rather their attributes – and the affects they elicit – that are most pertinent "in terms of speed, pace, repetition, and informational flows" (Puar 2007, 201). Puar highlights how the representation-based solution to the turbaned body as other would be to disseminate and promote "positive images" of the turbaned body that necessarily reify notions of what the "model minority" looks like, thereby contributing to rather than escaping the problem (2007, 188). For Puar, the solution cannot be simply representational because the problem is not purely representational. Puar instead argues for a new way of collectivising, outside of traditional identity politics, that emerges from an acknowledgement of the affective ruptures at play in particular "queer" embodiments (2007, 202).

In the same way that Puar's description of the turbaned body highlights the blend between the human and non-human, and the organic and the inorganic, so can we re-read femme along affective lines. As Puar suggests, sensorial and tactile differences between bodies mark out the "Other". Though it may seem a strange and disjunctive choice to use Puar's analysis of the turbaned body to the femme, she encourages us to make such a move:

> [M]y reading suggests the applicability of this analysis to all sorts of other bodies to destabilize the taken-for-granted assumption that the discursive body, however socially constructed it may be, is always already presumed to be a wholly discrete, intact, and fully-abled organic body. It would be a mistake, and the most damning interpretation of this work, to transpose this reading onto the most obvious bodies that lend themselves to a discourse of cultural alterity (burqa'ed or veiled bodies, disabled or dismembered bodies, diseased bodies).
>
> (2007, 201)

In the case of femme, long hair, lipstick, makeup, dresses, and other elements marked as "stereotypically" feminine can be seen from this perspective as excessive of being discreet objects or simple signifiers. Indeed, the femme body as long haired, lipsticked, made up, dress-ed, and so on, can be understood as an assemblage which elicits a particular kind of response (or lack thereof) in LGBTQ spaces. This understanding of femme as assemblage makes sense of a perceived "sameness" with femininity in the straight realm alongside "difference" in the lesbian/queer world. Seeing femme in this light helps us understand the abjection of femme in queer scenes, where feminine styles of the body designate femme as "Other". It also helps us understand the discomfort felt by femmes in the broader community, as they dissolve into a sea of heterosexual feminine bodies. Moreover, this affective perspective helps us understand how femininity *generally* is "Othered" relative to masculinity. Feminine styles of the body mark "woman" as different. When feminine styles of the body are embodied in an "excessive" way, either by femmes attempting to "turn up the volume" or by

heterosexual women enjoying "raunch", this embodiment changes their affective dynamics. Where femme assemblage or hyperfeminine embodiments are marked as "too much", they cross over into being perceived in relation to the masculine, and are often described in terms of drag and masquerade.

Like Puar's turbaned man, the femme body is inextricably linked with a particular material relation, and a shifting intensity of capacity for external recognition, for sensing the bodily, for desiring and being desired. Indeed as Margrit Shildrick argues, taking into account the blurred boundaries between the "human" and otherwise might lead to "an erotics and ethics of connection with an array of organic and inorganic others" (Shildrick 2015, 25). For example, this excerpt from Deborah Anderson's poem "fading femme", included in *Brazen Femme*, reveals the importance of the body, material, and sensate in relation to femme:

> flaccid mascara wand
> is getting dry
> flaky and emptier
> with each use
> and no money
> to buy a replacement
>
> to magnify the frame of eyes
> that glare at men who harass,
> eyes that emote
> sleeze haughty nasty
> femme top,
> my ooze of brazenness
> is halting here on the ward.
>
> my old power disappearing
> like a shrinking lipliner
> until I can't feel it
> **I'm losing my colours**,
> cloaked in the faded blue
> of hospital property pjs
> **almost forget the femme in me**
> (2002, 43; emphasis in original)

We see in this piece a reflection of the mascara wand not as a simple extension of the body, but *as* body, *as* femme. The thinning mascara encapsulates the illness of the author, and "ward" and "wand" resonate. That the mascara wand is "flaccid" and "dry" relates to a sense of losing capacity to "ooze"; there is a diminishing affective intensity and fading of femme as this critical material substance runs out. A paranoid reading of this poem might see it as conveying a sad and unhealthy attachment to feminine beauty standards despite grappling with illness. In contrast, the dominant femme reading of this poem may be to see

it reparatively, as a statement that femme aesthetics and identity are a source of empowerment, as reflected in the feeling of disempowerment experienced: "My old power disappearing/like a shrinking lipliner". However, re-reading this piece in terms of femme *affects* suggests that we need not only undertake paranoid or reparative readings of femme. The poem reflects that the feeling of femme is assembled through objects and colours, and as the latter weaken, so too do feelings of femme-ness. In other words, femme identity can be understood as an emergent material assemblage, where a change in material conditions threatens the continuing viability of femme, as reflected in the line, "Almost forget the femme in me". This perspective recovers the value of attending to femme, without casting it along a binary of empowerment or disempowerment, "good" or "bad".

Looking at another example we can see that just as material aspects can fade femme, different materialities can yield increasing intensities. Consider the following dialogue with an interview participant:

Audrey: If I'm just going out on a night out to a sort of club or something, then I usually don't plan what I'm gonna wear until I go down to my room, and I go "what do I feel like tonight?" do I want be, do I wanna be neat and sleek, or do I want to be big and puffy, or do I want to be light or dark, and sometimes it's like yeah no I wanna go out in black, black and green or . . . it's often colour driven. Or do I wanna be, do I wanna have frou frou, or do I wanna be latex, or . . . so I go by feeling and colour, really. And then build out from there.

Hannah: Do you feel different when you're in the outfit?

Audrey: Yeah, I just feel really powerful [laughs].

In this exchange, as in Anderson's poem, we see that the question of empowerment is not irrelevant. Indeed, Audrey indicates that power is a central aspect of femme. However, shifting focus to femme as assemblage highlights the *capacitating* affective dimensions involved in femme embodiment. Though Audrey arguably "chooses" her outfit for the night, this is driven by "feeling and colour", as if her outfit chooses her. Furthermore, there is a sense that a transformative capacity emerges from the assemblage of femme, engendered by the elements that come together as part of it: "I just feel really powerful". Rather than reading such experiences as discrete examples of empowerment, we can instead displace the question as one of capacity. In other words, the assemblage of femme yields a transformation in felt experience, but it is not *necessarily* resistant. Seeing femme in this way frees it from the impossible and exhausting labour of maintaining femme as a political identity that insists on prescribing its resistant quality as intentionality. The question is therefore no longer: "What does femme mean in terms of resisting power?" or "How does femme resist?", but rather: "What does femme feel like?" and "What can the femme body do?" These latter questions are not proposed as an endorsement of a kind of femme apathy – rather the opposite: they are about freeing up identity for the energy of political resistance to be

located less in the maintenance of the self, whilst simultaneously making room to understand shared experiences and interests.

Furthermore, theorising femme from the perspective of assemblage allows a whole new set of questions to emerge for thinking through femme. This set of questions opens up multiple pathways for understanding identity and difference anew, and for considering the significance of the material and affective in shaping the self, that is neither fully "natural" nor "social" – indeed, it is radically both. From this perspective, femme femininity is no longer a masquerade but a coagulation of elements that each produce different feelings and sensations. This also allows for understanding femme as a different kind of assemblage from (for example) butch, as it contains different elements, sensations, and forms of embodiment.

Furthermore, focusing on capacity as a central way to determine what the femme assemblage "does" opens up room for re-considering stereotypically feminine objects and paraphernalia. While these objects cannot be simply de-linked from gender norms or histories of oppression, new connections can be formed rendering different understandings of feminine beauty, fashion, and accoutrements. As Chloe stated:

> It's true that sometimes wearing delicate clothes can make you more delicate. Like if you wear heels, you can't really climb Angkor Wat. And [in] a dress, you have this expectation that you shouldn't reveal your underwear or whatever, then you can't do certain things. But I will happily climb in a dress, it doesn't bother me.

Here we see recognition that feminine clothing can be de-capacitating in the femme assemblage, but also that what is seen as limiting is often actually a function of how these objects are inscribed (for instance with demands for propriety) rather than one of considering their tangible capacitating/incapacitating effects. In another example, Rednour's *The Femme's Guide to the Universe* discusses: "How to Fuck in High Heels". Rednour states: "Fucking successfully in heels also requires quality heels. What is quality? Just something that is snug and not wobbly" (2000, 131). Here, the concern is not around whether heels are signifiers of feminine oppression but rather how heels can help enable an erotic experience, and what dimensions of the object are required – in this case, "quality" – to achieve this.

Hair in the femme assemblage

Following from the idea of assemblage, we can focus on hair as a specific material element of femme femininity. As Thrift has pointed out, "Hair has a neglected history that is only just starting to be explored in detail" (2010, 306). However it is not only significant to turn analysis to the topic of hair in order to address this lacuna, but specifically so because in each of the interviews conducted and within much of the femme literature, hair was frequently mentioned. Although I did not *set out* to ask questions about hair, all of the participants discussed their

experiences of having long or short hair in terms of what this meant in relation to their identification as femme. Many described cutting off their hair when they first "came out", as a way of signifying their entry into the queer community. Consider this discussion with Daria:

Daria: Yeah she was, the lady that cut my hair, she was really supportive about it. Cos it was really, I know it's just hair, but it feels like a really big decision when you cut it all off.
Hannah: Like Lady Gaga's song, "I am my hair".
Daria: Exactly. But I *was* kind of my hair. It was such a, I could really hide behind it. I felt like it was, helped me blend in a lot. For the first couple of weeks I just felt really exposed having short hair. Like I felt like everybody was looking at me, and it was really, it was kind of weird. But then I realised, well, I do live in Melbourne, people probably aren't looking that much! [laughs].

Daria also noted that, while having short hair made her feel more recognisably lesbian, it also affected her desire to wear the feminine clothes she had previously enjoyed. She stated: "I feel a bit uncomfortable if I'm wearing a dress now, having short hair. Cos I feel like people are thinking, 'Oh why is she, why is she dressing like that, she's got short hair?' Like I feel like I'm not supposed to, in a way sometimes. Which is . . . that's not good". Understanding this experience purely in representational terms, we can see how short hair acts as a visual signifier that is seen and recognised by others. However, what the representational perspective fails to address is how it *feels* to either have long or short hair, and how this might interact with the assemblage and embodiment of femme.

Considering what femmes say about hair as unrelated to purely symbolic communicative value, we begin to understand some of the dynamic aspects of hair as part of the assemblage of femme. Commenting on her long hair, Gemma recalled:

Gemma: I have felt more invisible, certainly. I have felt more desired by men. It gets very knotty as well [laughs].
Hannah: Is that annoying?
Gemma: Yes, fuckin hell! I haven't had hair this long since I was in primary school and now I think about cutting out knots in primary school. It's good though, I quite like it now. Now I just want bigger hair and bigger. I'm a Leo, it's my mane.

Gemma's description of her hair as a "mane" that she wanted to be "bigger" reflects a relationship with her hair that exceeds its value to represent her sexuality. Though the chosen style makes her feel "more invisible" in the queer community, her hair's symbolic value does not outweigh her desire to keep it long. Though it is unruly, she refers to it as lionesque; her hair doesn't defeat her but rather contributes to her sense of self.

Similarly, Chloe referred to her hair as a separate element of herself that contributes to how she feels:

Chloe: I used to straighten my hair and put makeup on, but I don't really feel comfortable with makeup any more. And even straightening my hair feels like . . . it's weird because it feels like curly hair is more rebellious. And straightening it feels like [inaudible].
Hannah: You feel what?
Chloe: Sorry for my hair. Burning it straight isn't right.

Here, Chloe reflects the idea that her hair is not only a material element that is critical to how she feels ("rebellious") but also one that is saturated with life. Similarly, Julia described her hair as having a kind of agency:

> I tried to go purple at the start of the year and it didn't really work. And then I was blonde for a while, and then I went red. But I guess for me my hair is almost like a living thing. It just changes and I accept the changes. And deal with them. I used to be concerned with perfection but I think it's just impossible. So you just gotta make the best of it really.

What we can see in all of these examples is a sense of the material vibrancy of hair as a substance not separate from the whole but a key contributing element of the femme assemblage appearing in various manifestations. Again we might recall Stewart's claim here, that agency is more "rooted in things" than we commonly imagine (2007, 86). Setting aside the question of representational symbolic value, we see that hair *does* different things and *feels* different for different femmes. Seemingly with a life of its own, hair cannot be reduced to its value as something seen but must be understood as something felt.

Failure, desire, and heterosexual connections

Alongside re-reading femme from an affective perspective, we might also consider the various elements of pleasure and failure perceptible in femme embodiment. From this, we can better understand the experience of embodying femme without recourse to identity politics frameworks that rely on notions of empowerment to justify femme's value. The mode of re-reading presented here does not propose a new way of achieving femme through failure. Rather, this perspective is about acknowledging the possibilities opened up via mistakes, hence painting a picture of femme as *less* controlled and mindful than is often argued. While femmes often mark heterosexual femininity as problematic, analysis of the queer elements of femme allows for moments of recognition between the two. This perspective does not simply assimilate femme as equivalent in experience to heterosexual femininity. In contrast, a focus particularly on *pleasure* allows for renewed focus on the role of desire in femme embodiment – an aspect slowly evacuated from femme literature over the past twenty years.

As discussed previously, some approaches to femme attempt to define it as related to failing "normal" femininity on *purpose*, with feminine presentation that appears slightly off ("something wrong with this picture"). However, rather than relying on knowingness to validate femme experience – which process also divides femme femininity from heterosexual femininity – examining femme failure allows consideration of the radical possibilities of femme, which are left open rather than closed. As Gemma described:

> Usually I'd wear a lot of makeup and I like makeup and I think it's really fun, but I also don't, I don't have the right brushes for it. I've got a friend of mine who just like always looks like a beautiful drag queen and has heaps of expensive makeups and brushes and things, and gets really annoyed because I still put eye shadow on with my fingers [laughs]. . . . So I think that's how I kind of still think about it as well. That it's all just funny. Like how amazing, how ridiculous that I can colour in my eyebrows and that that changes things, I think that's really fun and weird. But then I like, yeah I don't think of myself as like a "real girl" or something, cos I don't have all the proper equipment, I don't really know how to do it.

Here we see that Gemma desires a particular feminine aesthetic, yet doesn't "really know how to do it". Femme embodiment is connected here to ideas of joy, pleasure, and transformation, but perhaps more importantly, Gemma's mode of embodying femininity challenges a simple understanding of femininity as oppressive – that is, she fails at embodying "real girl", but achieves something else, something "fun and weird". This recognition of failure is crucial to appreciation of femme as a material assemblage. As Thrift writes:

> Embodiment includes tripping, falling over, and a whole host of other such mistakes. It includes vulnerability, passivity, suffering, even simple hunger. It includes episodes of insomnia, weariness and exhaustion, a sense of insignificance and even sheer indifference to the world. In other words, bodies can and do become overwhelmed.
>
> (2008, 10)

This also connects crucially with Halberstam's "queer art of failure", which suggests losing as an essential tactic (2011, 120). The importance of failure is also evident in Rachel's recollection of her "failure" to be a "real boy". Rachel states:

> I guess this is not much to do with femininity, or maybe it is! Anyway, I remembered my mother telling me that it was very wrong to want to mutilate myself like that, and it was the first time I'd heard that used outside a heavy metal context, cos my brother liked that kind of music. Because I'd told her that I wanted to cut my penis off. [Tearing up] And then this sort of huge upheaval happened inside me, it was like I'd fallen down and was drowning, because I'd started to wonder up until that time whether I wasn't really

> supposed to be that guy after all, and whether I was actually supposed to be Michelle, because it actually felt more normal.

Rachel's experience of being told by her mother that it was "wrong" to "mutilate" herself was clearly upsetting, but also deeply rupturing. A more positive recognition of "failure" may have helped Rachel make sense of these experiences. Rachel's felt sense of embodiment exceeded her mother's understanding of her as "son", and it was this feeling that led her to pursue a different gendered mode that would better fit her experience. The foregrounding of failure allows us to understand experiences of feminine embodiment away from the competing ideas that you are either born feminine or that you simply choose a feminine aesthetic. This perspective also connects with the understanding, presented earlier, that feminine embodiment is more than simply an effect of "oppression".

While failure is a key element of femme that challenges easy descriptions of feminine presentation as either related to oppression *or* as freely chosen, the *pleasures* of femme reveal a queer side of feminine embodiment. Many of the participants described the positive feelings they associated with certain femme practices. For example, Natasha and Julia both described wearing makeup as "war paint". As Natasha stated: "It's not very common to see someone with pink hair and green lipstick . . . and I feel ok about getting weird looks from people or whatever, when I'm dressed how I want to be. . . . I think it's my 'war paint'". In this sense, some participants referred to makeup as a protective barrier to enable them to face the world; for instance, Chloe remarked: "I love lipstick. . . . I guess it's kind of like an 'I'm ready to go out now'. I feel like I can face the world because I've got this special security blanket or something". This positive feeling defies description in many accounts; for example, Julia stated: "I just feel better, if I've got all those ridiculous trappings that shouldn't mean anything [laughs] but they do [laughs]". One perspective on this kind of feeling – of makeup and feminine attire as a "security blanket" – might posit it as revealing the power of patriarchal society to make women feel that they need to conceal their real selves and that there is something wrong with them if they do not present in a particular way. However participants often remarked that beauty practices were something fun that they took pleasure in. Claire stated that femme was about revelling in precisely the stereotypical expectations placed on women; for her femme was partly about:

> Enjoying . . . my body, enjoying the, some of the social norms that are afforded to women. Enjoying the flexibility in dressing up that it gives me, that I can be quite flamboyant. That I can muck around with makeup. And hair and things like that. That I can . . . I dunno, I feel more flirty.

For other participants, partaking in bodily expressions of femininity was often received as something excessive or unexpected, not simply because of their sexuality but because, socially speaking, a more "natural" look was, in fact, expected. For example, in discussing red lipstick, Daria recalled:

Daria: It's like a really big contrast on your face, and people, if it's not something you do all the time, people just kind of like, "oh woah!" it's just a bit of a shock. And I think that's one of the reasons I like it, it's nice to shock people sometimes.

Hannah: Does it make you feel different when you put it on?

Daria: Yeah I think so, it feels sassier somehow! [Laughs]

Here we see that Daria enjoys the shock that red lipstick affords by contrasting with her pale skin, making her feel "sassier". Thus we see that these practices of appearance – and the feelings and pleasures associated with them – are an important part in the story of femme.

Again we see, through addressing questions of pleasure, why femmes do not simply or easily conform to particular lesbian/queer norms. Furthermore, all of the feelings expressed earlier – for instance seeing makeup as "war paint" or lipstick as affording "sassiness" – are not about *sexuality* but feminine *gender presentation*. In this way, we can make the links between heterosexual femininity and femme femininity, acknowledging that the pleasures experienced by femmes may be similar to those experienced by other people adopting feminine styles. In other words, the femme recovery of feminine presentation from the doldrums of merely pertaining to "oppressive" representation can also call on us to rethink femininity more generally, outside of questions of femme identity.

Despite possible connections between femme and heterosexual femininity, the argument may be raised that heterosexual femininity is problematic precisely because it is *not queer*. Indeed, there may be an argument that heterosexual femininity is heteronormative and therefore exists in direct opposition to femme femininity. Green provides a thorough explanation of heteronormativity as "that set of institutionalised norms and practices that supports and compels private heterosexuality, marriage, family, monogamous dyadic commitment, and traditional gender roles" (2002, 542). Warner first coined the term "heteronormativity" to describe the underlying assumption that heterosexuality (as oppositional desire) is at the base of social relations. Warner argues that this problematic expectation derives from "heterosexual culture's exclusive ability to interpret itself as society" (1991, 8). In other words, heteronormativity involves the pervasive notion that the normal bounds of intimacy involve heterosexual practices, and this "normal" sphere extends out beyond relationships and into the everyday fabric of social life. As Ahmed describes, "[C]ompulsory heterosexuality shapes what bodies can do. Bodies take the shape of norms that are repeated over time and with force" (Ahmed 2006, 91). Related to heteronormativity, the "heterosexual matrix" proposed by Butler in *Gender Trouble* describes the normative relationship between sex, gender, and sexuality. Butler suggests that pervasive expectations exist regarding sex and gender such that sex can be seen as "always already" gender, and that given the taboo on homosexuality, oppositional desire follows from one's gender demarcation (1990, 9). Butler contends that sex, gender, and sexuality are interwoven terms within a system that presumes predominantly heterosexual, reproductive relations.

However, even under these terms all is not lost for recovering the productive insights femme femininity may yield for femininity more generally. That is, while heteronormativity and the heterosexual matrix theorise an intimate normative connection that operates between sex (female), gender (femininity), and sexuality (heterosexual), to queer our understanding of femininity necessarily means disrupting this normative chain. If we extend this radical understanding of femininity past the femme realm, there is more room to see heterosexual femininity queerly, to consider what the feminine body does rather than what it means. We can return here to Halberstam's point that we ought reconfigure our understandings "in ways that may favour heterosexual women in particular" (Halberstam 2012, 82). In other words, heterosexuality need not be seen as distinctly lacking in queer possibility.

However, regardless of the links between femme femininity and heterosexual femininity, the two need not be understood as *exactly the same*. Distinctions can be made via a consideration of desire in the realm of femme. As outlined, while earlier works on butch and femme embodiment focused explicitly on sex and desire, later works described femme in terms of gender expression largely evacuated of questions of sexuality, except as operating in the background. Indeed, when I presented my work on femme at the Femme Hive Conference I discussed with the audience the problems of seeing femme in purely representational terms and discussed the "antidote" to this as seeing femme's affective, material, and queer aspects. After multiple stories from audience members supporting the idea that femme exceeded the representational – that it was a felt mode where the assemblage of makeup and so on were keys to the experience– one person piped up from the back angrily, "But what about pleasure?" I asked for elaboration, and the person explained that femme "used" to be about questions of desire and sex – about wanting butches, or perhaps other femmes – but that in focusing simply on the material I was emptying femme of questions that were essential to femme identity. At the same conference, another attendee revealed to me over dinner that organisers had rejected a suggestion to stage a workshop on "stone femme". Here "stone" refers to sexual practices where you do not want to be touched/pleasured, as all pleasure is derived from actions performed on the other person (see Halberstam 1996). This attendee's application had been rejected on the basis that it was not sufficiently broad a topic to be relevant to all femmes in attendance. Conference activities instead focused on: "glamour photography", "femme bodies", "intersectional femme solidarity", "femme self-love", and similar subjects. In other words, activities were predominantly focused on the visual, bodily, and political, about the experiences of being an individual femme, but not about femme *desire* in relation.

After this conference I returned to the transcripts of the femme interviews and noticed the discussions of desire that I had overlooked. I also noticed a trend: older participants spoke about desire not only directed toward the self – the pleasure of embodying a certain aesthetic, for example – but also directed toward another, specifically with femme related to a sexual dynamic. As one such participant stated: "[B]eing femme is, it's obviously about my desire and who I'm attracted

to and what that dynamic is about for me. But it's not just about my desire, it's not just about who I fuck. If I'm a deserted island, or by myself, I'm still inherently femme". Or as another participant remarked:

> I quite like butch/femme play, and . . . sort of, I quite like some of those binary dynamics around top/bottom, those sort of things. But not actually, like I wouldn't ever be attracted to someone who, anymore, who didn't have some of that dynamic. Like that's part of my identity of desire, is that I want some of that dynamic. But I don't really need to . . . It's not strong for me to have to live in a permanent dynamic. But it's sort of like I need . . . I like the contrast.

In these cases femme was explicitly discussed in relation to sexual desire. Similarly, Claire explained her foray into playing with gender expression in her youth as directly related to an exploration of sexual desire and attraction:

> There used to be a group of us that had this, we had this thing called the "adventure club" and then we created this little subcommittee, cos the adventure club had quite a lot of people in it, because before genderqueer was cool [laughs] we wanted to go out there and explore what flirtation was, and how that was constructed, and how that could be enacted.

In comparison, among younger participants femme was discussed almost exclusively in terms of gender rather than sexual desire. Even in cases where the connection between sex and femme was considered, participants also made explicit that it *ought not to* be about desire. As Gemma for example remarked on her distress at not being recognised in the queer community: "I guess because being femme goes hand in hand with my sexuality as well, although it needn't, but for me it does [laughs] – so fucking PC [laughs]!" As she further stated:

> We all make assumptions. I mean I make assumptions as well. I think it's funny though cos like, I don't really know why it's such a big deal, I don't know if you feel that too, but it is, it really is, it really does affect me. When I'm sure lots of people go through their life not caring. I think it shouldn't have to be anyone's business, how I identify or who I have sex with, but it is, and I don't really know how to piece that together yet. "Notice me!"

Here Gemma expresses the connection she feels between her sexuality – who she wants to have sex with – and a femme presentation that challenges her ability to communicate who she wants to have sex with. Yet Gemma also expresses a concern to remove femme from a question of sex: that "it needn't" be related to sexuality. Alternatively, as noted, Julia reflected: "Gender I think is something that is a personal thing, and for me being femme is very personal. It's not about other people, it's about me". Here we see a double bind within the dominant discourse of femme. Imagined as a form of gender presentation separate from questions of

sexuality, femme is still positioned as distinct from heterosexual femininity. Yet it seems that the ability to communicate sexual desire, to be distinguished as queer yet feminine, is one of the fundamental conundrums of femme. Dominant femme discourse currently mediates sex as a side issue, one that is not necessarily central to femme. Though femme may be a "queer counterpublic" (Berlant and Warner 1998, 558), femme's recent distancing from desire effectively re-privatises sexuality. Femme gender is made public, but sexuality is a question relegated to the background.

To productively escape this bind, we can turn to the possibilities for understanding femininity outside of a rubric of oppression. Liberating femininity broadly opens up space for femme to focus on other things, for instance to turn to a discussion of sex, sexuality, romance, relations, or desire where needed. A focus on desire challenges the assumption that femme is solely about individual identity and relationality toward the self. In this way, femme would not be absorbed (as it were) by being seen as *the same as* heterosexual femininity, despite productive connections being made across the two fields. This would allow space for femme to remain distinct from heterosexuality where felt as significant, yet also connected. As Hemmings has argued, the homosexual desire of the femme means that heterosexuality too is haunted by the ever-present possibility of "same-sex" desire (1999, 453). A re-focus on desire and relations would also call us to take into account the interesting shifts in feminine embodiment across both queer and straight realms as desires change over time. This is particularly relevant to those who experience bisexual desires, or who change in sexual identification over time, or who may experience only romantic attachments, or no attachments at all. If, for example, one moves from being a femme who sleeps with women to a femme who sleeps with men, we ought not to see this simply as moving from "liberated" feminine embodiment to "oppressed" embodiment. Most importantly, this perspective of femme would be resistant to identity politics models that call upon femme to "do" politics via identification and bodily practices, opening up spaces for femme to be experienced and lived rather than necessarily wilfully expressed. A wider critique of the assumption that feminine presentation goes hand in hand with heterosexual desires can occur, without femmes themselves having to constantly demonstrate this resistance via their own bodies, or experiencing an anxiety to continually get the politics of femme "right".

In recent years commentators on femme have begun to raise problems with the frequent emphasis on wilfulness in queer femme communities, arguing that this focus on intentionality requires a certain amount of privilege (Dahl 2011, 181). While this critique of femme agency is welcome, it is worthwhile considering how the language of "privilege" does not necessarily undo the problems of identity politics that I have presented. Indeed, while the critique of femme intention may lead to finding solidarity through other avenues, without an attendant critique of the problems of investing in *identity* to do political work, the focus may simply shift to focusing on other aspects of identity and embodiment, and may inadvertently leave behind the task of understanding how we might queer femininity

altogether. For example, Dahl suggests, "I am interested in rethinking (queer) femininities by attending to how it articulates with norms around class, race, age, size and aesthetics, in order to investigate the limits and possibilities of alternative understandings of femininity" (2011, 183). While this approach may present us with valuable insights into the intersections of femininity with other norms and expectations, it does not necessarily displace the focus on identity, nor do the work of deconstructing femininity in order to see where commonality between bodies can be found.

Purely viewing femme in representational terms, without considering the experience of femme feminine embodiment, we are led to a world of identity unease in which getting one's individual identification "wrong" can cause dire problems for the community one is in. An example of this unease can be seen in returning to the emphasis on "fat femme" embodiment in the world of queer femme as discussed, noting that such embodiment is often used to exemplify the way femme represents resistance. Although this reclamation of "fat" is intended as liberatory, its practical use as a symbol of femme resistance leads to experiences of anxiety over appearing "too normative". At the Femme Hive Conference, for example, one of the femmes stated on a panel that she often worried about whether she was "fat enough" to be part of fat femme groups. As previously noted, some interview participants also expressed anxiety over emergent femme norms. As Monique described, for example: "Then there's this kind of . . . whether it's just going out, but there's this thing in the back of my head, what will other people think of me? Will I be read as femme? That whole femme enough idea . . . will I be seen as femme enough?" The example of "fat femme" as a model symbol of femme and the anxiety over being "femme enough" point to the expectations placed on femme when the individual is seen as the locus of control/site where politics happens. This attachment to femme as an identity politics can be considered a site of cruel optimism precisely because of the frequent ways in which this attachment turns – as Berlant terms – toxic. That is to say, preoccupation with the politics of femme is antithetical to opening up the possibilities of femme. The attachment to femme as something that one *ought* to do, without first considering what femme *can* do, actively maintains femme as illustrated so far: located in the individual; justified via appeals to wilfulness; fractured from commonality with other feminine-presenting people; and limited in the ability to respond to questions of sexual desire.

Utopian femme(ininity)

Taking the questions of affect and relationality into account, how might we proceed with imagining femme into the future? Furthermore, how might we maintain a desire for political transformation without manifesting this as attachment to a politics founded in identity? As Muñoz writes: "Queerness is a longing that propels us onward, beyond romances of the negative and toiling in the present" (2009, 1). This leads us to ask: where might we glimpse the queer horizon for femme femininity?

As described in chapter three, Muñoz describes moments of astonishment as key to revealing a spark for imagining how things might be different. Such moments were prolific throughout the femme interviews. Participants expressed astonishment with discovering the term "femme", dressing up, and enjoying feminine gender presentation. For example, Natasha expressed astonishment in realising that she could "layer" her feminine presentation, which made her feel liberated:

> I realised a little while after I started stripping, because I was like, oh I wanna cut my hair short and dye it pretty colours and things but I can't because I have to be conventionally attractive at work, and then I realized, I could get a wig. I was like, oh, wow, that makes such a difference! I feel much more comfortable that I can put on my work persona and take it off really easily and I think that helps me be . . . I can be more feminine in everyday life. . . . There we go . . . that's probably what femme means to me.

Here, Natasha describes the style of feminine presentation required in the workplace – concentrated in the object of the wig – as a layer that obscures her femme femininity of her personal life; thus she separates the two realms. Far from seeing femininity as a masquerade that must be challenged, here different styles of the feminine provide room for Natasha to feel comfortable and to experiment with presentation in everyday life outside of work. This ability to transform according to need was a realisation Natasha was astonished by, revealing a glimmer of the femme horizon where the feminine masquerade is understood differently. Interestingly, under Natasha's "stereotypical" feminine layer adopted for work, there is neither androgyny nor masculinity, but indeed another version of femininity. In another example, Audrey described the wonder that is evoked when she dresses up and goes out:

> I do it because I love the creation in myself, but I love the fact that I then go out. It's like, you know, being a performer without being a performer. So I get . . . there's a level of . . . affirmation and vanity in that. And, but there's also just pleasure in actually, you know . . . if something, if I've created an outfit that's more humorous or something, then it's like I really love that people will just be like "oh wow, that's great". Like people just enjoy, and I enjoy that in other people.

Here Audrey not only describes her own pleasure in creating and wearing femme costuming, but also the astonishment of others encountering her curations. This suggests a vision of a femme future where femininity is legitimately delighted in.

Rachel also discussed the feelings that arose when she first tried on "feminine" clothing, providing another example of astonishment:

> I put them on and I realised, oh my god, and I started to cry, cos I feel [tears up] I still feel very emotional about it actually, cos I thought "Where've you been all my life" and when I first saw myself then I knew I wasn't 100% man. Because I saw something looking back in the mirror that I had liked for the first time.

Here, we see how important feminine presentation felt for Rachel and how transformative this moment was. Far from being able to reduce femininity to a simple masquerade, feminine presentation was crucial to how Rachel felt about herself. The queer horizon visible here is one in which feminine styles of the body are valued as bestowing positive feelings, and are not merely reflections of oppressive gender norms.

Though diverse, all of these examples of femme astonishment in relation to the feminine offer a sense of how we might envisage femininity differently going into the future. Foremost, these examples challenge the notion that femininity can only be understood in relation to oppression, and instead they reveal moments of joy and unexpected pleasures that can be found in feminine presentation. Secondly, they all involve a focus on feminine presentation within a broader conversation about femme, and, rather than providing definitions of femme that focus on femme's political power, they are examples of instances of the *experiences* and *feelings* associated with femme femininity. From these occasions we get a glimmer of a femme future – a world where femininity can be layered and experimental, understood as a potential source of wonder and enjoyment, and seen a site of personal growth. This way of reimagining femininity is also evident in an anecdote provided by Daria:

> They did this thing, I think there were women in a concentration camp somewhere, and, they were taking all these donations and stuff. This was years ago, and someone donated like this whole box of red lipsticks and they gave them, and people were saying like "oh why would you give red lipstick to these women that are in a concentration camp sort of situation, or like a refugee sort of thing?" But these women just felt amazing having this red lipstick. Like it was such a luxury. I guess it was sort of taking them out of that situation that they were in, just having this red lipstick. I always think about that having red lipstick.

Whether myth or reality, this story clearly had resonance with Daria, who describes it as something she always thinks about when she puts on red lipstick. In this story we see the same femme horizon as that perceptible in the earlier reflections mentioned: the materials associated with feminine presentation – such as red lipstick – cannot be understood simply as oppressive beauty products; they can also be a source of wonderment.

Looking through the transcripts for moments of astonishment, I was also struck by how often I said "wow" after the participants described aspects of their femme lives: stories of doing sex work; changing their presentation in extreme ways; interacting with their families; getting dressed up; and so on. In other words, the femmes astonished *me*. The femmes often described outfits that made them sound like rare birds of paradise, such as Natasha's comment: "I have this, rainbow, florescent rainbow ruffley bra top thing that I'll wear under a see-through top to go out gaying, because it's amazing. And it's attention grabbing and stuff like that. I think a lot of my femininity is like *look at me, but don't touch me*!" I found myself in awe and

elation as participants shared these moments of pleasure, joy, and sometimes difficulty with me. Some femmes, such as Gemma, also described similar feelings:

> I never ever would have been sexually attracted to femmes in the past. Probably until like the last couple of years, where I feel like maybe I've become more comfortable with saying, "yes, I'm femme and that means this to me", and now I'm like, "oh my god, they're the most amazing women in the world!" Yeah [laughs].

This motif of astonishment – with femmes – is important because it suggests a future in which femme femininity is of interest and admiration. Though femme discourse ought not to be immune from critique, these moments suggest the importance of remembering the marvel of femme embodiment itself. These moments of wonderment felt by participants and myself alike may readily slip into the claim that femme is *empowering* because of the positive associations we can draw from them. However, this astonishment need not slip into a justification for femme identity politics if we maintain a reverence for femme but do not stop challenging it.

From these examples we can see that the future for femme holds much potential. Though we may return to questions of sex and desire in the discourse of femme, these need not involve a return to the past, as if suggesting femme now should be wound back to an earlier time. As these chapters have outlined, the identity of femme holds many interesting insights into gender presentation that should not be elided in a return to a focus on sexuality. Rather, glimpsing the femme future can build from the offerings of femme in the present. Furthermore, as Liz suggested, imagining the femme future is a critical project that has real-world implications:

> Can we actually be having discussions about what we want to be, how we want to be, how we want to feel, how we want to live in the future . . . if we're going to be 60% of the population as an ageing community, what the fuck is going to happen to us as old femmes and butches and transgender and queer people? Like where the hell are we gonna be in 10, 15, 20 years' time?

But as Liz further stated: "What would it mean for us to not feel disenfranchised, and like, oppressed, or you know. What would it feel like as a community to just be being, rather than thinking about what we want to be? You know, as the ideal". In Liz's sentiments we see a hint of a future where femme can just "be".

Implications for collectivisation, femininity, feminism

As this chapter has demonstrated, letting go of the drive to "do" politics via femme embodiment might let us sit with femme femininity and find out what the femme body *can* do. Instead of drawing boundaries between femme and normative femininity, we can see their interconnections, thus forming a new space for collectivity around shared experiences of the sensate, material, and bodily. As Gemma remarked on the question of femme icons: "I like Lady Gaga. But I'm

also convinced that Lady Gaga actually stole her life from me . . . because in fact I wasn't wearing pants well before she wasn't wearing pants". Here, Gemma uses the shared experience of being pants-less – the revealed body – as a way to draw a connection between those she considers femme idols and her own feelings of being femme. Though this example may sound frivolous, rather what we have here is an example of the way that reflecting on the affective aspects of femininity can help to build solidarity across bodies. Similarly, the act of considering the failure involved in femme embodiment might help produce connections across experiences of femininity in ways not fostered by concentrating on femme as an identity held by the individual alone. Further, a return to questions of queer desire and the relationality of femme bodies in encounters with others allows room for femme to be understood as distinct from heterosexual femininity, yet also adds to the prospect of queering heteronormative presumptions made of all feminine bodies. The need for femmes to collectivise around shared oppression rather than *identity* was raised by some lesbian scholars when butch/femme re-emerged in the 1990s (see Blackman and Perry 1990). However, as time has progressed, such commentary appears to have waned.

This chapter has shown that femme discourse, like feminist discourse on femininity, must be subject to critique for the limits it inadvertently poses on the possibilities of being and imagining femme femininity. Insofar as femme retains its cruel attachment to ideas of what femme identity *ought* to do (the idea that it must be political), rather than considering what femme *can do* (a suggestion to sit with femme), the ability to "just be" femme will remain incomplete. Yet this critical approach to femme need not require abandonment of femme altogether. Rather, an affective and queer re-examination of femme reveals all of the facets of femme experience that produce wonderment, awe, and astonishment within and between bodies. Thus, rather than constituting a critical project to dismantle femme, we find that affective and queer approaches allow for a reinvigoration of it. Here, there is a glimmer of a femme future where femme is not only a legitimate subject positon, but also where the pleasures, fascinations, affections, and complexities of femininity are taken seriously rather than always enrolled in a politics of identity.



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

Conclusion

What is queer about femininity?

The aim of *Queering Femininity* has been to open up an understanding of femininity beyond considering it as a sign of oppression. In looking closely at femininity, the focus has been to ruminate on what feminine styles of the body might *do*, rather than what they necessarily *mean*. What has been shown here is that while femininity is often perceived as indicative of passivity, weakness, heterosexuality, objectification, anti-feminism, and/or illness, it is not in fact at odds with conceptions of pleasure, transformation, rupturing expectations, humour, feminism, or queer desire.

Despite this, there remains a theoretical gap in considering femininity outside of recourse to notions of oppression, masquerade, or masculinity. As discussed in the first part of this work, the history of feminist thought has discursively connected feminine styles of the body to female subjugation and marked femininity as both a masquerade and as inherently oppressive as a body practice. Looking at writing from Levy, McRobbie, Walter, and Power, it is clear that a perceived cultural loss of feminism is discussed as intimately connected to and evidenced by contemporary styles of feminine presentation. Though Ahmed's notion of the "feminist killjoy" is important here, in order to take seriously the feminist critiques on offer without simply dismissing them, frequently the object of feminist critique centres on the bodies of women themselves. In these accounts, fake breasts in particular are seen as symbolic of lost feminism, and the feminine female body is marked as always connected to capitalist consumption, problematic if exposed, and performing inauthentic sexual desire. We might wonder why appearance and the body are taken up as symbols of a lost past, rather than comparing how struggle has changed, and the movements and activism that do (or do not) exist in the present, that may appear in different forms. Such perspectives easily lend themselves to feminism as identity/identity as feminism, which must be embodied to be authenticated. Instead we might emphasise feminism as a set of political values that may or *may not* play out at the level of the body, and which might emerge on the surface of the body in messy and contradictory ways. While the feminist texts examined from Moran and Valenti are problematic in some ways, they also demonstrate how feminine styles of the body can be understood differently. Indeed, Moran's and Valenti's works tread the line between attending to individual experiences and appealing to wider structural causes. From these accounts we might

see the potential value of the queer and affective aspects of feminine styles of the body rather than focusing purely on a representational approach to femininity.

Queer approaches on the other hand – aside from those addressing queer femme – have tended to defer to seeing femininity as having queer potential only where an underlying layer of masculinity is perceived. Based on analysis of texts on femme and interviews conducted with femme participants, the latter part of this book turned to consider how we might address the question of the queer potential of femininity through the phenomenon of queer femme specifically. While femme is often thought of as a gender identity that one *is*, feminine style is seen as something one *does*. Analysis of dominant femme discourse reveals that femme identity is seen as distinctly feminist, achieved with a high level of knowingness, is predominately felt as an invisible identity in both queer and straight realms, and is understood as very distinct from heterosexual normative femininity. Examining the strategies of representation promoted in femme discourse reveals a general distancing from femininity perceived as normative and heterosexual – a limitation on the ability of queer femme to challenge social expectations connected with feminine styles of the body. However as shown, the affective and queer dimensions of femme might be drawn out, in order to provide an antidote to the more characteristic representational focus of femme identity politics. Indeed, femme might be understood as an affective assemblage in which material elements come together to create a particular sense of queerness. Such a perspective serves to illustrate the shared bodily connections between femme and so-called heterosexual femininity, and the queer potential of both, in an attempt to provide a bridge and in general to make a case for looking differently at femininity. Considering the queer and affective elements of femme could provide greater space for femme to just "be" than is afforded by constant enrolment in a politics of identity. This is not to argue for femme as an apolitical site but, rather, to take politics out of femme in its specificity and to invigorate political collectivisation on a broader and more dispersed level.

However, though turning to examine affects is helpful for opening up new research questions and directions, it may be limited insofar as it can too greatly stress the affirmative, the random, those things that happen by chance, and more specific individual affects, at the expense of considering structural effects. Similarly, queer theory's postmodern tendencies toward radical unfixity and subversion can create difficulties for appreciating or focusing on the "normal", in this case, heterosexual normative femininity. In considering what is queer about femininity we are forced to confront the idea that we might also have to rethink what counts as "queer" if we are to truly make space for multiple forms of embodiment and presentation in LGBTQ spaces and beyond, where people may simply present however they wish, rather than having their identity enrolled in a politics of presentation.

I can imagine that one response to this position might be to say that the expectations of femininity do not allow us to simply "be" – and more broadly the fact that there are social rules about how one must look, act, and feel means that this concept of "simply being" is utopic at best. While this may be the case, the main point

is specifically to acknowledge that taking gender presentation as *the* site of political investment is both misguided and impotent. Most importantly, all of this is not to say that one should not also be *political*, but it does throw into doubt what the political means, what the objects of our political focus ought to be, and how political action might be best enacted. Here I suggest we turn to Duggan's observation that political *complacency* is the homonormative antagonist of hope for change (in Duggan and Muñoz 2009, 280): from this perspective we should not advocate for the LGBTQ community to be merely content with existing conditions so that people can simply be "who they are". As Duggan suggests, homonormativity is not about how one *looks* or even who one is partnered with, but rather is demonstrated by those advocating neoliberal "nonpolitics" within the LGBTQ community (2002, 177). Fighting what Duggan terms homonormativity need not involve the adoption of particular gendered styles that are "non-normative". Rather, it is the focus on appearance and individual formations of the self that has distracted from attending to these broader concerns and from taking a position that turns outward toward structures of power rather than inward to specific aspects of the self. Here, queering femininity might allow us to see through a lens that understands femininity differently but also suggests the limits of what queering alone can or ought to do.

Queer femininity without anti-normativity

A rethinking of what counts as queer connects with Robyn Wiegman and Elizabeth Wilson's discussions around how to do queer theory without anti-normativity (2015). The point here is to question how queer theory has often positioned itself as against "the norm" and what this does to shore up the coherence of that which is considered "normative". As Wiegman suggests, the point is not necessarily to argue that heterosexuality *is* queer, but rather to understand that making queerness an object lends itself to normativity. As she writes, "[Q]ueer critical desire to champion gender transitivity reveals normativities of its own" (2006, 97). As Wiegman and Wilson also suggest, "In imagining the norm as a device that divides the world into centres and peripheries, antinormativity misses what is most engaging about a norm: that in collating the world, it gathers up everything" (2015, 17). Here Wiegman and Wilson challenge Rubin's suggestion that we might simply understand sexual norms as divided between a charmed inner circle and outer limits, and instead we must see that norms contain much more difference than they do simple divides, consistent boundaries, or unity for easy categorical organisation. As they argue, it is through *insisting* on alterity to a norm that queerness creates a false sense of stability. It appears that the desire of queer to challenge regimes of normalcy ironically and paradoxically works against this aim by creating the impression that a regime of normalcy exists in the first instance.

This effect of falsely cohering normalcy is at play in queer femme identity politics that adopts feminist critiques of femininity. Rather than offering a way of seeing the potential of feminine embodiment to be read as LGBTQ where it would otherwise be read as straight, dominant queer femme discourse often falls

into reinforcing the necessity of queer femme's "difference" from normative femininity. In doing so, a seemingly coherent picture of non-queer femininity (or femininity that is not "queer enough") emerges. While feminism has focused on critiquing norms of femininity, queer theory has looked to celebrating the anti-normative: yet both of these perspectives make the same move to bind the idea of the norm as intelligible and real. As discussed, such an outlook serves to occlude the messiness of gender and the very incoherence that queer perspectives seem to desire. The suggestion I have made throughout this book has been to see femininity queerly, to look at the possible (if not always manifest) capacities that feminine embodiment might engender, and the spaces where pleasure might emerge, in order to challenge the perception that feminine styles are always already problematic. This undoing does not celebrate femininity as empowered – which would merely invert the problematic identified – but simply seeks to trouble the lucidity assumed around feminine norms. Not only does such an undoing make a little more room to do queer theory without anti-normativity, but it also offers a generous space to understand why and how people attach to different gendered embodiments. Significantly, this also suggests that we ought to displace political investments founded in the personal as *the* political, to investigate new sites of enacting power.

Objects of resistance

In suggesting that new sites of resistance need to be found that do not invest in individual embodiments and identities, this is not to say that femininity doesn't *do* things. As I have argued previously for example, femininity marked as "excessive" poses a threat to the gender regime because it is wild and unrestrained and clashes with ideas of "natural" femaleness and what is "appropriate" (McCann 2015b, 249). Though there is no body that is truly "natural" and free from the inscriptions of culture (Thesander 1997, 19), the "excessive" *shows* the workings of culture and putting-on that natural beauty seeks to occlude. The kind of over-the-top femininity displayed by so-called ladettes, and represented on television shows such as *Snog, Marry, Avoid* (BBC 2008), can be considered a form of "queening" that inadvertently reveals the constructedness of gender, and how ideas of "natural beauty" are also created (McCann 2015b, 248). Such embodiments *do* something to show us the machinations of gender, even though they are not "wilful" in the sense promoted by many feminists and queer femmes alike. For some, this might be considered a kind of "resistance", and this is certainly how I have read such embodiments in the past: a will-less resistance. Yet, as I have argued in this book, perhaps even this claim would too readily place resistance at the site of the body, encouraging a kind of identity politics, a doing-through the body that undoes the possibility of seeing femininity queerly in the first instance. Furthermore, to mark certain embodiments as excessive also does work to shore up the norm of naturalness, rather than undo it. However, rather than doing away with wilfulness altogether, we might instead take up Ahmed's "call to arms", to understand the importance of wilfulness to political action (Ahmed 2014, 173),

while also heeding the warnings outlined in this book about placing political investment *in* individual self-embodiment/presentation.

In other words, the argument I am making here is not to do away with ideas of the political, wilfulness, or resistance altogether, but rather to rethink the objects of our politics, wilfulness, and resistance. It is hoped that such a rethinking might offer the possibility of catching a glimmer of a possible future where the options for embodiment and presentation are opened up to radical complexity, dynamism, and experimentation. Importantly, the future of femininity in this ought not to be presumed; I have argued against making femininity a key object that has to be enrolled (be that rejected or endorsed in specific formations) in order to bring this future about.

To consider what femininity "does", and what it feels like, might also be a way to find new modes of collectivity where resistance is not simply found in the specific and the individual. As I have explored, there is much to be found in examining the play, joy, pleasure, fun, failures, sensations, and material assemblages of femininity. But here the body itself is not politics. To examine the femme assemblage, for example, is to disperse the focus on femininity from the individual to the collective, to see points of intersection and connection, even as there may be other very significant differences. This approach need not be isolated to femininity alone. For example, as discussed, much femme literature has focused on the "privileges" of butch masculine-presenting women being easily identifiable as lesbian/queer. Such perspectives reveal a failure to acknowledge the true consequences of this recognition, where butch women are made subject to violence because of their gender difference. It is a gross misrepresentation of butch experience to see this recognition as purely "celebratory". Yet such views also show the problem of seeing a sharp divide between queer femininity and heterosexual femininity: femmes are also subject to gender violence, such as in the form of heterosexual sexist street harassment. We can of course extend this beyond gender alone, to recognise the daily tirades of racist abuse that many people face in public spaces across the West. Or we might consider the way that a man standing in a particular way, or wearing particular clothes might be targeted for the perception that he is sexually "deviant" (and indeed, here we may wish to talk about the connections between femme and male femininity specifically). Different embodiments and appearances might lead to different specific responses, but the broader takeaway message is the same: we would do well to see the commonality in our embodied assemblages that subject us to so many forms of violence, in a myriad of ways. Yet seeing how our bodies and perceived identities are targeted does not mean our bodies can necessarily do the work. Taking into account affective assemblies points to our common bonds, and suggests that violence is a collective issue rather than a solo one. Individual resistance alone – particularly in terms of appearance – maintains the idea that we are alone in our experiences of oppression, and reinvests in the self as the object of resistance.

Furthermore, while bodies may be targeted in different ways while other bodies "pass" in certain instances, this does not mean that we can easily identify a normative regime of appearance that ought to be our target. As I have laboured to point

out, normativity is a fantasy at best, even as it has real effects. Normativity is a symptom of wider machinations of capitalism that would see us divided against one another and organised into particular groups. To identify *precisely* who will always fail and who won't, and in which ways, coheres the normative versus non-normative in ways that misdirect our energies. The aim of all of this must be to see that everyone is failing to meet normative expectations all the time. Everyone's gender has queer potential precisely because of this ever-present failure. However, we generally only imagine failure as going in one direction: not enough. That is, failure as a failure to meet expectations. However we can also understand failure in terms of "too much". This is the realm of the "hyper", the "fake", the "excessive". We often refer to "hyperfemininity" but don't clearly articulate what this means. But we can understand this as meaning the "too much" – too much makeup, too much hair, the heels that are too high, the dress that is too short, the breasts that are too big, the desire that is too rampant, and so on. Interestingly femme often positions itself in this space of the "too much", the overdone, failing femininity. However, we ought not to rely on the "too much" (or the "not enough") as our site of resistance because a new norm inevitably fills this space – the norms of not being "too much" or "not enough" (expressed as "not queer enough"). In this way, I take the idea of queer failure to be incredibly useful, but I disagree with Halberstam that "all our failures combined might just be enough, if we practice them well, to bring down the winner" (2011, 120). Under such a rubric, those femmes who would dance around so-called normativity, who manage to "pass" as heterosexual, and who fail to fail enough are sidelined as irrelevant, or assimilationist. Such a view misses the necessity of adaptability to normative fantasies, and the need to pass, or the desire to. While we might imagine a world where our desires could go in different and changing experimental directions, it cannot be overlooked that imagined normative spaces offer cruel but necessary shelters. With this recognition we need not celebrate norms or anti-norms as emancipatory, but rather see that the necessity of such spaces only emerges under conditions where survival is key.

Concluding thoughts

Exploring feminist and femme texts has yielded some surprising findings. Of particular note is the discovery of the limits of representational approaches in yielding a full picture of what femininity "does". Feminist discourse's long history of connecting feminine styles with oppression has had ongoing effects: femme's attachment to feminism can cause a paradox in its understanding of femininity as both an enjoyable style and as a problematic masquerade. These realisations have been difficult to discuss as this book has progressed due to my own fear of seeming antagonistic to, or outside of, feminist theory. Here, my own attachment to feminism has meant several re-writes of various chapters, in the process of which I have had to negotiate between generous and more critical readings of the feminist texts in an attempt to challenge their representational focus. I have developed the sense that perhaps the most salient cruel optimism evident in the

background of both feminist and femme texts is an attachment to a particular version of feminism past where a critique of so-called normative femininity is seen as important and inevitable.

The question that remains at the conclusion of this book is how this project might contribute to making feminine lives more liveable. In drawing out the elements of feminine failure, pleasure, play, joy, transformation, laughter, bodies, sensations, attachments, and utopia, what have we gained? Hopefully the answer flowing from this work is a richer understanding of feminine styles of the body and, as such, more room for femininity to be seen as something of *interest* rather than something that necessarily indicates a problem of oppression. Importantly, I have hinted at possibilities for collectivity based on the shared affects and queer possibilities of femininity that have been outlined. The favoured approach has been to make space for identity but to be critical of identity politics, where politics is seen to be enacted at the level of the individual body. I have also highlighted glimmers of a feminine utopia, where the future of femininity is unclear but still full of potential. I have advocated for giving the individual a break (as it were) by taking attachments to femininity seriously, without dismissing them. Ultimately, what is hoped for here is recognition of the things we share *as human beings* living through gender. As Berlant might also suggest, what is essential is a shared recognition of precarity, and of the difficulties of the present, along with a sense of being in it together. This suggests that we ought not to scorn the Effie Trinkets of the world, attached as they are to feminine styles. Though femininity can be humorous, it is no laughing matter.

As Janet Jakobsen highlights, there was a tendency for papers in gay and lesbian studies in the 1990s to end with the invocation and general gesture toward "queer" (1998, 511). Arguably this tendency persists – though hopefully in *beginning* this book with the purpose of offering a "queering" of femininity, I have avoided some of the pitfalls of this open-ended movement that can never reach its destination. As Jakobsen also argues, using queer as a verb must mean "to do different and to make a particular set of relations that are different from the binary oppositions defined by the norm" (1998, 528). Yet I have also argued that in undertaking queering we might extend this orientation toward solidarity further, beyond identity and into materiality, corporeality, sensation, pleasure, the organic, the non-organic, and more. The upshot of all this is that hopefully what is queer about femininity is now somewhat more clear, rather than held off for a future "queer". Femininity is queer because nothing is normative: it is the fiction of the norm, rather than the queer, that we keep on the horizon and that we often strive cruelly toward, even (perhaps especially) as we aim to resist and subvert this fiction. Recognising this might free up some space to rethink the here and now, to make strange what is already before us, and to reconsider the political objects that we invest in as we aim to create a better world. This is not to say that "queering" femininity is all that is needed – in fact quite the opposite: as I have suggested here, perhaps we need to consider the benefits of seeing and reading identity and experience differently, in ways that do not locate the political *in* the intricacies of the personal. If there is any future-oriented gesture in this book, it

is the encouragement to further explore this question: what happens if we do not invest in individual identity formations as our source of power and transformation? From this starting point we might find that revolution is possible in the here and now, rather than always remaining a promise, a glimmer of a future that can never arrive.

References

Adkins, Lisa 2004. "Passing on Feminism: From Consciousness to Reflexivity?" *European Journal of Women's Studies* 11 (4): 427–44.

Ahmed, Sara. 2006. *Queer Phenomenology: Orientations, Objects, Others*. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

———. 2010a. "Killing Joy: Feminism and the History of Happiness". *Signs* 35 (3): 571–94.

———. 2010b. *The Promise of Happiness*. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

———. 2014. *Willful Subjects*. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

Albrecht-Samarasinha, Leah Lilith. 1997. "On Being a Bisexual Femme". In *Femme: Feminists, Lesbians, and Bad Girls*, edited by Laura Harris and Elizabeth Crocker, 138–44. New York; London: Routledge.

Alcoff, Linda. 1992. "The Problem of Speaking for Others". *Cultural Critique* 20: 5–32.

Alcoff, Linda Martin, and Satya P. Mohanty. 2006. "Reconsidering Identity Politics: An Introduction". In *Identity Politics Reconsidered*, edited by Linda Martin Alcoff, Michael Hames-Garcia, Satya P. Mohanty, and Paula M. L. Moya, 1–9. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.

Anderson, Deborah. 2002. "Fading Femme". In *Brazen Femme: Queering Femininity*, 2010 ed., edited by Chloë Brushwood Rose and Anna Camilleri, 43–4. Vancouver: Arsenal Pulp Press.

Appignanesi, Lisa, Rachel Holmes, and Susie Orbach, eds. 2013. *Fifty Shades of Feminism*. London: Virago Press.

Armstrong, Elizabeth A., Laura Hamilton, and Paula England. 2010. "Is Hooking up Bad for Young Women?" *Contexts* 9 (3): 22–7.

Arnold, Rebecca. 2001. *Fashion, Desire and Anxiety: Image and Morality in the 20th Century*. New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press.

Atkins, Dawn. 1998. "Introduction: Looking Queer". In *Looking Queer: Body Image and Identity in Lesbian, Bisexual, Gay, and Transgender Communities*, edited by Dawn Atkins, xxix–li. New York: Haworth Press.

Badiou, Alain. 2004. "Behind the Scarfed Law, There Is Fear". *IslamOnline.net*. www.lacan.com/islbad.htm.

Baker, Sarah Elsie. 2016. "A Glamorous Feminism by Design?" *Cultural Studies* 31(1). Taylor & Francis: 47–69.

Bale, Clare. 2011. "Raunch or Romance? Framing and Interpreting the Relationship between Sexualized Culture and Young People's Sexual Health". *Sex Education* 11 (3): 303–13.

Banet-Weiser, Sarah, and Laura Portwood-Stacer. 2006. "'I Just Want to Be Me Again!': Beauty Pageants, Reality Television and Post-Feminism". *Feminist Theory* 7 (2): 255–72.

Barnard, Malcolm. 1996. *Fashion as Communication*. London; New York: Routledge.

Bartky, Sandra Lee. 1990. *Femininity and Domination: Studies in the Phenomenology of Oppression*. New York: Routledge.

———. 1997. "Foucault, Femininity, and the Modernization of Patriarchal Power". In *Writing on the Body: Female Embodiment and Feminist Theory*, edited by Katie Conboy, Nadia Medina, and Sarah Stanbury, 129–54. New York: Columbia University Press.

Bates, Laura. 2014. *Everyday Sexism*. London: Simon & Schuster.

———. 2016. *Girl Up*. London: Simon & Schuster.

Baumgardner, Jennifer, and Amy Richards. 2010. *Manifesta [10th Anniversary Edition]: Young Women, Feminism, and the Future*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux.

BBC. 2008. "Snog, Marry, Avoid Season One". United Kingdom: Remarkable Television.

Beauvoir, Simone de. 1953. *The Second Sex*. Edited by H. M. Parshley [Trans.]. 1997 ed. London: Vintage Books.

Beins, Agatha. 2015. "Radical Others: Women of Color and Revolutionary Feminism". *Feminist Studies* 41 (1): 150–83.

Bell, David, Jon Binnie, Julia Cream, and Gill Valentine. 1994. "All Hyped up and No Place to Go". *Gender, Place and Culture* 1 (1): 31–47.

Berlant, Lauren. 2007. "Cruel Optimism: On Marx, Loss and the Senses". *New Formations* 63: 33–51.

———. 2008. *The Female Complaint: The Unfinished Business of Sentimentality in American Culture*. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

———. 2011. *Cruel Optimism*. Durham: Duke University Press.

Berlant, Lauren, and Michael Warner. 1998. "Sex in Public". *Critical Inquiry* 24 (2): 547–66.

Bersani, Leo. 1987. "Is the Rectum a Grave?" *AIDS: Cultural Analysis/Cultural Activism* 43: 197–222.

Blackman, Inge, and Kathryn Perry. 1990. "Skirting the Issue: Lesbian Fashion for the 1990s". *Feminist Review* 34 (1): 67–78.

Blair, Karen L., and Rhea Ashley Hoskin. 2015. "Experiences of Femme Identity: Coming Out, Invisibility and Femmephobia". *Psychology & Sexuality* 6 (3): 229–44.

Bordo, Susan. 1993. *Unbearable Weight: Feminism, Western Culture, and the Body*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

———. 1997. "The Body and the Reproduction of Femininity". In *Writing on the Body: Female Embodiment and Feminist Theory*, edited by Katie Conboy, Nadia Medina, and Sarah Stanbury, 90–110. New York: Columbia University Press.

Bornstein, Kate. 1994. *Gender Outlaw: On Men, Women and the Rest of Us*. New York; London: Routledge.

Bourdieu, Pierre. 1984. *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Boxer, Marilyn J. 2002. "Women's Studies as Women's History". *Women's Studies Quarterly* 30 (3–4): 42–51.

Braidotti, Rosi. 1996. "Cyberfeminism with a Difference". In *New Formations*, no. 29, edited by Michael Peters, Mark Olssen, and Colin Lankshear, 9–25. Oxford: Rowman & Littlefield.

Branlandingham, Bevin. 2015. "Queer Fat Femme Guide to Life". Accessed March 18. http://queerfatfemme.com/.

Brennan, Samantha. 2011. "Fashion and Sexual Identity, or Why Recognition Matters". In *Fashion: Philosophy for Everyone: Thinking with Style*, edited by Jeanette Kennett and Jessica Wolfendale, 120–34. Oxford: Wiley-Blackwell.

Britton, Luke Morgan. 2017. "Katy Perry on 'I Kissed a Girl': 'Truth Be Told, I Did More Than That'". *NME*. www.nme.com/news/music/katy-perry-i-kissed-a-girl-did-more-than-that-2023048.

Brown, Jeffrey A. 2005. "Class and Feminine Excess: The Strange Case of Anna Nicole Smith". *Feminist Review* 81: 74–94.

Brownmiller, Susan. 1984. *Femininity*. New York: Linden Press.

Brushwood Rose, Chloe, and Anna Camilleri. 2002. "Introduction: A Brazen Posture". In *Brazen Femme: Queering Femininity*, edited by Chloe Brushwood Rose and Anna Camilleri, 2010 ed., 11–14. Vancouver: Arsenal Pulp Press.

Bulbeck, Chilla. 2011. " 'Faux Feminism' Vs the Real Thing". *Australian Feminist Studies* 26 (68): 229–37.

Butler, David. 1953. *Calamity Jane*. United States of America: Warner Bros.

Butler, Judith. 1990. *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity*. 2008 ed. New York; London: Routledge.

———. 1999. "Revisiting Bodies and Pleasures". *Theory, Culture & Society* 16 (2): 11–20.

———. 2004. *Undoing Gender*. New York: Routledge.

Calasanti, Toni M., and Kathleen F. Slevin. 2001. *Gender, Social Inequalities, and Aging*. New York: Altamira Press.

Carroll, Bret E. 2004. *American Masculinities: A Historical Encyclopedia*. Edited by Bret E. Carroll. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications.

Carter, Connie, and Jean Noble. 1996. "Butch, Femme, and the Woman-Identified Woman". *Canadian Woman Studies/Les Cahiers de La Femme* 16: 24–29.

Case, Sue-Ellen. 1993a. "Book Review: The Persistent Desire". *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies* 1: 79–82.

———. 1993b. "Toward a Butch-Femme Aesthetic". In *The Lesbian and Gay Studies Reader*, edited by Henry Abelove, Michele Aina Barale, and David M. Halperin, 294–306. New York; London: Routledge.

Chisholm, Kami, and Elizabeth Stark. 2006. *FtF: Female to Femme*. USA: Frameline.

Clare Burke, Jennifer. 2009. "Introduction". In *Visible: A Femmethology*. Volume 1, edited by Jennifer Clare Burke, 11–13. Michigan: Homofactus Press.

Clark, Danae. 1991. "Commodity Lesbianism". *Camera Obscura* 9 (1–2): 181–201.

Cockburn, Cynthia. 2007. *From Where We Stand: War, Women's Activism and Feminist Analysis*. London: Zed Books.

Connell, R. W. 1987. *Gender and Power: Society, the Person and Sexual Politics*. Sydney: Allen & Unwin.

———. 1995. *Masculinities*. Berkeley; Los Angeles: Polity Press.

———. 2002. *Gender*. Cambridge, UK: Polity Press.

Connell, R. W., and James W. Messerschmidt. 2005. "Hegemonic Masculinity: Rethinking the Concept". *Gender & Society* 19 (6): 829–59.

Cooper, Charlotte. 2010. "Fat Studies: Mapping the Field". *Sociology Compass* 4 (12): 1020–34.

Cooper, Charlotte, and Samantha Murray. 2012. "Fat Activist Community: A Conversation Piece". *Somatechnics* 2 (1): 127–38.

Cosslett, Rhiannon Lucy, and Holly Baxter. 2014. *The Vagenda: A Zero Tolerance Guide to the Media*. London: Vintage Publishing.

Coy, Maddy, and Maria Garner. 2010. "Glamour Modelling and the Marketing of Self-Sexualization: Critical Reflections". *International Journal of Cultural Studies* 13 (6): 657–75.

Coyote, Ivan E., and Zena Sharman. 2011. "Introduction". In *Persistence: All Ways Butch and Femme*, edited by Ivan E. Coyote and Zena Sharman, 23–6. Vancouver: Arsenal Pulp Press.

Cranny-Francis, Anne, Wendy Waring, Pam Stravropoulos, and Joan Kirkby. 2003. *Gender Studies: Terms and Debates*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.

Creed, Barbara. 1995. "Lesbian Bodies: Tribades, Tomboys and Tarts". In *Sexy Bodies: The Strange Carnalities of Feminism*, edited by Elizabeth Grosz and Elspeth Probyn, 86–103. London; New York: Routledge.

Crenshaw, Kimberle. 1991. "Mapping the Margins: Intersectionality, Identity Politics, and Violence against Women of Color". *Stanford Law Review* 43 (6): 1241–99.

Dahl, Ulrika and Del LaGrace Volcano. 2008. "Introduction". In *Femininities, Femmes of Power: Exploding Queer*, edited by Del LaGrace Volcano and Ulrika Dahl, 18–26. London: Serpent's Tail.

Dahl, Ulrika. 2010. "Femme on Femme: Reflections in Collaboration Methods and Queer Femme-Inist Ethnography". In *Queer Methods and Methodologies: Intersecting Queer Theories and Social Science Research*, edited by Kath Browne and Catherine J. Nash, 143–66. Farnham; Burlington: Ashgate.

———. 2011. "Notes on Femme-Inist Agency". In *Sexuality, Gender and Power: Intersectional and Transnational Perspectives*, edited by Anna G. Jónasdóttir, Valerie Bryson and Kathleen B. Jones, 172–88. New York: Routledge.

———. 2014. "White Gloves, Feminist Fists: Race, Nation and the Feeling of 'vintage' in Femme Movements". *Gender, Place & Culture* 21 (5): 604–21.

Dean, Jonathan. 2012. "On the March or on the Margins? Affirmations and Erasures of Feminist Activism in the UK". *European Journal of Women's Studies* 19 (3): 315–29.

Deleuze, Gilles. 1969. *The Logic of Sense*. Edited by Constantin V. Boundas and Mark Lester [Trans.]. 1990 ed. London: The Athlone Press.

Diamond, L. M. 2005. "'I'm Straight but I Kissed a Girl': The Trouble with American Media Representations of Female-Female Sexuality". *Feminism & Psychology* 15 (1): 104–10.

Diprose, Rosalyn. 2002. *Corporeal Generosity: On Giving with Nietzsche, Merleau-Ponty, and Levinas*. New York: State University of New York Press.

Dole, Carol M. 2008. "The Return of Pink: Legally Blonde, Third-Wave Feminism, and Having It All". In *Chick Flicks: Contemporary Women at the Movies*, edited by Suzanne Ferriss and Mallory Young, 58–78. New York: Routledge.

Dove-Viebahn, Aviva. 2007. "Fashionably Femme: Lesbian Visibility, Style, and Politics in the L Word". In *Queer Popular Culture: Literature, Media, Film, and Television*, edited by Thomas Peele, 71–83. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.

Driscoll, Catherine. 2002. *Girls: Feminine Adolescence in Popular Culture and Cultural Theory*. New York: Columbia University Press.

Duggan, Lisa. 2002. "The New Homonormativity: The Sexual Politics of Neoliberalism". In *Materializing Democracy: Toward a Revitalized Cultural Politics*, edited by Russ Castronovo and Dana D. Nelson, 175–94. Durham: Duke University Press.

Duggan, Lisa, Nan D. Hunter, and Carole S. Vance. 1985. "False Promises: Feminist Antipornography Legislation". In *Sex Wars: Sexual Dissent and Political Culture*, edited by Lisa Duggan and Nan D. Hunter, 1995 ed., 43–65. New York: Routledge.

Duggan, Lisa, and Kathleen McHugh. 1996. "A Fem(me)inist Manifesto". *Women & Performance: A Journal of Feminist Theory* 8 (2): 153–9.

Duggan, Lisa, and José Esteban Muñoz. 2009. "Hope and Hopelessness: A Dialogue". *Women & Performance: A Journal of Feminist Theory* 19 (2): 275–83.

Dunham, Lena. 2014. *Not That Kind of Girl: A Young Woman Tells You What She's "Learned"*. New York: Random House.

Dux, Monica, and Zora Simic. 2008. *The Great Feminist Denial*. Melbourne: Melbourne University Press.

Edley, Nigel, and Margaret Wetherell. 1995. *Men in Perspective: Practice, Power and Identity*. Hertfordshire: Prentice Hall/Harvester Wheatsheaf.

Entwistle, Joanne. 2000. *The Fashioned Body: Fashion, Dress and Modern Social Theory*. Cambridge: Polity Press.

Evans, Adrienne, Sarah Riley, and Avi Shankar. 2010. "Technologies of Sexiness: Theorizing Women's Engagement in the Sexualization of Culture". *Feminism & Psychology* 20 (1): 114–31.

Evans, Caroline, and Minna Thornton. 1991. "Fashion, Representation, Femininity". *Feminist Review* 38: 48–66.

Eves, Alison 2004. "Queer Theory, Butch/Femme Identities and Lesbian Space". *Sexualities* 7 (4): 480–96.

Faderman, Lillian. 1991. *Odd Girls and Twilight Lovers: A History of Lesbian Life in Twentieth-Century America*. New York: Penguin Books.

———. 1992. "The Return of Butch and Femme: A Phenomenon in Lesbian Sexuality of the 1980s and 1990s". *Journal of the History of Sexuality* 2 (4): 578–96.

Feinberg, Leslie. 1993. *Stone Butch Blues: A Novel*. Ithica: Firebrand Books.

"Femme Hive". 2015. http://femmehive.com/about/femmehive/.

Ferreday, Debra. 2007. "Adapting Femininities: The New Burlesque". *M/C Journal* 10 (2).

———. 2008. " 'Showing the Girl': The New Burlesque". *Feminist Theory* 9 (1): 47–65.

———. 2012. "Anorexia and Abjection: A Review Essay". *Body & Society* 18 (2): 139–55.

Ferreday, Debra, and Rebecca Coleman. 2010. "Introduction: Hope and Feminist Theory". *Journal for Cultural Research* 14 (4): 313–21.

Fey, Tina. 2011. *Bossypants*. New York: Little, Brown and Company.

Finley, N. J. 2010. "Skating Femininity: Gender Maneuvering in Women's Roller Derby". *Journal of Contemporary Ethnography* 39 (4): 359–87.

Flood, Michael, Judith Kegan Gardiner, Bob Pease, and Keith Pringle. 2007. "Introduction". In *International Encyclopedia of Men and Masculinities*, edited by Michael Flood, Judith Kegan Gardiner, Bob Pease, and Keith Pringle, vii–x. New York; London: Routledge.

"FNLS Event 1: The Canberra Femme Collective Spring Picnic at Floriade". 2012. www.youtube.com/watch?v=eisRCSxEaCo.

Foucault, Michel. 1972. *The Archaeology of Knowledge and the Discourse on Language*. Edited by A. M. Sheridan Smith [Trans.]. New York: Pantheon Books.

———. 1976. *The History of Sexuality*. Volume 1. Edited by Robert Hurley [Trans.]. Victoria: Penguin Group.

———. 1979. *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*. Edited by Alan Sheridan. New York: Vintage Books.

Fraser, Nancy. 1995. "From Redistribution to Recognition? Dilemmas of Justice in a 'Post-Socialist' Age." *New Left Review* 1 (212): 68–93.

———. 1999. "Social Justice in the Age of Identity Politics: Redistribution, Recognition, and Participation". In *Culture and Economy after the Cultural Turn*, edited by Larry Ray and Andrew Sayer, 25–52. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications.

———. 2005. "Mapping the Feminist Imagination: From Redistribution to Recognition to Representation". *Constellations* 12 (3): 295–307.

Freeman, Elizabeth. 2010. *Time Binds: Queer Temporalities, Queer Histories*. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

Freud, Sigmund. 1965. "Lecture XXXIII: Femininity". In *New Introductory Lectures on Psychoanalysis*, edited by James Stratchey [Trans.], 112–35. New York: W. W. Norton & Company.

Friedan, Betty. 1963. *The Feminine Mystique*. 1974 ed. New York: W. W. Norton & Company.

Galewski, Elizabeth. 2005. "Figuring the Feminist Femme". *Women's Studies in Communication* 28 (2): 183–206.

Gamson, Joshua. 1995. "Must Identity Movements Self-Destruct? A Queer Dilemma". *Social Problems* 42 (3): 390–407.

Gay, Roxane. 2014. *Bad Feminist*. London: Corsair.

Gibson, Michelle, and Deborah T. Meem. 2002. "Introduction: The Way We Want to Go". In *Femme/Butch: New Considerations of the Way We Want to Go*, edited by Michelle Gibson and Deborah T. Meem, 3–8. New York: Harrington Park Press.

Gill, Rosalind. 2003. "From Sexual Objectification to Sexual Subjectification: The Resexualisation of Women's Bodies in the Media". *Feminist Media Studies* 3 (1): 100–6.

———. 2008. "Empowerment/Sexism: Figuring Female Sexual Agency in Contemporary Advertising". *Feminism & Psychology* 18 (1): 35–60.

———. 2009. "Beyond the 'Sexualization of Culture' Thesis: An Intersectional Analysis of 'Sixpacks', 'Midriffs' and 'Hot Lesbians' in Advertising". *Sexualities* 12 (2): 137–60.

———. 2011. "Sexism Reloaded, Or, It's Time to Get Angry Again!" *Feminist Media Studies* 11 (1): 61–71.

———. 2012. "Media, Empowerment and the 'Sexualization of Culture' Debates". *Sex Roles* 66 (11–12): 736–45.

Gillis, Stacy, and Rebecca Munford. 2004. "Genealogies and Generations: The Politics and Praxis of Third Wave Feminism". *Women's History Review* 13 (2): 165–82.

Green, Adam Isaiah. 2002. "Gay but Not Queer: Toward a Post-Queer Study of Sexuality". *Theory and Society* 31 (4): 521–45.

Greer, Germaine. 1970. *The Female Eunuch*. London: MacGibbon & Kee.

Guild, Sydney Femme. 2016. "Sydney Femme Guild". http://femmeguild.com/.

Halberstam, Jack. 1996. "Lesbian Masculinity or Even Stone Butches Get the Blues". *Women & Performance: A Journal of Feminist Theory* 8 (2): 61–73.

———. 1998. *Female Masculinity*. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

———. 2005. "Shame and White Gay Masculinity". *Social Text* 8485 (23): 3–4.

———. 2011. *The Queer Art of Failure*. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

———. 2012. *Gaga Feminism: Sex, Gender, and the End of Normal*. Boston: Beacon Press.

Hall, Marny. 1986. "The Lesbian Corporate Experience". *Journal of Homosexuality* 12 (3–4): 59–74.

Harris, Anita, and Amy Shields Dobson. 2015. "Theorizing Agency in Post-Girlpower Times". *Continuum* 29 (2): 145–56.

Harris, Laura, and Elizabeth Crocker. 1997. "An Introduction to Sustaining Femme Gender". In *Femme: Feminists, Lesbians, and Bad Girls*, edited by Laura Harris and Liz Crocker, 1–12. New York; London: Routledge.

Hearn, Jeff. 2013. "Men, Masculinity and Masculinities". In *Gender: The Key Concepts*, edited by Mary Evans and Carolyn H. Williams, 149–56. London; New York: Routledge.

Heath, Stephen. 1986. "Joan Riviere and the Masquerade". In *Formations of Fantasy*, edited by Victor Burgin, James Donald, and Cora Kaplan, 45–61. London; New York: Routledge.

Hekman, Susan. 2014. *The Feminine Subject*. Cambridge: Polity Press.

Hemmings, Clare. 1999. "Out of Sight, Out of Mind? Theorizing Femme Narrative". *Sexualities* 2 (4): 451–64.

———. 2005. "Telling Feminist Stories". *Feminist Theory* 6 (2): 115–39.

Holland, Samantha. 2004. *Alternative Femininities: Body, Age and Identity*. Oxford; New York: Berg.

Holliday, Ruth, and Jacqueline Sanchez Taylor. 2006. "Aesthetic Surgery as False Beauty". *Feminist Theory* 7 (2): 179–95.

Hollows, Joanne. 2000. *Feminism, Femininity and Popular Culture*. Manchester: Manchester University Press.

Horn, Katrin. 2010. "Camping with the Stars: Queer Performativity, Pop Intertextuality, and Camp in the Pop Art of Lady Gaga". *Current Objectives of Postgraduate American Studies* 11: 1–16.

Hudson, Barbara. 1984. "Femininity and Adolescence". In *Gender and Generation*, edited by Angela McRobbie and Mica Nava, 31–53. Houndmills, Basingstoke, Hampshire; London: Macmillan.

Huyssen, Andreas. 1986. "Mass Culture as Woman: Modernism's Other". In *Studies in Entertainment: Critical Approaches to Mass Culture*, edited by Tania Modleski, 188–207. Bloomington; Indianapolis: Indiana University Press.

Jackson, Carolyn. 2006a. *Lads and Ladettes in School: Gender and a Fear of Failure*. New York: Open University Press.

———. 2006b. "'Wild' Girls? An Exploration of 'Ladette' Cultures in Secondary Schools". *Gender and Education* 18 (4): 339–60.

Jackson, Carolyn, and Penny Tinkler. 2007. "'Ladettes' and 'Modern Girls': 'Troublesome' Young Femininities". *Sociological Review* 55 (2): 251–72.

Jakobsen, Janet R. 1998. "Queer Is? Queer Does? Normativity and the Problem of Resistance". *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies* 4 (4): 511–36.

Jeffreys, Sheila. 2005. *Beauty and Misogyny: Harmful Cultural Practices in the West*. London; New York: Routledge.

Jennings, Rebecca. 2015. *Unnamed Desires: A Sydney Lesbian History*. Clayton, Vic: Monash University Publishing.

Karyln, Kathleen Rowe. 2011. *Unruly Girls, Unrepentant Mothers: Redefining Feminism on Screen*. Austin: University of Texas Press.

Kennedy, Rosanne, Jonathon Zapasnik, Hannah McCann, and Miranda Bruce. 2013. "All Those Little Machines: Assemblage as Transformative Theory". *Australian Humanities Review* 55: 45–66.

Kinser, Amber E. 2004. "Negotiating Spaces for/through Third-Wave Feminism". *NWSA Journal* 16 (3): 124–53.

Kiraly, Miranda, and Meagan Tyler. 2015. "Introduction". In *Freedom Fallacy: The Limits of Liberal Feminism*, edited by Miranda Kiraly and Meagan Tyler, x–xvii. Ballan: Connor Court Publishing Pty Ltd.

Krakauer, Ilana D., and Suzanna M. Rose. 2002. "The Impact of Group Membership on Lesbians' Physical Appearance". *Journal of Lesbian Studies* 6 (1): 31–43.

Lazar, Michelle M. 2006. "Discover the Power of Femininity!" *Feminist Media Studies* 6 (4): 505–17.

Lee, Janet. 2009. "Bodies at Menarche: Stories of Shame, Concealment, and Sexual Maturation". *Sex Roles* 60: 615–27.

Levitt, Heidi M., Elisabeth A. Gerrish, and Katherine R. Hiestand. 2003. "The Misunderstood Gender: A Model of Modern Femme Identity". *Sex Roles* 48 (3–4): 99–113.

Levitt, Heidi M., and Katherine R. Hiestand. 2004. "A Quest for Authenticity: Contemporary Butch Gender". *Sex Roles* 50 (9–10): 605–21.

———. 2005. "Gender within Lesbian Sexuality: Butch and Femme Perspectives". *Journal of Constructivist Psychology* 18 (1): 39–51. doi:10.1080/10720530590523062.

Levitt, Heidi M., and Sharon G. Horne. 2002. "Explorations of Lesbian-Queer Genders: Butch, Femme, Androgynous or 'Other'". *Journal of Lesbian Studies* 6 (2): 25–39.

Levy, Ariel. 2005. *Female Chauvinist Pigs: Women and the Rise of Raunch Culture*. [2010]. Collingwood: Black Inc.

Littler, Jo. 2013. "The Rise of the 'Yummy Mummy': Popular Conservatism and the Neoliberal Maternal in Contemporary British Culture". *Communication, Culture & Critique* 6 (2): 227–43.

Love, Heather. 2011. "Queers____This". In *After Sex? On Writing Since Queer Theory*, edited by Janet Halley and Andrew Parker, 180–91. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

Luketic, Robert. 2001. *Legally Blonde*. United States of America: Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer.

Marcuse, Herbert. 1964. *One-Dimensional Man: Studies in the Ideology of Advanced Industrial Society*. 2002 ed. London; New York: Routledge.

Martin, Biddy. 1996. *Femininity Played Straight: The Significance of Being Lesbian*. New York; London: Routledge.

Martin, Courtney E. 2007. *Perfect Girls, Starving Daughters: The Frightening New Normalcy of Hating Your Body*. New York: Free Press.

Marwick, Alice. 2010. "There's a Beautiful Girl Under All of This: Performing Hegemonic Femininity in Reality Television". *Critical Studies in Media Communication* 27 (3): 251–66.

McCann, Hannah. 2013. "Masculinity behind the Masquerade: The Problem of Reading Queer Femininity". In *Queer Sexualities: Diversifying Queer, Queering Diversity*, edited by Vikki Fraser. Interdisciplinarypress.net.

———. 2015a. "Finding Femme". *Feminartsy*. http://feminartsy.com/?p=623.

———. 2015b. "Pantomime Dames". *Australian Feminist Studies* 30 (85): 238–51.

———. 2016. "Epistemology of the Subject: Queer Theory's Challenge to Feminist Sociology." *WSQ: Women's Studies Quarterly* 44 (3–4): 224–43.

McCue, Jennifer Anne. 2014. "Empowering the Female Voice: Interdisciplinarity, Feminism, and the Memoir". *Journal of Integrated Studies* 5 (1): 1–10.

McDonald, Tamar Jeffers. 2007. "Carrying Concealed Weapons: Gendered Makeover in 'Calamity Jane'". *Journal of Popular Film and Television* 34 (4): 179–86.

McRobbie, Angela. 1978. "Working Class Girls and the Culture of Femininity". In *Women Take Issue: Aspects of Women's Subordiantion*, edited by Women's Studies Group Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies, 96–108. London: Hutchison of London.

———. 1991. *Feminism and Youth Culture: From "Jackie" to "Just Seventeen"*. Boston: Unwin Hyman.

———. 1994. *Postmodernism and Popular Culture*. London; New York: Routledge.

———. 2009. *The Aftermath of Feminism: Gender, Culture and Social Change*. Los Angeles; London; Thousand Oaks: Sage Publications.

———. 2011. "Reflections On Feminism, Immaterial Labour and the Post-Fordist Regime". *New Formations* 70 (70): 60–76.

McWhorter, Ladelle. 1999. *Bodies and Pleasures: Foucault and the Politics of Sexual Normalization*. Bloomington; Indianapolis: Indiana University Press.

Mendes, Kaitlynn 2012. " 'Feminism Rules! Now, Where's My Swimsuit?' Re-Evaluating Feminist Discourse in Print Media 1968–2008". *Media, Culture & Society* 34 (5): 554–70.

Milkie, Melissa A. 2002. "Contested Images of Femininity: An Analysis of Cultural Gatekeepers' Struggles with the 'Real Girl' Critique". *Gender & Society* 16 (6): 839–59.

Miller, Michelle. 2008. *Branding Miss G: Third Wave Feminists and the Media*. Toronto: Sumach Press.

Mills, Sara, and Louise Mullany. 2011. *Language, Gender and Feminism: Theory, Methodology and Practice*. New York: Routledge.

Minichiello, Victor, Rosalie Aroni, Eric Timewell, and Loris Alexander. 1995. *In-Depth Interviewing: Principles, Techniques, Analysis*. 2nd ed. Sydney: Longman.

Moran, Caitlin. 2011. *How to Be a Woman*. [2012]. London: Ebury Press.

———. 2012. *Moranthology*. London: Ebury Press.

———. 2014. *How to Build a Girl*. London: Ebury Press.
Morgan, Robin. 1970a. "Introduction: The Women's Revolution". In *Sisterhood Is Powerful: An Anthology of Writings from the Women's Liberation Movement*, edited by Robin Morgan, xiii–xl. New York: Vintage Books.
———, ed. 1970b. "No More Miss America! August 1968". In *Sisterhood Is Powerful: An Anthology of Writings from the Women's Liberation Movement*, 521–4. New York: Vintage Books.
Muncer, Steven, Anne Campbell, Victoria Jervis, and Rachel Lewis. 2001. "'Ladettes,' Social Representations, and Aggression". *Sex Roles* 44 (1–2): 33–44.
Muñoz, José Esteban. 2009. *Crusing Utopia: The Then and There of Queer Futurity*. New York; London: New York University Press.
Munt, Sally R. 1998. "Introduction". In *Butch/Femme: Inside Lesbian Gender*, edited by Sally R. Munt, 1–11. London; Washington: Cassell.
Murray, Samantha. 2004. "Locating Aesthetics: Sexing the Fat Woman". *Social Semiotics* 14 (3): 237–47.
———. 2005. "(Un/Be)Coming Out? Rethinking Fat Politics". *Social Semiotics* 15 (2): 153–63.
———. 2008. "Normative Imperatives Vs Pathological Bodies". *Australian Feminist Studies* 23 (56): 213–24.
Musser, Amber Jamilla. 2016. "Queering the Pinup: History, Femes, and Brooklyn". *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies* 22 (1): 55–80. doi:10.1215/10642684-3315229.
Nash, Meredith, and Ruby Grant. 2015. "Twenty-Something Girls v. Thirty-Something Sex and the City Women". *Feminist Media Studies*, 15(6): 976–91.
Negrin, Llewellyn. 2008. *Appearance and Identity*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.
Nestle, Joan. 1992. "Flamboyance and Fortitude: An Introduction". In *The Persistent Desire: A Femme-Butch Reader*, edited by Joan Nestle, 13–20. Boston: Alyson Publications.
———. 2011. "Foreward!" In *Persistence: All Ways Butch and Femme*, edited by Ivan E. Coyote and Zena Sharman, 9–21. Vancouver: Arsenal Pulp Press.
Newman, Leslea. 1995. *The Femme Mystique*. Boston: Alyson Publications.
Newton, Esther. 1972. *Mother Camp: Female Impersonators in America*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
Onick, Marnina, Emma Renold, Jessica Ringrose, and Lisa G. Weems. 2009. "Rethinking Agency and Resistance What Comes after Girl Power?" *Girlhood Studies* 2 (2): 1–9.
Orenstein, Peggy. 2011. *Cinderella Ate My Daughter: Dispatches from the Front Lines of the New Girlie-Girl Culture*. New York: Harper Collins.
Orr, Catherine M. 1997. "Charting the Currents of the Third Wave". *Hypatia* 12 (3): 29–45. doi:10.2307/3810221.
Paoletti, Jo B. 2015. *Sex and Unisex: Fashion, Feminism, and the Sexual Revolution*. Bloomington; Indianapolis: Indiana University Press.
Patrick, Adele. 1997. "These Boots Aren't Made for Walking Style, Fetishism and the 'Will to Adorn'". *Variant* (5). www.variant.org.uk/5texts/Adele_Patrick.html.
Payne, Katherine. 2002. "Whores and Bitches Who Sleep with Women". In *Brazen Femme: Queering Femininity*, edited by Chloe Brushwood Rose and Anna Camilleri, 2010 ed., 47–56. Vancouver: Arsenal Pulp Press.
Penny, Laurie. 2014. *Unspeakable Things: Sex Lies and Revolution*. London: Bloomsbury.
Pickering, Michael. 2008. "Experience and the Social World". In *Research Methods for Cultural Studies*, edited by Michael Pickering, 17–31. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press.
Piepzna-Samarasinha, Leah Lakshmi. 2011. "Femme Shark Manifesto!" In *Persistence: All Ways Butch and Femme*, edited by Ivan E. Coyote and Zena Sharman, 286–91. Vancouver: Arsenal Pulp Press.

Pilcher, Jane, and Imelda Whelehan. 2017. *Fifty Key Concepts in Gender Studies*. Edited by Jane Pilcher and Imelda Whelehan. 2nd ed. London: Sage Publications.

"Pinkstinks". 2015. www.pinkstinks.co.uk/.

Poehler, Amy. 2014. *Yes Please*. New York: Harper Collins.

Power, Nina. 2009. *One Dimensional Woman*. Winchester; Washington: O Books.

Press, Andrea L. 2011. " 'Feminism? That's So Seventies': Girls and Young Women Discuss Femininity and Feminism in America's Next Top Model". In *New Femininities: Postfeminism, Neoliberalism, and Subjectivity*, edited by C. Scharff and R. Gill, 117–33. Houndmills, Basingstoke, Hampshire: Palgrave Macmillan.

Probyn, Elspeth. 1995. "Lesbians in Space. Gender, Sex and the Structure of Missing". *Gender, Place & Culture* 2 (1): 77–84.

Prosser, Jay. 1998. *Second Skins: The Body Narratives of Transsexuality*. New York: Columbia University Press.

Puar, Jasbir. 2007. *Terrorist Assemblages: Homonationalism in Queer Times*. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

———. 2011. "The Cost of Getting Better: Suicide, Sensation, Switchpoints". *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies* 18 (1): 149–58.

Radner, Hilary. 2011. "Legally Blonde (2001): 'A Pink Girl in a Brown World!'" In *Neo-Feminist Cinema: Girly Films, Chick Flicks and Consumer Culture*, edited by Hilary Radner, 62–81. New York: Routledge.

Redden, Guy, and Rebecca Brown. 2010. "From Bingeing Booze Bird to Gilded Cage: Teaching Girls Gender and Class on Ladette to Lady". *Critical Studies in Education* 51 (3, SI): 237–49.

Rednour, Shar. 2000. *The Femme's Guide to the Universe*. Los Angeles; London: Alyson Publications.

Renegar, Valerie R., and Stacey K. Sowards. 2009. "Contradiction as Agency: Self-Determination, Transcendence, and Counter-Imagination in Third Wave Feminism". *Hypatia* 24 (2): 1–20.

Renold, Emma, and Jessica Ringrose. 2008. "Regulation and Rupture: Mapping Tween and Teenage Girls' Resistance to the Heterosexual Matrix". *Feminist Theory* 9 (3): 313–38.

Ringrose, Jessica, and Valerie Walkerdine. 2008. "Regulating the Abject: The TV Make-Over as Site of Neoliberal Reinvention toward Bourgeois Femininity", *Feminist Media Studies* 9 (3): 37–41.

Riviere, Joan. 1929. "Womanliness as a Masquerade". *The International Journal of Psychoanalysis* 10: 303–13.

Robertson, Pamela. 1996. *Guilty Pleasures: Feminist Camp from Mae West to Madonna*. Durham: Duke University Press.

Rosario, Margaret, Eric W. Schrimshaw, Joyce Hunter, and Anna Levy-Warren. 2009. "The Coming-Out Process of Young Lesbian and Bisexual Women: Are There Butch/Femme Differences in Sexual Identity Development?" *Archives of Sexual Behavior* 38 (1): 34–49. doi:10.1007/s10508-007-9221-0.

Rubin, Gayle. 1984. "Thinking Sex: Notes for a Radical Theory of the Politics of Sexuality". In *Pleasure and Danger: Exploring Female Sexuality*, edited by Carole S. Vance, 1992 ed., 267–319. Boston; London; Melbourne; Henley: Routledge & Kegan Paul.

Rugg, Rebecca Ann. 1997. "How Does She Look?" In *Femme: Feminists, Lesbians, and Bad Girls*, edited by Laura Harris and Elizabeth Crocker, 175–89. New York; London: Routledge.

Russell, Rachel, and Melissa Tyler. 2002. "Thank Heaven for Little Girls: 'Girl Heaven' and the Commercial Context of Feminine Childhood". *Sociology* 36 (3): 619–37.

Saguy, Abigail. 2012. "Why Fat Is a Feminist Issue". *Sex Roles* 66 (9–10): 600–7.
Schacht, Steven P. 2000. "Gay Masculinities in a Drag Community: Female Impersonators and the Social Construction of 'other'". In *Gay Masculinities*, edited by P. Nardi, 247–68. Newbury Park, California: Sage Publications.
Scharff, Christina. 2013. "Femininities". In *Gender: The Key Concepts*, edited by Mary Evans and Carolyn H. Williams, 59–64. London; New York: Routledge.
Scharff, Christina, and Rosalind Gill. 2011. "Introduction". In *New Femininities: Postfeminism, Neoliberalism, and Subjectivity*, 1–17. Houndmills, Basingstoke, Hampshire: Palgrave Macmillan.
Schippers, Mimi. 2007. "Recovering the Feminine Other: Masculinity, Femininity, and Gender Hegemony". *Theory and Society* 36 (1): 85–102.
Sedgwick, Eve Kosofsky. 1990. *Epistemology of the Closet*. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press.
———. 1993. *Tendencies*. Durham: Duke University Press.
———. 1997. "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading: Or, You're So Paranoid, You Probably Think This Introduction Is about You". In *Novel Gazing: Queer Readings in Fiction*, edited by Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, 1–37. Durham: Duke University Press.
Seidman, Steven. 1997. *Difference Troubles: Queering Social Theory and Sexual Politics*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
Seigworth, Gregory, and Melissa Gregg. 2010. "An Inventory of Shimmers". In *The Affect Theory Reader*, edited by Melissa Gregg and Gregory Seigworth, 1–25. Durham; London: Duke University Press.
Serano, Julia. 2007. *Whipping Girl: Transsexual Woman on Sexism and the Scapegoating of Femininity*. Emeryville, CA: Seal Press.
Shildrick, Margrit. 2015. "'Why Should Our Bodies End at the Skin?': Embodiment, Boundaries, and Somatechnics". *Hypatia* 30 (1): 13–29.
Siegel, Deborah. 2007. *Sisterhood Interrupted: From Radical Women to Grrls Gone Wild*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.
Silverman, Kaja. 1986. "Fragments of a Fashionable Discourse". In *Studies in Entertainment: Critical Approaches to Mass Culture*, edited by Tania Modleski, 139–52. Bloomington; Indianapolis: Indiana University Press.
Skeggs, Beverley. 1997. *Formations of Class & Gender: Becoming Respectable*. London; California; New Delhi: Sage Publications.
———. 2001. "The Toilet Paper: Femininity, Class and Mis-Recognition". *Women's Studies International Forum* 24 (3–4): 295–307.
———. 2004. "Context and Background: Pierre Bourdieu's Analysis of Class, Gender and Sexuality". *The Sociological Review* 52 (2): 19–33.
Smith, Angela. 2011. "Femininity Repackaged: Post Feminism and 'Ladette to Lady'". In *Women on Screen: Feminism and Femininity in a Visual Culture*, edited by Melanie Waters, 153–66. Basingstoke; New York: Palgrave Macmillan.
Smith, Dorothy E. 1988. "Femininity as Discourse". In *Becoming Feminine: The Politics of Popular Culture*, edited by Leslie G. Roman, Linda K. Christian-Smith, and Elizabeth Ellsworth, 37–59. London; New York; Philadelphia: The Falmer Press.
Snyder, R. Claire. 2008. "What Is Third-Wave Feminism? A New Directions Essay". *Signs* 34 (1): 175–96.
Snyder-Hall, R. Claire. 2010. "Third-Wave Feminism and the Defense of 'Choice'". *Perspectives on Politics* 8 (1): 255.
Sontag, Susan. 1982. "Notes on 'Camp'". In *A Susan Sontag Reader*, introduction by Elizabeth Hardwick, 105–19. Middlesex, England: Penguin Books.

Stardust, Zahra. 2015. "Critical Femininities, Fluid Sexualities and Queer Temporalities: Erotic Performers on Objectification, Femmephobia, and Oppression". In *Queer Sex Work*, edited by Mary Laing, Katy Plicher, and Nicola Smith, 67–78. New York: Routledge.

Stets, Jan E., and Peter J. Burke. 2000. "Femininity/Masculinity". In *Encyclopedia of Sociology, Revised Edition*, edited by Edgar F. Borgatta and Rhonda J. V. Montgomery, 997–1005. New York: Macmillan.

Stewart, Kathleen. 2007. *Ordinary Affects*. Durham: Duke University Press.

Sullivan, Nikki. 2009. "The Somatechnics of Bodily Inscription: Tattooing". *Studies in Gender and Sexuality* 10 (3): 129–41.

Tally, Margaret. 2008. "Representations of Girls and Young Women in Film as an Entry Point to Studying Girl Culture". In *Girl Culture*, edited by Claudia A. Mitchell and Jacqueline Reid-Walsh, 107–15. Westport, CT: Greenwood Publishing Group.

Tasker, Yvonne, and Diane Negra. 2006. "Postfeminism and the Archive for the Future". *Camera Obscura: Feminism, Culture, and Media Studies* 21 (262): 170–6.

Taylor, Anthea. 2013. "Germaine Greer's Adaptable Celebrity". *Feminist Media Studies* 14 (5): 759–74.

Taylor, Verta, and Leila J. Rupp. 2004. "Chicks with Dicks, Men in Dresses". *Journal of Homosexuality* 46 (3–4): 113–33.

Thesander, Marianne. 1997. *The Feminine Ideal*. London: Reaktion Books.

Thrift, Nigel. 2008. *Non-Representational Theory: Space, Politics, Affect*. Oxon: Routledge.

———. 2010. "Understanding the Material Practices of Glamour". In *The Affect Theory Reader*, edited by Melissa Gregg and Gregory J. Seigworth. Durham; London: Duke University Press.

Tweedy, Ann. 2009. "Subverting Normalcy: Living a Femme Identity". In *Visible: A Femmethology*. Volume 1, edited by Jennifer Clare Burke, 66–9. Michigan: Homofactus Press.

Valenti, Jessica. 2008. *He's a Stud, She's a Slut: And 49 Other Double Standards Every Woman Should Know*. Berkeley, CA: Seal Press.

———. 2010. *The Purity Myth: How America's Obsession with Virginity Is Hurting Young Women*. Berkeley, CA: Seal Press.

———. 2014. *Full Frontal Feminism: A Young Woman's Guide to Why Feminism Matters*. Berkeley, CA: Seal Press.

Valentine, Gill. 1993. "Negotiating and Managing Multiple Sexual Identitities: Lesbian Time-Space Strategies". *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers* 18 (2): 237–48.

Vint, Sherryl. 2007. "The New Backlash: Popular Culture's 'Marriage' with Feminism, or Love Is All You Need". *Journal of Popular Film and Television* 34 (4): 160–9.

Walker, Ja'Nina J., Sarita Golub, David S. Bimbi, and Jeffrey T. Parsons. 2012. "Butch Bottom-Femme Top? An Exploration of Lesbian Stereotypes". *Journal of Lesbian Studies* 16 (1): 90–107. doi:10.1080/10894160.2011.557646.

Walker, Lisa M. 1993. "How to Recognize a Lesbian: The Cultural Politics of Looking Like What You Are". *Signs* 18 (4): 866–90.

———. 2012. "The Future of Femme: Notes on Femininity, Aging and Gender Theory". *Sexualities* 15 (7): 795–814.

Walter, Natasha. 1999. *The New Feminism*. London: Virago Press.

———. 2000. "Introduction". In *On the Move: Feminism for a New Generation*, edited by Natasha Walter, 1–4. London: Virago Press.

———. 2010. *Living Dolls: The Return of Sexism*. London: Virago Press.

Ward, Jane. 2009. "Butch/Femme". In *Encyclopedia of Gender and Society*, edited by Jodi O'Brien, 100–3. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications.

Warner, Michael. 1991. "Introduction: Fear of a Queer Planet". *Social Text* 29: 3–17.

Watson, Amanda D., and Corinne L. Mason. 2015. "Mapping the SlutWalk Paradox: Challenges and Possibilities of Using Raunch in Transnational Feminist Politics". In *This Is What a Feminist Slut Looks Like: Perspectives on the SlutWalk Movement*, edited by Alyssa Teekah, Erika Jane Scholz, May Friedman and Andrea O'Reilly, 133–153 Bradford: Demeter Press.

White, Rosie. 2012. "Women Are Angry! Lizzie and Sarah as Feminist Critique". *Feminist Media Studies* April (January): 1–12.

Whitehead, Kally, and Tim Kurz. 2009. "'Empowerment' and the Pole: A Discursive Investigation of the Reinvention of Pole Dancing as a Recreational Activity". *Feminism & Psychology* 19 (2): 224–44.

Wiegman, Robyn. 2002. "Academic Feminism against Itself". *NWSA Journal* 14 (2): 18–34.

———. 2006. "Interchanges: Heteronormativity and the Desire for Gender". *Feminist Theory* 7 (1): 89–103.

Wiegman, Robyn, and Elizabeth A. Wilson. 2015. "Introduction: Antinormativity's Queer Conventions". *Differences: A Journal of Feminist Cultural Studies* 26 (1): 1–25.

Wilson, Elizabeth. 1985. *Adorned in Dreams: Fashion and Modernity*. 2003 ed. New Jersey: Rutgers University Press.

———. 2001. *The Contradictions of Culture: Cities: Culture: Women*. London; Thousand Oaks; New Dehli: Sage Publications.

———. 2013. *Cultural Passions: Fans, Asthetes and Tarot Reader*. London; New York: I.B. Tauris.

Wise, J. Macgregor. 2005. "Assemblage". In *Gilles Deleuze: Key Concepts*, edited by Charles J. Stivale, 77–87. Chesham: Acumen.

Wolf, Naomi. 1990. *The Beauty Myth: How Images of Beauty Are Used against Women*. 1991 ed. London: Vintage.

Wollstonecraft, Mary. 2003. *A Vindication of the Rights of Men and a Vindication of the Rights of Women*. Edited by Sylvana Tomaselli. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Wood, Rachel. 2013. "'You Do Act Differently When You're in It': Lingerie and Femininity". *Journal of Gender Studies*, 25(1): 10–23.

Zeisler, Andi. 2016. *We Were Feminists Once: From Riot Grrrl to Covergirl, the Buying and Selling of a Political Movement*. New York: The Perseus Books Group.

Zipkin, Dvora. 1999. "The Myth of the Short-Haired Lesbian". *Journal of Lesbian Studies* 3 (4): 91–101.



Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group
http://taylorandfrancis.com

Index

affect: as assemblage 67–8, 120–7, 130, 140, 143; ordinary affects 69, 75, 126
affect theory 8–9, 65, 78–9, 118–20, 133, 137
agency: in femme discourse 103, 108–10, 115; limits of 27–8, 36, 41, 53; rethinking 68, 74, 120, 126
Ahmed, Sara 3, 40–1, 68, 129

Badiou, Alain 51–3
Bartky, Sandra 24–6, 42, 53
Berlant, Lauren 73–6, 132–3, 145
bisexuality 54, 98, 104, 109, 132
bondage and sadomasochism 71
Bordo, Susan 25, 28
Bourdieu, Pierre 60
breasts: fake 48–50; flashing of 54, 78; humour 67–71, 79; symbolic 34, 44
Brownmiller, Susan 24–5, 35
Butler, Judith 5, 9, 11, 13, 95, 113–14, 119–20, 129
butch/femme 84–8, 103, 115, 131, 137

'Calamity Jane' 33–4
camp 82–3, 111
capitalism 5–6, 14, 36, 43, 46–7, 56–8, 144
celebrity 28, 32, 56, 59, 73, 82
childhood; development 2; gender norms 9, 43–5, 47, 53, 59; queer 8
Civil Rights Movement 21
class: classism 60–1, 76, 99; femme as working class 84, 88, 95; hypersexualisation 28, 31–4, 43
compulsory heterosexuality 6, 129–130
Connell, Raewyn 2, 20, 26, 37
cruel optimism 73–76, 133

Dahl, Ulrika 57, 82, 86, 88–90, 92, 99, 104, 113, 133
Day, Doris 33
De Beauvoir, Simone 9, 22
Deleuze, Gilles 120
Dietrich, Marlene 27
docile bodies 25
drag 82–3, 93, 98, 111, 122, 127
Driscoll, Catherine 47

false-consciousness: critique of 72, 78; fashion and beauty 2, 26, 28; postfeminist 51, 53, 55, 61
fashion: communicating identity 90–1, 93, 111; enjoyment 76–9, 124; industry 6, 56; feminist critique 22, 24–6, 45, 47; sociology of 34–7
fat politics 94–5, 133
Feinberg, Leslie 85, 104
femininity: able-bodied as norm 30; alternative 4, 20, 35; ageing 47, 130, 136; doll-like 44–45, 48, 53, 59; hegemonic 3, 9, 18; illness/death 14, 25, 62, 122–3, 139; as masquerade 25–8, 35, 51, 82, 110–11, 122, 124, 134, 139; normative 4–6, 9, 14, 21, 26, 33, 47, 66, 78, 88, 90, 96, 115, 130; and race 100, 133; as subordinate 19–20, 83; and weakness 6, 13, 25
feminist killjoy 40–1, 45, 68, 139
femmephobia 89
film 1, 30, 33–4, 86
Foucault, Michel 24–5, 105, 114
Fraser, Nancy 100, 114
Freeman, Elizabeth 29, 93
Freud, Sigmund 3, 21, 26
Friedan, Betty 21, 24, 25, 85

Gaga feminism 71–3, 78
Gay, Roxane 63
gender scripts 4
girl power 29, 64
girlhood 2, 42, 47, 59
'Girls Gone Wild' 48, 54, 72
glamour 1, 27, 49, 130
Greer, Germaine 1, 4, 26, 60

hair: body 48; feminist 22; and femininity 24; femme 10, 86, 89, 96, 121, 124–6; signifying queerness 9, 94–5, 97, 128, 134, 144
Halberstam, J. Jack 3–5, 19, 70–3, 78, 82–3, 88–9, 127, 130, 144
Hemmings, Clare 21, 39, 132
homonormativity 141
homophobia 89
hypervisibility 92

intersectionality 86, 92, 95, 123, 130, 133, 143

Jeffreys, Sheila 26

Lady Gaga 73, 82, 125, 136–7
lesbian: desire 56, 114–15; expected appearance 9, 83; fake 56, 70, 72; feminism 85–7, 97; lipstick lesbian 10, 87, 96–7; subculture 84–6, 97
Levy, Ariel 10, 25, 42–8, 51, 54–5, 58–61, 69, 71–2, 77–8
lingerie 22–3, 44, 48, 67–71, 135
lipstick 26, 110, 121, 128–9, 135
Love, Heather 7–8

Madonna 82
make-up 45, 89, 90
male gaze 25, 47, 49, 54, 56–7, 70–2, 107
masculinity: alternative 83, 111; female 3, 5, 19, 83, 85; hegemonic 18, 20, 56; studies 17–20; subordinate 37, 83
McRobbie, Angela 14, 30, 41–3, 46–51, 55–8, 60–1, 78
Miss America protest 22–5, 37, 44
Moran, Caitlin 64–5, 67–9, 70–3, 76–7
Morgan, Robin 21
Muñoz, José Esteban 76–7, 133–4

Narcissism 25, 33, 47, 71
neoliberalism 3, 6, 19, 28, 30, 43, 58, 114
Nestle, Joan 84–7, 103, 105, 114

Orientalism 98

Parton, Dolly 82
patriarchy theory 7, 19–20, 47, 56
performativity 5, 109, 114, 120
Perry, Katy 56–7
personal is political 18, 23, 37
pink, significance of colour 2–3, 30, 44–5, 53, 63
Pinkstinks 45
'Playboy' 32, 42, 44, 59
pornography 41–2, 49, 58–9, 76–7, 84
postfeminism: and choice 51; and femininity 18, 33, 48, 82; feminism lost 12, 17, 39, 46, 50; and neoliberalism 19; third wave as 28–31, 57
Power, Nina 43, 46–9, 51–2, 56, 58–9, 66, 76–7
princesses 45
Puar, Jasbir 14, 120–2

'queer enough' anxiety 100, 111, 142, 144
queer failure 70–3, 126–33, 144

radical feminism 9, 23, 26, 84, 103
raunch culture 32, 42, 44, 48, 50–1, 54, 58–60
Rubin, Gayle 84, 141

'second wave' feminism 19–23, 37, 51
Serano, Julia 5, 14–15, 20
sex education 51
sex work 73, 77–8, 135
sex/gender distinction 89, 129
sex-desire 114–115
Siegel, Deborah 23
SlutWalk 42

'The L Word' 88
'third wave' feminism 28–31, 51, 57–8, 64–5
transgender identity 20, 51, 92, 98, 111, 114, 127–8, 134–5

utopia 36, 65–6, 73–7, 118, 133–6, 145

Valenti, Jessica 43, 47, 65–7, 69–70, 72–6
'veil' debate, the 2–3, 26, 31, 53, 77, 121
vintage 58, 92, 99

Walter, Natasha 43–6, 49, 52–3, 55, 59, 77
Whiteness 4, 32, 46–8, 60, 70, 78, 99
Wolf, Naomi 24
West, Mae 82